

STEADFAST

M E N

The way of Godly Men



Wes Hart

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walksteadfast.com

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Published by Steadfast Men
walksteadfast.com

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ISBN: TBD (ebook)

ISBN: TBD (paperback)

First edition, 2026

A note on the four marks

The four principles behind these marks owe a debt to Robert Lewis's teaching on manhood (*Raising a Modern-Day Knight*, 1997). Steadfast Men is independent and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Robert Lewis, Men's Fraternity, or Authentic Manhood.

Disclaimer

This book offers general encouragement and a biblical look at a man's life. It is not a substitute for professional counseling, medical care, legal advice, or the care of a local church. If you are in crisis, in danger, or in a situation that needs a professional, get that help without delay. The men and stories in this book are composites. Names, places, and details have been changed or combined so that no household can be picked out. The author's own wife, children, wedding, and baptism are real.

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DEDICATION

For the men who pulled a chair out for me before I had anything worth setting on the table, and who left that chair open long after they stopped needing me in the room.

For my wife, who has watched me try to become the man in these pages and has never once pretended I had already arrived. The true sentences here were lived where she could see them. She is the reason most of them hold.

And for our children, who are still watching. I hope you find your father in this book, and I hope you find him further along than he was when you were small.

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Every chapter ends the same way. Name it. Do this week. Tell a brother. Carry this.

Introduction

If you added up the hours of my grown life that mattered, a lot of them would turn out to have happened at tables. A kitchen table nobody wiped after supper. A folding table in the back of a church hall. The cab of a pickup in a dark lot, engine ticking as it cooled. A diner counter where the waitress pours before you ask because she knows which stool is yours. The men around those tables with me have been nineteen and they've been seventy. They've driven trucks and run companies. And under all of it, they kept circling the same three questions. What is a man? Am I one? If I'm not, is it too late?

This book is my long answer, the one I give after the coffee's gone cold and the man hasn't left yet. It isn't the only answer you'll find. It's the one I've watched hold up in plain houses over a lot of years, and I've written it the way I'd talk if you pulled up a chair.

What this book claims

At the center of these pages is one sentence. I didn't discover what's in it. Every piece is older than all of us, and it's been sitting in plain view in the Bible the whole time. My work has been putting it into words a tired man can carry to his job on a Tuesday. I've tested it against my own life for a long time, and against men in every season you can name, and I haven't found the spot where it gives way.

A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

That's the four marks. Early in the book we'll lay them out, and then take them one at a time: Stop Waiting, Pick Up the Weight, Go First, and Work for God's Pay.

Notice what kind of sentence it is. It doesn't describe what a man feels. Plenty of good books start inside a man's chest, with longing and wild country, and a few of them helped me when I was young. I'm not arguing with them. I'm making a plainer claim. The four marks are things you do on ordinary days, and people can see them. They show on a man the way thirty years of work shows on his hands. You can see them when they're there and you can see when they're missing, and no amount of feeling hides either one.

One word on that last mark, so nobody misreads it. God's pay isn't a wage, and you can't work your way into His family. It's the inheritance a Father gives to sons. He already calls His own. We'll spend real time there later in the book.

Who's in the room

Every season is already sitting at this table. Find your chair.

You might be single and still waiting for somebody to say out loud that you're a man. You might be newly married, or buried so deep in the baby years that nobody in your house has slept a full night since March. You might be providing everything except yourself. You might be divorced and still a father, every other weekend on the calendar and every day in your head. The kids might be gone and the house too quiet. You might be retired and unsure what a man does with a morning nobody scheduled. You might be standing in a kitchen where her coffee cup is still upside down in the drainer. You're not a footnote here. You're who this is for.

I'm not only writing to the man with the mortgage and the minivan. When the counsel needs to bend toward your season, I'll turn and say so right there in the paragraph. I won't stop every chapter to take roll. Near the end of the book, we'll sit with each season on purpose. Until then, trust that I see you.

And if the house is loud and the page count looks impossible, here's a shorter road. Read the opening chapter, and work the closer at the end of each chapter you read, one a week. Then read the one near the end that walks through a man's seasons, one chapter from the house that fits where you sit, and one about your kids if you have them. Come back for the rest when life gives you room. The book will wait.

How it's put together

We start with an ordinary day, because that's where a man's life actually gets settled. An ordinary Tuesday names the problem. Next we tell the truth about the confusing room you're standing in, and then we put the four marks in your hands until you can say them without looking down.

After that we go back to what you inherited and what's still yours to answer for. The empty chair at the table you grew up around. The anger, the itch, and the drift. The Father who doesn't leave. The handoff you may never have gotten from home. Leaving home without slamming the door. Brothers. Asking an older man for help. The trouble inside you that would still be there if your dad had been perfect. Then further back, to the first pages of the human story, so you can quit living as if you

were the first man to try this. Then the house: a wife if there is one, and a life with real purpose if there isn't. The marriage bed. A daughter. A son. And then the long road: work, feelings, seasons, the years nobody claps for, a page you write in your own hand, and the men who stay.

Tuesday runs underneath all of it. Not the altar call or the retreat weekend. The day with nothing on the calendar, when nobody's watching. Somewhere in every chapter there's a picture about that size. That's on purpose.

The four lines at the end

Each chapter closes with the same four short lines. I'll explain them here once.

The first line, Name it, asks you to say, out loud and in your own words, what the chapter touched in you. Men are good at nodding and bad at saying "that's me." Nothing moves in a man until he says it.

The second line, Do this week, gives you one thing to do before next Tuesday. Only one. If that's all you take from each chapter, you'll have done more with this book than most men do with any book.

The third line, Tell a brother, asks you to say it to another man. A mark you keep to yourself never sets. If you don't have that man yet, there's help for that further on in the book. Until you get there, telling a brother can mean writing it where you'll see it and telling God, who has heard worse.

The fourth line, Carry this, gives you one sentence for the week. The kind of line you could text a friend without feeling like you're preaching at him.

I know how a worn-out man reads a book like this, so one more thing. At some point you'll reach a chapter without having done the last one's thing. When that happens, don't skip ahead in shame and don't quit. Tell your brother you didn't do it. That counts as the third line. Then do it this week. Every man in these pages has missed a week. The ones who changed are the ones who said so and went again.

The men you'll meet

You'll meet men here by name. Roy, who turned in a state trooper's badge. Tomás, whose baby will not sleep. Kenny, divorced, who calls his son every Tuesday. Micah, who sat at the single men's table at weddings for six years. Anthony in a doorway. Walt, whose shop got bigger than his house. Others too. They're composites, built from real conversations with real men, with the names and details mixed so nobody can be picked out, and so you might find yourself in them without

finding your neighbor.

Before you start

This book can stand by itself. Read it, do one thing a week, and find one other man to do it with. That's enough for a man to change.

If there's no other man yet, don't wait for him to start. Write it down. Tell God. Your brother can catch up when he shows up.

We also built a twenty-four-session training on the same backbone: videos, printable guides, and a class that a church, a small group, or one man on his own can run. There's a short map of those sessions in the back of this book, and the full guide is at walksteadfast.com. The book is the book and the training is the training. Use either. Use both. Just don't binge four chapters on a Saturday and call it done.

Get your coffee and pull up a chair. Let me tell you about a Tuesday.

PART ONE

The Man You Were Built to Be



CHAPTER 1

A Quiet Tuesday

Roy's alarm goes off at 5:30. He's seventy-two. For thirty-one years that alarm meant a pressed uniform and a state trooper's badge, and now there's nothing to pin on and nowhere he has to be. If he rolled over and slept till nine, not one person in the county would notice. So the question sitting in the dark with him is bigger than it looks: will these last years be a slow walk to the exit, or the most useful stretch of his whole life? He gets up. He makes the coffee. Hang on to that. It'll matter later.

Walt is fifty-five. He built his company from one truck to eleven. Every evening around 6:15 there's a fork in the road. Lock up and go cook supper, or give it one more hour because the shop is quieter than the house. For twenty years he took the hour. He never decided it in a meeting, never out loud. An hour here, an hour there, and the staying made the decision for him.

Tomás is twenty-nine, with a baby who won't sleep. At two in the morning the crying starts, then he feels the mattress shift as his wife begins to get up, and every tired cell in him votes for lying still. That two o'clock is his marriage, more than any trip they're saving for.

Eli is nineteen and single. He runs the counter at a parts store and shares an apartment with two roommates. Around ten the place goes quiet and his phone lights up his face. He told me once it felt like he was still waiting for life to start. His real life is the ten o'clock.

None of those four would call that hour a decision. Every one of them is making one.

Where men get made

I used to think the loud days were the ones that counted. Catch me at twenty-five and I'd have listed them: my wedding, the morning our first child arrived, a couple of funerals, the Saturday a pastor lowered me into a river and I came up sure. I've

had all of those now. They sit in my memory like mile markers, and I can point at each one.

They didn't build me, though. What built me was the long gray stretch between them, days so alike I couldn't sort them for a hundred dollars.

So here's the claim this book stands on. A man's life is decided on Tuesdays. Not Sunday, when he knows where to stand and what to sing. Not the Saturday he takes his kid fishing and gets to feel like a dad all afternoon. Tuesday. Nothing on the calendar. Nobody keeping notes. He gets home spent, the house is already loud, and somewhere before bed there's a sentence he'll say or swallow, a call he'll return or let go cold, a dead porch bulb he'll swap tonight or leave for next week. That's the stuff.

Markers aren't miles

I've quit expecting the big days to do the building. A big day is a mile marker. You see it coming, you might pull over and take a picture, and it tells you how far you've come. God made us to need those, and before this book is done I'll ask you to give your son one. But a marker never moved a truck one foot. The miles did that, and nobody takes a picture of a mile. What actually marks a man is the thing he does a few thousand times, the way a callus comes from mornings nobody photographed.

Plenty of us have driven home from a men's conference ready to change the world and been back in the recliner within two weeks. I know that chair well. We stopped to admire the marker and never drove the miles.

Big days have one more problem. Everyone's watching. Weddings and baptisms and gravesides come with a script, and most of us can hit our marks with an audience. The truer test is the empty room, where nobody would ever find out whether a man made the call, kept the drawer shut, told the small truth. Tuesday has no audience. That's precisely why it counts.

Anthony, 8:40 p.m.

Picture a man in a recliner at 8:40 on a Tuesday night in October. Game on, phone in his hand. His wife is alone in the kitchen. I'll call him Anthony. Here's how he got to that chair.

The evening before, she'd made a remark about money that wasn't quite fair. He said nothing back. So it came along at 6:10 the next morning, after a lousy night's sleep, riding in the cab like a passenger.

At work a customer had been promised his truck by noon. The parts ticket was

still lying on Anthony's bench where he'd set it down the day before, fully intending to phone it in. No call, so no fuel pump. All morning he stalled, and two bays over the shop lead heard every bit of it and kept quiet. Lunch was forty minutes in the cab scrolling. An hour later he couldn't have told you one thing he'd seen.

Around three, his dad's name came up on the screen. That happens maybe twice a year, and every time, Anthony is nine years old. He watched it ring out. Later, he thought.

He finished the job, rode home in silence, parked, and then stood in the kitchen doorway a while, like most evenings, before he went in. A kiss to the side of her head without meeting her eyes. Supper. Kids down. Recliner.

Count the choices. Swallowing the reply. The unordered part. The missed call. The doorway. The kiss. The chair while she stood at the sink. He'd tell you he didn't decide anything that day. It just felt like Tuesday. Pile up ten thousand of those and a man becomes a very particular somebody without ever casting a vote.

He's not a bad man, and I want to be clear about that. He works hard, pays the bills, comes home, is gentle more often than not. He wasn't trying to hurt anyone. He's also turning into something, a forgettable day at a time, and his wife could describe exactly what. She has a front-row seat.

Very little

People who've been in church a while tend to file the spiritual life under altars and retreat weekends. God absolutely meets men there. But listen to where Jesus puts the weight.

Luke 16:10 NIV

Whoever can be trusted with very little can also be trusted with much, and whoever is dishonest with very little will also be dishonest with much.

"Very little" sounds a lot like Tuesday. A voicemail. A recliner. A kiss aimed at the side of a head. Jesus says that's where trust gets built or lost, long before anything big is on the line. The quiet stuff is the workbench. The man who'll hold steady in some hard room ten years from now is getting made there, or he isn't.

Jesus tells a story about two houses, too. Notice what made the difference.

Matthew 7:24 NIV

Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock.

Practice. Something you do so many times it stops being an effort and turns into who you are. That builder poured his footing on days when nobody pulled over to admire it. When the storm came, those boring days held the house up.

Most of following Jesus happens on a Tuesday. So does most of marriage and most of fathering, and if you're single, most of your friendships and your work and whatever you do with a quiet apartment. Go to the retreat. It won't do Tuesday's work for you. Want to know where you're headed? Look at last Tuesday.

Twelve months on

Let me show you Anthony once more, a year later. This isn't a before-and-after ad. It's just proof that a man has more say over a plain day than he thinks.

Same 6:10 start. Another rough night. Driving in, he talked to God out loud: "Father, I don't want to drag this around all day." At a gas station he stopped and texted her. He was sorry he'd gone silent. Could they grab ten minutes once the kids were in bed? It took ninety seconds. He was still tired, but he wasn't hauling it anymore.

The noon part was on the shelf, because he'd ordered it the afternoon before. Another job blew up anyway (they do), and he walked over and gave the shop lead the straight story, then phoned the customer before anyone had to watch him scramble. When his dad called, he felt nine again for a second, and answered. Six stiff minutes about almost nothing. It was the first call in two years he hadn't let die.

That night he caught himself stalling in the doorway and kept walking. Phone face down on the counter. He looked at her when he kissed her. After bedtime they took their ten minutes about the money, and when he felt the urge to win, he let it go. Dishes. A short, clumsy prayer, his palm resting between her shoulder blades. Sleep.

There's a seven-year-old in that house, and she watches her dad's face whenever her mom comes into the room. She couldn't name what changed. Something did, in maybe six places, each choice over in a few seconds. Multiply that by every Tuesday until she leaves home and she grows up with a different picture of what a husband looks like when his wife walks in.

That's really all this book is after. Find out what a man does on an ordinary day, and then do it again.

Where this goes

Before long you'll meet the four marks of a steadfast man, and most of what follows is about how they look on a Tuesday. First, though, something for anybody who's started to wonder whether what he's been told about manhood is thin, or at war with itself. You're not imagining it, and you're not crazy. That's where we go next.

Before you turn the page

Maybe you saw yourself in Roy or Walt, Tomás or Eli, or maybe you live somewhere between them. Either way, there's a Tuesday on your calendar, and it'll hand you a few moments where you'll choose without noticing you chose. I'm not asking you to become someone new by Sunday. I'm asking you to catch one of those moments and make one small, deliberate move inside it. Your Father sees it happen, and it gladdens Him. May He open your eyes to an ordinary day, and give you enough strength to walk on through the doorway rather than lingering there.

01 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

You can't change a day you've never really looked at. Replay your last plain weekday from alarm to pillow, and name two spots where you chose something without feeling like you chose.

DO THIS WEEK

Small things done again are what shape a man. Take one of those two spots and handle it differently next Tuesday. Pick up the call you'd usually let ring out. Leave the phone face down through supper. Sit at the counter for the ten minutes.

TELL A BROTHER

Nobody remembers a Tuesday nobody else heard about. Send one man a text: what you saw in your ordinary day, and what you'll try differently on the next.

CARRY THIS

A man's life is decided on Tuesdays. Watch what you do with the next one.



CHAPTER 2

You Are Not Crazy

Most men I know can't get a clear look at what a man is supposed to be, and it isn't because they're slow or don't care. Three things stand in the way. They've been handed too many instructions, and the instructions fight each other. Almost nobody older ever sat them down and drew them one clear picture. And somewhere along the way they decided the confusion was their own fault, so they quit asking out loud.

That's why so many good men feel lost inside a life that looks fine from the street. So here's what I want you to hear first. You're not crazy. The confusion is real, and much of it comes from outside you. The gap you feel is an actual gap.

Counting on his fingers

A man I'll call Garrett laid the whole thing out for me over breakfast at a diner. He's somewhere in the middle of his working years, good at his job, the kind of man people call when a project's on fire. A few minutes in, he pushed his plate to the side and barely touched it after that. Then he started counting on his fingers. Six different sets of instructions for being a man, gathered over a lifetime, and every one of them canceled the other five. He'd been trying to obey all six at once, as if they added up to one plan.

He wasn't angry. He was tired, the kind of tired that comes from chasing a target somebody keeps moving while somebody else keeps score. One voice had told him manhood was a costume he could take off. Another said it was the deepest thing in him. A third said he got to decide what it meant. A fourth said it had been decided long ago and he was flunking. Church had handled him as a problem to manage, the locker room as an appetite to feed. After enough years of that he'd started to wonder if the fog was out in the world or if he'd brought it in himself, folded up in his coat pocket.

I told him across that table what I just told you. He wasn't crazy. Neither are you.

What it does to a man

I knew every word Garrett said, because I've carried my own pile. Be strong. Wait, be gentle. Take the lead. Wait, step back. I was told the push inside me to build and lead was a threat, right up until the day I sat on it, and then I was told sitting on it was why home felt like a cold room. I knew the pile by heart. It never got me through one ordinary Wednesday.

Crossed instructions do a few things to a man, and I've got the bruises of each.

They lock him up. When somebody has condemned every direction, holding still feels like the only safe move. A lot of what we call passivity in men is exactly this freeze. I've been a man on a tailgate with the tools still zipped in the bag, telling myself a man that unsure had no business touching anything. It sounded humble. The bag never got unzipped.

They make him a performer. I know the costume changes. One face on Sunday, one at the job, one for the guys after work, one when he walks in his own door. Whoever woke up that morning keeps getting replaced by whoever the room seems to want. Nobody can do that all week and stay full. Under the costumes is a man who never got a picture solid enough to keep, so he borrows one from whoever's nearest.

And they leave him ashamed, and shame shuts a man's mouth. Hand him orders he can't keep, orders at war with each other, and he'll convict himself every time. A low hum starts up under everything. He won't mention it, sure that once it's said out loud the verdict is final. Garrett had the hum. So did I. Most of the men I know have it. It's the noise a decent man makes while trying to please six maps before the weekend.

Six maps

So where did all those instructions come from? Spread them out where you can see them. Once you see which ones were never real maps, you can stop following them.

The first came from home, from whoever sat at the head of the table. He taught you what a man is before you could read, and most of us got that lesson in fragments. Maybe he was there and silent. Maybe he'd already gone. Maybe he blew through the door like a storm front. Even faithful fathers left gaps. We'll walk into that room properly later in the book. For now, notice that you left home with a torn piece of map and went looking for the rest.

The culture was glad to supply it. That second map looked at the itch to build, compete, protect, and take charge, and called it outdated wiring. Then in the same breath it mocked guys who never grew up or committed or took on anything hard, and never admitted it had talked them out of all three.

The third map glowed on a screen. Be the sitcom dad lost in his own kitchen, or the brute some boys were taught to admire, or the loner hero of the movie every kid runs in his head. That hero has no worn-out wife, no father who phones twice a year, no teenager who stopped talking, no church, no friends, no sink full of dishes. His life has no street address. We were trained to want it while living in a real house with a real mortgage.

The fourth came from the job and said a man equals his paycheck. The fifth came from the phone and said he equals his feed, what he watches and who watches him.

The sixth came from church, and it tore down the middle. Some pulpits handed you “spiritual leader” and never said what it looks like on a Wednesday. Others cranked “warrior” and “king” so loud there was no room for a car note, a mother in the ICU, or the graveyard shift. Neither one told you what to do on Monday.

Six maps, and none of them agree where north is. One true picture was never in the box. You can haul all six. You can’t navigate by them. Each new heading wipes out the last, and the man who keeps trying gets dizzy and then decides the dizziness is his own fault.

The same bruise at every age

Where you are in life changes where it hurts. The bruise is the same.

At nineteen, school calls your restlessness a disorder, your phone says manhood is followers, youth group says servant leader, and older guys say it’s how many girls. You try the whole menu, crash, and blame yourself. Blame the maps.

Single at thirty, you hear without anyone saying it that you’re on pause until a wedding makes you a man. You aren’t. This life already counts, and it’s already yours to steer.

As a new dad, inside one week you’re told to earn more and be home more, to lead and to defer, to be a rock for the baby and stay in touch with your feelings. It won’t fit in the calendar because it was never built to.

In the middle years, plenty of men quietly quit. Manhood shrinks to the job and the drive home, and they tune out every voice since the voices cancel anyway. It

passes for peace. It's a man who folded the maps and sat on them. Some of those men run whole companies and still couldn't give their own son one sentence about what a man is. A title is not a definition.

Later on, a man looks at the picture he was handed fifty years ago while his grandkids scroll past videos mocking it, and he wonders if he built on sand. Some of what he got was true and some wasn't. The true parts didn't spoil. He needs a friend to help him sort the pile and keep the good pieces standing.

Every age carries the same maps. You're not alone with them.

What's true

Now let me answer that hum, slowly.

Your sense that being a man is something real? You're right. God thought of it. He made male and female, both bearing His image, and called the work good before either of them had done a day's labor.

Genesis 1:27 NIV

So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them.

Manhood is one way that image walks around in the world. It was His design from the start.

Your sense that the instructions don't fit together? Also right. You've been navigating with crossed maps, and the lost feeling goes on their bill, not yours.

And the hunger to hear someone say plainly what a man does? That's a good hunger. Older men were supposed to hand you a picture. Plenty of us never got one, and we've been guessing ever since.

What's ahead is simpler than a shelf of books and costs more than one. It fits in a sentence. It has to be lived on regular days, including the ones when you feel nothing. A rush of feeling won't carry it, and neither will your best Sunday.

Before you turn the page

Hauling a contradiction around is exhausting, and that's the tiredness you've been feeling. You've spent strength on freight that was labeled wrong. If that hum has run under your days for years, let it settle tonight. You can see the maps now. Lay them down. A line that can bear real weight is close, and you don't need the rest of your life figured out first. May God take off your back what He never put there, and make

you strong for what He did.

02 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

A contradiction nobody names keeps running your week. Pick two things you were told about manhood that can't both be true. Say them out loud, along with who taught you each one.

DO THIS WEEK

Six crowds have been talking for you long enough. Write one line: the work you think a man is here to do. If you don't have a good answer, write the one you've actually been living, even if it's a poor one. Keep that paper. Soon you'll set another line beside it.

TELL A BROTHER

Keep a hum to yourself and it starts to sound like a sentence handed down. Read your line to one man and ask to hear his. It gets quieter with company.

CARRY THIS

Other hands drew the maps that got you lost. The line coming next is short enough to learn by heart and big enough to spend your life on.



CHAPTER 3

The Four Marks

We've spread the maps out on the table and watched them argue with each other. That leaves you with a sharper question than the one you sat down with. All right, then. What is a man?

I want to hand you the answer as one sentence that fits in a shirt pocket. We'll open it up afterward, a piece at a time, at the size of an ordinary week. But a picture first, because a sentence without one goes right back on the shelf.

What a mark is

Walk into a shop where a man has worked the same bench for twenty years and the room tells you about him before he does. There's a groove worn into the wood where the same cut has been made a few thousand times. There's a brown ring where his coffee cup always lands. The wrench hooks sit right where his hand already reaches. A friend of mine has a ring like that on his bench from a mug he reheated twice and still walked off without. Wanting to be a craftsman didn't cut those grooves. A Saturday class didn't either. Work did, on a long run of days that all looked about the same.

That's a mark. Thinking well of yourself leaves nothing anybody can see. Neither does a title on a business card. Work, kept up for years, presses something into a man that shows. The fire you feel at six in the morning is mostly gone by lunch. The mark comes from the hour you walk back in the door.

So here's the sentence. It's how this book defines a man, and it's ours to carry.

A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

THE FOUR MARKS

STOP WAITING PICK UP THE WEIGHT GO FIRST WORK FOR GOD'S PAY

Read it again, slower. Four marks, and every one of them is something you do. Keep doing them and they stop being words on a page. They become things people can see on you, plain as the groove in that bench.

Paul gave the church one line about where all of it starts.

Philippians 2:5 NIV

In your relationships with one another, have the same mindset as Christ Jesus:

The mind of Christ, worn by an ordinary man, looks like those four marks. In his house. With his crew. On a week where nothing special happens.

Stop Waiting

Every town has a tailgate with a decent man sitting on it. He'll fill you in on the weather, the school board, and the city water while the job he drove out there to do sits behind him in the truck bed. It's not the right time. Or the right price. Or he's not in the mood. He's waited so long he's started to trust the waiting.

Left alone, a man drifts toward waiting, and it rarely looks lazy. It looks like patience, or keeping the peace. Its favorite line is "I didn't want to overstep," and the man saying it usually thinks he's being humble. I've said it in my own house.

James doesn't leave much room to hide.

James 4:17 NIV

If anyone, then, knows the good they ought to do and doesn't do it, it is sin for them.

Stop Waiting isn't about being loud or pushing people around. It's about moving. When it's yours to do, start now, before you feel like it. Get down off the tailgate. Open the hard conversation while it's still yours to open. Later in the book we'll stay with this one until you can spot it in the week you're actually living.

Pick Up the Weight

One August a friend of mine and his brother-in-law moved a gun safe, four hundred pounds of it, down a hallway that barely cleared their shoulders, in air thick enough to lean on. Lift something like that and there comes a moment when backing out is gone. You've both got it off the floor. There's nowhere in that hallway to set it down. Halfway along, you don't get to announce that the safe is somebody else's problem. You finish the carry.

Paul says it in eight words.

Galatians 6:5 NIV

for each one should carry their own load.

A boy handles weight by waiting to be assigned something and then arguing that it isn't fair. A man looks at what's in front of him and says, "That's mine." Somebody else may have dropped it, but once it's landed in his house or his lane, it's his, and he picks it up without waiting to settle the blame. The stack of unopened bills. The kid nobody in the house is talking to. The apology he still owes. Carry what's yours, even when somebody else dropped it. That's different from helping another man carry his load, which Paul asks for too; we'll keep the two apart when we get there. A load on a young man's shoulders is a gift, because carrying is what makes the carrier. You'll see how to take what's yours and put down what was never handed to you.

Go First

Picture a stock tank on a cold morning and a row of boys on the bank. The water is deeper and colder than any of them guessed, and every one of them is waiting on somebody else. The boy who goes in first is the one leading, because now the rest know which way to go. He didn't need a title. He needed wet boots.

Jesus described Himself that way.

John 10:4 NIV

When he has brought out all his own, he goes on ahead of them, and his sheep follow him because they know his voice.

Homes and crews and churches stall until somebody moves. Three days of silence in a marriage, and somebody has to say "I was wrong" before anybody else will. Somebody has to pray out loud at a table that's never heard it. A drifting brother needs somebody to make the first call. I've held back on every one of those and called

it being careful. Go First means you step out ahead of your people, scared or not. The fear can stay in your chest while your boots go on. We'll open that up soon.

Work for God's Pay

This last mark is where good men and godly men part ways. I put it last because it's the one men step right over.

A pecan tree keeps its own clock. Plant one this fall and you'll water it for years before it gives you a nut worth cracking. Pecan orchards have always been gifts to people who show up later. The man with the shovel is spending his back on a harvest he may never hold.

Paul wrote this to people doing hard work for masters who never thanked them.

Colossians 3:23-24 NIV

Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for human masters, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving.

Notice the word. Inheritance. That's what God's pay is. It isn't a wage, and it isn't a deal where you work hard enough and God lets you into the family. Nobody earns an inheritance. You get one because you're a son, and in Christ you're a son by grace before you've lifted a finger. The pay is the Father's gift to His children, and the best of it is the Father Himself saying "well done." Work for God's Pay means you do it for the Lord's reward, not the room's applause.

That changes ordinary days more than anything else in this book. Obedience nobody sees becomes possible. So does a hard decade in a marriage, and money you'll never get back, and hours nobody thanks you for, because a Father sees what's hidden and remembers it. Look to Him for nothing and you'll go shopping somewhere else. A crowd. A bigger number. A newer truck. A father who finally says it. Before long we'll follow that hunt.

Why these four

Why four, and why in this order? Because they're one life seen from four sides, and each one leans on the one before it.

You can't carry what you never started, so the first mark comes first. You can't lead anybody while you refuse your own load, because people follow a man with his hands on something, not a man explaining why it isn't his. And you won't keep going first, Tuesday after Tuesday, when it costs you and nobody notices, unless you

know whose son you are and what He's keeping for you. Take away the last one and the first three are a list of good habits that decent men with no faith can manage for a while. The fourth ties the other three to Christ, and it keeps a man going after the applause stops. No fifth. Four is plenty to spend a life on.

The seasons will shift under your feet. The marks won't. A young man can get serious now, without a wife to force it. A young father in the noise can turn toward a worn-out wife and actually see her. A man in his middle years can catch himself drifting toward applause and point the truck home. An older man with nothing left to pin on his chest can still get up and find the work. Four marks. Another Tuesday.

Before you turn the page

The sentence is yours now. This week, don't try to work all four. Shelve three and stay with the one that's faintest on you. Every man I've watched change did it one mark at a time, on one plain day, and then did the same mark again the next day. May the Father who made you in His image show you which mark He wants to press in first, and may His patience with your slow start outlast it, the way it has outlasted mine.

03 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

You can't work on a mark you won't look at. Write one full sentence naming the faintest of the four on you right now, and why you picked it.

DO THIS WEEK

Grooves only come from doing the same thing again. Before next Tuesday, do one small thing that belongs to your faint mark. Get off the tailgate. Say "that's mine" and stop talking. Walk into one room first. Do one good thing nobody will ever hear about.

TELL A BROTHER

What stays in your head stays shapeless. Tell one man which mark is faint on you and what you did about it this week. Then ask him which one is faint on him.

CARRY THIS

A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.



CHAPTER 4

Stop Waiting

The man I worry about isn't on the couch. He's out of the driveway before the sun, and he's good at nearly everything. Ask him to land a contract, rebuild a transmission, run the church fish fry, and it's done by Friday. But there are three or four things in his own house that would actually change it, and on those he waits. He's waited so long it doesn't feel like a choice anymore. It just feels like how things are.

This chapter is about the first of the four marks, Stop Waiting. It's simple to say and hard to live. When something is yours to do, you start now, before you feel like it.

The stair

In one house I know, a step near the bottom of the staircase groans every time somebody lands on it. The kids learned to hop over it about the time they learned to tie their shoes. The fix is ten minutes: a couple of long screws, some glue, and the drill that's hung on the garage pegboard since forever. Their dad will tell you he plans to take care of it, and he sincerely does plan to. Those plans are the only attention that board has ever gotten.

Honestly, the stair is the least of it. What worries me is the lesson it's teaching him: that a man can see what's broken, hold the fix in his hand, and walk around it so long the detour becomes the hallway. The stair is just practice. Bigger ones are all over that house. A hard talk with his wife filed under "later." A brother he hasn't phoned since their mother's funeral. A sealed envelope from the bank. A son who went silent around fourteen, and a dad still waiting for the boy to make the first move. A pew he keeps meaning to sit back down in. It's all on his someday list, and someday is eating his years.

Here's the verse underneath this mark.

James 4:17 NIV

If anyone, then, knows the good they ought to do and doesn't do it, it is sin for them.

That verse locks the back door. Not doing isn't a neutral zone where a man gets to park. To God, the thing left undone is as real as the thing done.

What we tell ourselves

Nobody's ever confessed to me, "I'm passive." Men have nicer words for it, and in a parked truck they sound almost wise.

"I didn't want to start a fight." This is the one I hear most. He's wagering that the silence he has costs less than the argument he'd get. But silence keeps its own tab, and the interest compounds whether anybody looks at it or not.

"I wasn't sure." That's the dread of being wrong, dressed in a sensible jacket. Standing still is a decision too. It has outcomes, and God will ask him about those just as surely as about a bad call.

"Nobody asked." Usually this grows out of a boyhood where speaking up got you swatted and the safest way through a room was to wait for orders. Plenty of men bring that boy along into the office, the church, and the marriage, still hoping somebody picks them. Young man, if that's you, hear it straight. Nobody is going to issue you a permit to lead your own life. The ground you're standing on is already your assignment, not "once I get my stuff together," and not "after the wedding." A wedding doesn't install anything in a man. It shows what his single years built.

"It'll work out." It won't. Weeds don't pull themselves.

Proverbs 24:30-31 NIV

I went past the field of a sluggard, past the vineyard of someone who has no sense; thorns had come up everywhere, the ground was covered with weeds, and the stone wall was in ruins.

Read what went wrong there. No arson. No sledgehammer to the wall. Just neglect, season after season, and thorns that never needed anyone's say-so. Distance in a marriage works like that. So does a credit card balance. So does a teenage boy who's quietly concluded his dad isn't coming.

Then there's the reason under the reasons, the one a man never says: he's comfortable. Comfort doesn't debate you. It just sets the thermostat where you like it and lets you nod off. The man who sold off the trucks or retired knows it best. His phone goes quiet, and nobody needs him unless he walks in somewhere and asks

what he can carry.

Good costumes

Passivity rarely shows up looking like laziness, because laziness is easy to spot and shame eventually gets a lazy man moving. So it dresses better.

It puts on patience: “I’m giving it some time.” Sometimes that’s genuine wisdom. More often he’s handing time a job he won’t do himself, and time has no judgment and no love for anyone under that roof.

It puts on peace: “I don’t want to stir things up.” So nothing gets stirred, and the peace he’s protecting turns out to be a kitchen where nobody says anything costly.

It puts on humility: “Who am I to bring it up?” You’re her husband. You’re his dad. You’re the one standing right there. That’s who.

It puts on preparation. Another book, another podcast, another long conversation about the conversation. A man can become an expert on something he has never once done.

It even puts on faith: “I’m waiting on the Lord.” There’s an honest kind of waiting on God, and there’s a counterfeit that signs His name under a pair of folded hands. We’ll sort those out in a minute.

And its favorite outfit is busy. Gone before daylight, home after dark, coaching Saturdays, setting up chairs Sundays. Nobody would call that man passive, least of all him. His wife could name what he’s dodging before you finished asking. Busy isn’t the cure for passive. A lot of the time it’s the hiding spot.

Hiding is as old as we are. When God came through the garden as the day cooled off, the first man was crouched behind the trees.

Genesis 3:9 NIV

But the LORD God called to the man, “Where are you?”

God knew exactly which tree. He wasn’t asking for coordinates. He was asking, in effect, where’s the man I set here to tend and guard this place, the one who stood beside her and said nothing? That question still moves through our houses. Tonight it’ll pass your stair with your name on it.

Waiting with your boots on

Now, Scripture really does call a man to wait on the Lord. That's a gift, and I won't pry it out of your hands. Just look at how the psalmist pictures it.

Psalm 27:14 NIV

Wait for the LORD; be strong and take heart and wait for the LORD.

Strong. Heart up. Those are words for somebody standing, not slouching. He does everything in reach and leaves what's out of reach to God. Think about Abraham. A quarter century between the promise of a son and the boy's arrival, and look at his calendar in those years: a move with everything he owned to a place he'd never laid eyes on, altars stacked along the way, a rescue raid with his own trained men when Lot got carried off, sitting across from kings. He never treated the promise as a reason to sit out the chores God had already handed him.

Try this the next time "I'm waiting on God" comes out of your mouth. Glance down. Hands moving on the next obvious good thing? Then you're waiting on Him. Hands in your lap until heaven sends a memo? Then it's comfort you're waiting on, and you've signed God's name to the bill.

Our Lord didn't slide into His last week by accident.

Luke 9:51 NIV

As the time approached for him to be taken up to heaven, Jesus resolutely set out for Jerusalem.

Resolutely. He could see the cross at the end of that road, and He pointed Himself straight at it.

The first screw

Put the thing in calendar words. "Our marriage" can't go on a calendar. "Sit down with her Thursday about the credit card" can. "My boy" can't. "Take him for tacos Saturday, radio off, and ask how he's really doing" can. Fog can't be scheduled. A named thing can.

Next, be honest about what you're holding out for. You've got enough information. What you want is a feeling: ready, brave, certain. Those trail in behind the move like dust behind a truck. They don't lead it. The divorced man saving a call for when he's calmer will find that calm usually shows up after obedience, not ahead of it.

Then shrink the step until it's small enough to take today and still real. Opening

his contact card isn't a step. Pressing call is. Lifting the drill off the pegboard isn't a step. Sinking the first screw is.

Morning is your friend. Whatever nerve you've got is freshest before lunch, and by supper the recliner has built a very persuasive argument.

Last, expect it to feel off. Years of waiting have tuned you for waiting, so the first right move will feel like a misstep for a day or so. That isn't God's verdict. It's stiff muscle getting used again.

Seen in secret

That verse from James locked one door. Here's the one it opens. The Father who notices what we leave undone notices just as surely what a man does when nobody's around: the dark hallway at 5:45 with a drill in his hand because he's through stepping over it, the call he finally makes, the question he finally asks. God is glad over that, the way a father is glad over a son. Today, that's Stop Waiting: fix the stair, and then pick up the phone.

Before you turn the page

Nobody taught you to skip that stair on purpose. You picked it up from the men you grew up around, the way you picked up how to stand and how to laugh. You can put it down the same way, one deliberate step at a time, and the first is the heaviest. May the God who came calling for Adam in the garden find you up and moving.

04 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Whatever you never say out loud stays in charge. Write down the one thing you've put off longest. Beside it, write how long. Be honest.

DO THIS WEEK

Years vanish in the gap between knowing and doing. Pick a workday and, before noon, make the smallest real move on that thing. Feeling ready isn't required. New baby, and you've been saying "after this crazy stretch"? The stretch is the season. Ten minutes with her at the counter tonight, both phones face down, counts.

TELL A BROTHER

It's easier to move when someone's watching for it. Tell one man what you've been stepping around and what you did, and ask him to bring it up again next week.

CARRY THIS

Where are you? He isn't asking for directions. Get up and answer Him.



CHAPTER 5

Pick Up the Weight

Tomás had a broke Tuesday. The car payment drafts on the fourteenth. His paycheck lands on the fifteenth. Diapers and formula had already gone on the card, and even after picking up a Saturday shift he was forty dollars short. Sitting there with the laptop open, what he felt wasn't greed or even panic so much as a pull to hide. Close the screen. Let her stumble on it in the banking app sometime next week. Instead, after the baby finally went down, he stayed at the kitchen table, turned the laptop so she could see the numbers, and said, "That's mine. We're short." Then he walked her through what he'd cut. Nothing got solved that night. The math was just as ugly at bedtime. But she wasn't alone with it, and neither was he.

That's the second of the four marks, and it has a plain name: Pick Up the Weight. A steadfast man finds the part of the load that's his and gets his hands under it, even when it isn't fair, and even when somebody else dropped it, once it lands in his house or his lane. Paul says it in eight words.

Galatians 6:5 NIV

for each one should carry their own load.

Two words and a period

Notice what Tomás said, and what he didn't. He didn't say, "I can see how you might be frustrated." He didn't open with how the bank times its drafts. He said, "That's mine." That's the whole move. Look at the person and claim it.

Then stop. A period belongs right there. The instant "but" shows up, a second speech has started, and everybody listening hears the gears shift.

What you're claiming is the outcome, not the intention. A wet spot spreading on the ceiling is an outcome. The Saturday you planned to get up on the roof is a story. If you tell your kids you meant to cook supper, you've described a plan. They'll

describe an empty table.

The oldest dodge

I've fought this. I've stood in my own kitchen and eased a load onto somebody else with one tidy sentence and told myself I was just being honest. We come by it naturally. The first thing a man said to God after the fall was a handoff. God asked what happened, and Adam pointed two directions at once: the woman, and You, since You're the One who gave her to me. His wife gets half, God gets the other half, and Adam walks off holding none of it. He got to his "but" before he'd finished one sentence. A generation later, Cain had the move down cold.

Genesis 4:9 NIV

Then the LORD said to Cain, "Where is your brother Abel?" "I don't know," he replied. "Am I my brother's keeper?"

The answer to Cain was yes, and it's still yes. Yes for the manager who says that's another department. Yes for the stepdad who says that's her kid's issue. Yes for "she knew what she signed up for" and "nobody ever told me."

Both men were protecting a story where the weight belonged to someone else. That story is called blame, and it makes an afternoon feel lighter for a while.

Good men get stuck right here, because they confuse fault with ownership. Fault looks backward and asks who caused this. Ownership looks at today and asks whose it is now. You can carry zero fault for a layoff, a cancer diagnosis, a daughter's panic attacks, or a dad who left you nothing but his debts, and still find your name on every one. Fairness is a fine question for a judge. A load-bearing wall doesn't get to ask it.

The wall you can't move

Most houses have one wall that can't come out, and you can't tell by looking. Same paint, same nail holes from the old school pictures. But the ceiling joists all rest on it, and every bed and dresser and sleeping kid upstairs is riding on that wall. A contractor knocks, glances up, checks which way the floor runs, and points. That one. You can still open up the kitchen, but only after you set new support under the load. Pull the wall out bare and the second floor sinks a little at a time, until next year a bedroom door won't latch.

Every family carries weight, and so does every job and every single life. It lands somewhere, fair or not.

And a household needs a floor that holds. A teenager who shoves back is testing whether it will, and the dad of a new driver is mostly carrying his own temper. A wife who finally says the hard thing is trusting you to stay planted while she says it. A divorced man is still the floor under two addresses. You can feel shaky and stay. When it gets loud, stay again. Nobody upstairs ever thinks about the beam. They just walk across the floor. That's the beam doing its job.

More than a paycheck

Plenty of men know the verse about providing, and most were taught it means a paycheck, full stop.

1 Timothy 5:8 NIV

Anyone who does not provide for their relatives, and especially for their own household, has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.

Look at “household.” That’s everyone under the roof, and money is a sliver of what a dad owes them. A man can bankroll a house he barely sets foot in. He can pay for ten years of piano lessons and leave his folding chair empty at the recital, and the empty chair is what his daughter remembers. Groceries are the floor of providing, not the ceiling. Showing up is part of it. Short on money, Tomás still gave what mattered most that night: himself, at the table with the bill.

Your name on it

What’s actually yours is a shorter list than you’d guess. But a handful of things won’t negotiate.

Your own life comes first. Your body, your bank account, your word, your habits, your soul. No volunteer will schedule your physical, pay off your card, or open your Bible for you. Those left your mother’s hands years ago. Living alone, that’s most of your load, and it’s heavier than it sounds, since nobody sees a man quit in an empty apartment.

If you share a home, that’s next. A marriage runs warm or cool, and you answer for the trend. A new father is carrying a wife who hasn’t slept in a week. Children under your roof are being shaped, and you’re the one shaping them. A coach helps and a youth pastor helps, but the voice your son grows into will sound like whoever was actually around.

Then today’s work. Do it like the owner is standing behind you. One is.

Then the people tied to you. The buddy in trouble. The man at church whose wife moved out this month. The boy two doors down whose dad is mostly a rumor. Keeper is your job. Savior is already taken, by One Man.

Last comes the weight men drop first, and it's the heaviest: your own wrong. Not the wrong done to you. We'll get to that later. I mean the thing you said at supper you can't take back, the years you were home in body only, the thing she still hasn't been told. Put that down and it doesn't shrink. It slides onto everybody else in the house and grows on the way. With grown kids, it's mostly the oldest weight, the mistakes from their childhood. It's not too late to lift it. Usually that starts with a phone call.

The crush and the pack

Three verses before telling us to carry our own load, Paul says what sounds like the opposite.

Galatians 6:2 NIV

Carry each other's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ.

Both are true because he uses two different words. The burden in verse 2 is a crushing weight, more than one man can lift. The load in verse 5 is a soldier's pack, gear issued with your name on it and sized for your back. When Jesus called His burden light, that second word is the one He chose. Something another man dropped joins your pack once it lands in your house or your lane. Until then it's his, and if it's crushing him, that's verse 2. Your pack goes on without a speech. When a brother is pinned under the crushing kind, you get under it with him, invited or not. And the order matters: a man who helps everyone in town while his own pack sits in the driveway is hiding, and his family can tell.

Pride gets this backward. It loads one arm until a man staggers, because an empty hand feels like failure. His wife's entire happiness. Every choice his kids make. The spiritual condition of the whole church. He calls that devotion. It's overload.

Moses hit that point in the desert, a whole nation griping about the menu, and said what pride usually swallows.

Numbers 11:14 NIV

I cannot carry all these people by myself; the burden is too heavy for me.

God's answer was seventy elders. Some weights He left off your list on purpose,

and grabbing them anyway is pride in a work shirt. Your wife's joy belongs to her and to God. Your grown son's choices belong to your grown son. So name the weight God never handed you and give it back. Let two or three men take the piece that's flattening you. That isn't quitting. It may be the most faithful hour of your year.

The One who carried ours

Long before any of this was said about us, it was said about Him.

Isaiah 53:4 NIV

Surely he took up our pain and bore our suffering, yet we considered him punished by God, stricken by him, and afflicted.

Took up. Bore. He didn't cause the wreck and didn't owe a cent of it. He never once said, the woman You gave me. The cross is "That's mine" spoken by the only man who could have refused and been telling the truth.

There was joy ahead of Him while He carried it. Your Father sees the beam nobody upstairs mentions, and what He has for you is a son's inheritance, not a wage. That's why Pick Up the Weight is a mark and not a chore.

Before you turn the page

If something settled on your shoulders while you read, that's what being the wall feels like. It's meant to rest on a frame built for it, and God sizes a man for the load He issues, with seventy more stationed around him for the rest. Hold up your corner. When it gets heavy, keep your finger from pointing. May He plant you under what's yours, keep you honest about what He's taken back, and teach your house that the floor will hold.

05 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

The mark begins with a sentence you let stand on its own. Write one line that opens with “That’s mine” and stops at the period. Leave off any “but.” Leave off any “because.”

DO THIS WEEK

Your household needs more from you than a deposit. Each day this week, give something money can’t buy. Cook supper. Sit up front at the game. Ask a question and hear the whole answer. Living alone or with roommates? Claim the chore nobody claims, the trash or the sink, and keep it.

TELL A BROTHER

Once another man has heard you claim a weight, it’s harder to drop. Tell him your “That’s mine” line and what you did next, and ask him to check back in a week.

CARRY THIS

Absence purchased with a bigger paycheck is still absence. Stay in the room.



CHAPTER 6

Go First

Sometime after midnight a storm laid an old oak down across a residential street. By sunrise the root ball stood taller than a mailbox and the branches were sprawled over a neighbor's lawn. No power. One by one, people came to their front windows, looked at the tree, looked at the other houses, and you could almost hear everybody doing the same arithmetic. Who's going to handle this?

For a good while, nobody. Every house cared, but caring had come loose from moving. Behind every curtain: that tree needs a man who knows a saw, and he's probably somebody else.

Then a front door opened. One guy, sweatpants and an old coat, work gloves, a chainsaw. He didn't call a meeting on the lawn. He walked out to the trunk and started studying where to cut. For a long minute he had the street to himself.

Then a second door. Fifteen minutes later: six men, two saws, a truck at the curb, coffee on a camp stove for the crew. That street had never been short on tools. It had been short on a door.

I know the view from behind that glass. I've handed the job to a more experienced guy in my head and stayed put. This chapter is about the third of the four marks: Go First. Say leader and most men picture a title, the loud voice in the meeting, which gives us permission to stay inside. Going first is smaller and harder. It's the one man who moves while the block is still deciding, walking the open ground so everyone behind him has somewhere to go. It's what Jesus said a shepherd does.

John 10:4 NIV

When he has brought out all his own, he goes on ahead of them, and his sheep follow him because they know his voice.

On ahead of them. The flock isn't following an org chart. They follow a voice they trust, and that voice is already out in front.

He went ahead of everybody

Before we get to you, look at Him. Hebrews gives Jesus a name that fits this whole chapter.

Hebrews 12:2 NIV

fixing our eyes on Jesus, the pioneer and perfecter of faith. For the joy set before him he endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.

Pioneer. The man who goes into the hardest country first and cuts a trail the rest can walk. Jesus did that at the cross, alone, His friends scattered. And the writer tells you what pulled Him forward: joy, set out ahead like a porch light at the end of a long road.

That's why Go First can't run on nerve. Nerve is a small tank, usually dry by the second door. What keeps a man moving is knowing what's waiting on the far side, and who. You don't go first to get God to take you in. If you belong to Christ, you're already His son. You step out because the One out ahead is trustworthy, and whatever it costs will turn out to be worth it.

Watch me

He didn't only go first at the cross. He did it on an ordinary evening, with dirty feet.

In the upper room, washing feet was the lowest job in the house, and all twelve were quietly hoping someone else would get stuck with it. Jesus tied a towel on, filled a basin, and got down on the floor. Afterward He explained.

John 13:14-15 NIV

Now that I, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also should wash one another's feet. I have set you an example that you should do as I have done for you.

Teaching humility from a chair would have cost Him less. He did the dirty job first and then said, your turn. Centuries before, Gideon stood over a sleeping army with three hundred men and gave them one order.

Judges 7:17-18 NIV

"Watch me," he told them. "Follow my lead. When I get to the edge of the camp, do exactly as I do. When I and all who are with me blow our trumpets, then from all around the camp blow yours and shout, 'For the LORD and for Gideon.'"

Watch me. Two words, most of what leadership is, and the reason so few of us

volunteer. A podium protects you. Out front, nothing does. You're first into the cold creek. Guess wrong and everybody sees. If nobody follows, you're out there holding a plan by yourself. You go anyway, with the order and no guarantee.

Small doors

Most of the doors are closer and smaller than a tree in the road.

Saying you're sorry, early and clean. "I'm sorry I raised my voice." Period. Tack on "but you always" and the apology becomes a court case. I've done that and called the cease-fire peace. She hears the "but" coming before you get there. Divorced? Give your kids' mom the most honest apology you've got, and leave what she does with it to her.

Praying out loud at supper. In a lot of homes the plates hit the table, there's a silence everybody understands, and the eyes drift to one chair. I've prayed for strangers without a flinch and gone mute in front of my own family. With a newborn, start over the crib, out loud, and again tomorrow.

Naming the mess. Nehemiah walked the ruined wall alone in the dark first. Then he got everyone together and said out loud what all of them could see.

Nehemiah 2:17 NIV

Then I said to them, "You see the trouble we are in: Jerusalem lies in ruins, and its gates have been burned with fire. Come, let us rebuild the wall of Jerusalem, and we will no longer be in disgrace."

At your place it might be this. We haven't been to church in months. We're behind on the truck. Our son is drinking and we've all agreed to pretend he isn't. You can't rebuild what you won't name. Left unnamed, it turns into scenery.

Making the first move in a cold marriage, where two people stand frozen, each waiting on the other. Go. Maybe she's more at fault this time. You're still the one called to move. That kitchen is twelve feet across and can feel like a mile. I've stood on my side and let the mile win.

Pointing by walking. Nehemiah said "come" on his way to the wall. When a man decides his household is going to worship this Sunday, he doesn't give a speech. He's in the truck with it running while the kids are still looking for shoes. Single, you say Sunday matters and offer a buddy the ride.

Why we stay inside

Four fears keep the door shut, and I've fed every one.

Looking stupid. The prayer comes out clumsy, the apology sounds scripted, you reach the trunk and can't tell where to cut. Rejection. You turn toward her and she stays turned away. Your son shrugs and shuts his door. Being wrong, so we pick nothing and call it humility. And the cost, which is not imaginary. The first man out loses his morning. The first man to apologize loses the argument. Going first always gets the bill first.

The Bible is honest about fear. It just never says to wait until it's gone. Paul wrote this to Timothy, a young man with every reason to hang back.

2 Timothy 1:7 NIV

For the Spirit God gave us does not make us timid, but gives us power, love and self-discipline.

Scared and frozen is timidity. Scared and walking is courage. The man heading for that oak with his pulse in his ears isn't missing anything.

Second in line

Here's what changes the whole street. When Moses handed leadership to Joshua, there was a river ahead and fortified cities past it. Moses didn't say toughen up. He said who was already out ahead.

Deuteronomy 31:8 NIV

The LORD himself goes before you and will be with you; he will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged.

Goes before you. Every door you open, He opened first. Every hard conversation at your table, you're walking into a room He's already in. So you're never actually first. You're second in line. It still costs. But He's already out on the road, and He isn't heading back in.

How to start

Have one sentence ready, not the whole conversation. Men who rehearse every line usually never say any of it. I know that stall. "I was wrong." "Can I pray for us?" "Son, I've noticed something." After that first sentence, the people in the room will carry more of it than you expect.

Practice in small rooms. Wanting to lead the men's ministry while mute at your

own table is backward. A man can run a team of forty and still be the last one to move in his own living room, because managing well and going first are different muscles. The truck, the kitchen, the group text with three close friends. Big rooms are made of small ones.

Ask instead of announce. “What’s this year of being married to me really been like?” Then wait. Not married? Ask a friend what’s on him that you never asked about. A silent teenager gets one real question in the car. Older? Cross the lobby to the young guy, because he won’t cross it first.

Expect a gap. You go out, and for maybe eight seconds nobody else does. Most of us retreat at about four. The gap is just what first feels like. Stay.

And pick an ordinary day. Storms are rare. Dinner is tonight.

Before you turn the page

Nobody needs you to be the bravest man on the block. That’s Go First: open the door with your heart still banging, knowing you aren’t the first one out. He is. May you be given your first sentence, may the quiet after it be held for you, and may you hear a second door open.

06 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Somewhere in your life everyone's watching and nobody's moving, and that room is yours. Write down the room, who's in it, and what has to happen first.

DO THIS WEEK

The second door is always easier than the first. Pick one this week. Pray out loud at the table, or apologize without the "but you," or name the mess to the people living in it. On your own, say Sunday and drive, or go cross the lobby to a younger man.

TELL A BROTHER

Say it to one man and it gets harder to back out of. Tell him your first line beforehand. Then tell him how it went, gap and all.

CARRY THIS

He went out ahead of you. Your number is second.



CHAPTER 7

Work for God's Pay

Most men know the drive home with the radio up and a trophy riding shotgun. That night it feels permanent. Years later one just like it turns up at a yard sale, in a cardboard box on a folding table with FREE down the side in marker. A gold batter missing an arm. A bowling pin glued to marble. A sales plaque from a company that folded. Somebody's Saturdays were in that box, and nights he was sure would define him. By noon nobody had claimed it. By spring it was at the curb.

That's how the rewards you can hold tend to go. They're great for a night. Then your hand's empty and you go hunting again.

The fourth mark is Work for God's Pay: do it for the Lord's reward, not the room's applause. Hear that word the way Paul meant it. God's pay is an inheritance, what a Father gives His sons because they're His, and in Christ you're a son by grace before you've lifted a finger. Nobody earns an inheritance. You work like a son because you already are one.

The other three marks lean on this one. Stop Waiting, Pick Up the Weight, and Go First all cost you something today, and a man keeps at them only if he trusts the Father who's watching. Why fix what nobody asked you to fix if nobody ever sees it? Why say "that's mine" if the blame would have slid right past you? Why go first if the street is all there is? Those questions don't go quiet until this mark answers them.

What you're already working for

You're already working for some kind of pay. Every man is, from the minute his feet hit the floor. The only question is whose.

Your father's approval, alive or not. More men are still working for that one than will admit it. Comfort, which a new dad is chasing by week six and a retired man on too many afternoons. Being right, which a young husband will trade a whole evening for. The number on the screen, checked before you're out of the parking lot. The

nod from across the room. Being wanted, which single men chase quietly and married men forget they're chasing. Being remembered. Your name on something.

Some of those are good in their place. Every one of them runs out. The nod dies in the parking lot. The bigger number shows up without the feeling that was supposed to ride along. Your father's approval, if it ever comes, is smaller than the version you rehearsed. Collect the kind of pay that lasts one night and you end up on that folding table.

Treasure that keeps

Jesus never told men to stop wanting a reward. He told them where to put it.

Matthew 6:19-21 NIV

Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.

Moths, vermin, thieves. He described the yard sale two thousand years early. Earlier in the same sermon He told them how the lasting kind gets stored.

Matthew 6:3-4 NIV

But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing, so that your giving may be in secret. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

Every kind of pay on that old list needs an audience. This one asks you to send the audience home. A widow's driveway shoveled while her kitchen light is still off. A check with no story attached. Praise spoken about a man who'll never find out you said it. A single guy's Saturday spent hauling a young family's couch up to a second-floor apartment, with nobody to tell about it that night. Hidden work still has a witness, and He doesn't forget a thing.

And it's bigger than what happens at church.

Colossians 3:23-24 NIV

Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for human masters, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving.

Whatever you do. The invoice and the diaper, the spreadsheet and the graveyard shift. This pay isn't only for the guy on the stage. It's for the man on the ladder and the man at the sink with nobody watching, when he does it for the Lord. Who

you're doing it for is what turns it into treasure.

The pay is an inheritance

Men get this wrong in both directions, so stay with it. You can't clock in for an inheritance. You get one because you're in the family, and the only way into this family is grace.

Ephesians 2:8-10 NIV

For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God—not by works, so that no one can boast. For we are God's handiwork, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance for us to do.

Look at the order. Saved by grace, as a gift. Then the good works God already laid out for you. The work comes after you're His, never as the price of becoming His. So when this book says work for God's pay, it doesn't mean work hard and maybe God will let you in. It means you're already a son, so work like one, and trust your Father to remember every hidden thing. The pay isn't wages. It's a son's inheritance, and the best part of it is the Father Himself.

Matthew 25:21 NIV

His master replied, 'Well done, good and faithful servant! You have been faithful with a few things; I will put you in charge of many things. Come and share your master's happiness!'

Well done. More put in your hands. A door open into His joy. The pay is mostly welcome. What a son wants at the end of the road is a Father glad to see him coming up the walk.

Moses chose well. He grew up in a palace with the treasury a hallway away, and he walked out to stand with slaves.

Hebrews 11:26 NIV

He regarded disgrace for the sake of Christ as of greater value than the treasures of Egypt, because he was looking ahead to his reward.

Looking ahead. He saw past the treasure room to something worth more, and seeing it is what let him walk away. A man can leave almost anything with something better in view. He can't leave much when all that's in the frame is what he's losing.

What it does to a man

You don't need to interview him. A man working for God's pay shows it. He does good and doesn't bring it up. He drops arguments he could win. He stays, in his

marriage and his church and his town, on days he'd have every excuse to leave. He takes the low seat without scanning the room. He forgives a man who doesn't deserve it, because his Father has already forgiven him more. He prays for grandkids not yet born. He teaches a boy to work, and that boy will teach another long after he's gone. Mr. Pruitt, a widower who planted forty pecan trees the spring after he buried his wife, keeps them like that. The nuts are for other people. The watering is his.

That way of living only makes sense if this life isn't the end of the story. It isn't.

What it doesn't promise

The loud version of this is a counterfeit, so let me say plainly what God's pay doesn't include. No promise of health, a bigger house, an easier year, or kids who land where you aimed them. Staying married doesn't promise warmth by spring. Forgiving a man doesn't promise he'll ever apologize. Preachers who sold those deals left wreckage behind them. Paul wrote down the real scale after he'd been beaten and shipwrecked.

2 Corinthians 4:17-18 NIV

For our light and momentary troubles are achieving for us an eternal glory that far outweighs them all. So we fix our eyes not on what is seen, but on what is unseen, since what is seen is temporary, but what is unseen is eternal.

Light and momentary, from a man covered in scars. He was looking at the long view. He never said the trouble would vanish. He said it was producing something. The hard years stay on the record. They're the raw material the reward is made from.

How to live for it

Every day, fix your eyes. Fix is Paul's word, and a glance won't do it. One line before your feet hit the floor: today is seen, and today counts.

Every week, one kindness nobody will ever know about. If the story leaks, you picked the wrong kindness.

On the drive home after a day nobody thanked you for, practice hearing "well done" in His voice.

Catch yourself performing while it's starting. Jesus was plain: good done for a crowd has already gotten everything it's going to get. The second you look around to see who noticed, you've traded a Father's "well done" for a glance from the room.

Pray past Thursday. A single man's apartment is room enough for this. So is a grandfather's porch. Same audience to let go of. Same Father doing the seeing.

One man

Put all four marks on one life and look at him. He doesn't walk around the job that needs doing. He says "that's mine" and lets it stand. He opens the first door while the street watches. And the pay he's after is out of reach of any yard sale. There's an old word for a man like that. Steadfast.

A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

That's Work for God's Pay, lived out. Live for the reward that lasts. Then go back to work.

Before you turn the page

The small rewards pay out the same night, and that's why men keep picking them. Raise your aim. The Father who sees in secret forgets nothing, and He's keeping an inheritance for His son. May your eyes be fixed where moths can't get at the treasure, and may the words you're longing for be kept for you until the day He says them.

07 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

A prize you won't name is a prize you can't trade in. Write down the small reward that's driving right now. Applause, the number, being wanted, being right, the nod, comfort, or being remembered. Under it, write where it's been taking you.

DO THIS WEEK

The Father who sees in secret is the one who rewards secret work. Do one kindness no human being will find out about. Your wife or your roommate doesn't hear about it. Your brother doesn't hear about it. The men you meet don't hear about it. After that, keep quiet for good.

TELL A BROTHER

Saying the small reward out loud to another man loosens its grip. Tell him what it is. Tell him what it's cost you. Keep the hidden kindness to yourself. That one stays between you and your Father.

CARRY THIS

Some kind of pay already has you. Name it, and aim higher.

PART TWO

What You Inherited, and What Is Yours



CHAPTER 8

The Empty Chair

The boy had owned his learner's permit for about three hours. On a quiet Saturday, Curtis drove him to the empty high school lot, got out, walked around, and lowered himself into the passenger side of his own car. He had no idea where to put his hands.

His son was good. A year of watching from that seat had taught him plenty. He eased into every stop and circled the light poles twice, slow and careful. Curtis gripped the door handle until his knuckles went pale, and his left foot kept stamping the mat for a brake that wasn't there. Every touch of the gas pulled a tight "easy" out of him in a voice he'd never have claimed. Halfway through the third lap, his son stopped, shifted into park, and said, "Dad. You're doing the thing."

That night, alone at the sink with the house asleep, Curtis finally saw it. When he was sixteen, it was his mom in that right-hand seat, both palms pressed against the dash, scared right along with him. His dad had left years before, and there was no other man to ask. Curtis had never seen a calm father beside a boy at the wheel. All he'd been handed was a door handle and a single word, and even the word came out crooked.

Before the hard part, know where this road ends, because some of you won't make it through the middle otherwise. There's a Father who doesn't leave. We'll come back to Him soon. For now, hold on to how the psalm names Him.

Psalm 68:5-6 NIV

A father to the fatherless, a defender of widows, is God in his holy dwelling. God sets the lonely in families, he leads out the prisoners with singing; but the rebellious live in a sun-scorched land.

That's who's waiting at the end of this. Now let's look at the chair honestly.

The first classroom

Every man learned about manhood long before anyone gave a talk on it. The classroom was one seat at the end of a kitchen table, filled or empty. You were taking notes before you could spell. When he got home. What his silence was saying. Whether his hands could be trusted. Whether your mom's words reached him at all. Whether Saturday's promise survived to Saturday. You'd graduated from that school before you were trusted with a key to the front door.

My aim in this chapter is to help you separate two piles. One pile was set on you. The other is now yours to answer for.

Some of you grew up around a vacant seat. Divorce, a funeral, a prison sentence, or a man who drove off and never explained. His absence still taught. Men go. When Mom is exhausted, the boy fixes things. You figure life out alone.

Some of you had a man sitting there who never really showed up. His job swallowed him, or the bottle did, or the TV got what you never got. Ask what he thought of you and you hit a wall. Relatives make allowances for him. I won't. That wound cuts as deep as a packed bag at the door, and it hides better, because the neighbors saw him come home every night and figured you had it fine.

Some of you had a chair you feared. The way the keys hit the counter told you what kind of evening it would be. You learned to shrink, or to pick the fight yourself so the storm would land on you instead of your mom.

Some of you had a good, steady father. Thank God, and keep it. Even good men have sharp corners, and you carried a few out of the house. Nobody gets through unmarked, though some of you will need a while to find yours.

What sits down in the empty place

No boy can live around a hole that big. Something takes the seat, and whatever takes it does the rest of the raising.

Often the boy takes it. He fathers himself, sets his own rules, coaches himself through the fear until it's small enough to carry. Some genuine toughness comes from that. So does a man nobody can father anymore, including God. That man has carried the load solo for so long that a second pair of hands feels like drowning.

For other boys, a rule takes the seat. Need people and they'll hurt you. So he quits needing, and grows into a husband who never asks for a thing. His wife could spend two decades beside him and not know what he longs for. He'll tell you he longs for

nothing, and mean it.

Some boys give the seat to whoever's in the room. He knows how everybody feels. He has no clue how he feels.

Some hand it to an audience. He earns scraps of approval with a report card, a punch line, a curveball. The beard's going gray, the show is still running, and he couldn't say who he's playing to.

And for some, what fills the seat is the man he promised never to be. Curtis made that promise as a kid. No child of his would be left, and none has been. That's good, and I'd never take it from him. But that promise is the whole of his idea of a dad. He'd memorized everything not to do. Nobody had shown him how to sit still in the passenger seat while his son figured it out. The door handle was all he knew to grab.

Yours to answer for

You didn't choose who was in that chair. Nobody hands a seven-year-old a ballot on whether his father stays. It was done to you, and it formed you. God saw all of it, and it matters to Him.

What you do with it from today on, though, is yours. When Curtis snaps at his kids, the snap has the shape of a missing father, and it's still his snap. His wife meets it in a real kitchen. She never met the years that left. I've mistaken a good diagram of my wound for a healed one. Plenty of men describe their damage perfectly and then settle in to live there, because describing started to feel like getting somewhere.

Scripture is straight with men like this. Joseph had a father who loved him, and the pit happened anyway. David was out with the flock when the prophet came to look at Jesse's sons. Jesus was raised by a man who wasn't His father, and Joseph quietly exits before Jesus' public years. Each carried a mark from the chair. None was excused by it. That's a kind of honor. God treats you as a man who can respond to what happened to you. He's talking to the right man.

What to do with it

Say it first. I've asked grown men about their dads, big men who fill a doorway, and watched them freeze. "I don't really think about him." That answer is the thinking. Say your sentence once, out loud, in your own hearing. My dad left. My dad was home and I never knew him. My dad frightened me. My dad was a good man, and some part of me never reached him.

Then grieve it. Men dodge this one every chance they get. Grief lets a loss be its

true size. A seat that stayed empty. A shoulder you never leaned on. Words a fifteen-year-old needed, words some of you are still waiting for. Give it the weight you'd give a funeral. Managing it won't do your grieving for you. I keep thinking of David, the son his own father didn't bother to call in from the field, and the line he wrote without any polish on it.

Psalm 27:10 NIV

Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me.

He doesn't act like nobody left. He names the hurt, and he names who took him in.

Then let the empty chair be your first word about fathers, never your last. That's where the Father from the start of this chapter comes in. If the chair gets the final say, you've believed a lie, and the next pages are here to put the truth back in the seat.

It comes with you

The chair doesn't stay put in one house, and it doesn't age out.

Maybe your father's alive and still absent. Don't wait for his permission before you live like a man. Put your weight on the Father who's already here.

Sometimes a death closes the conversation before it opened. I'm sorry. Say it to God, who knew your father as you never could, and to a brother. And if you're sixty with the seat still empty, it isn't too late to name it.

If you've built a big career, a corner office doesn't fill a chair. Men keep trying anyway.

The first time you hold your own son, the chair returns as a catch in your throat. What if this comes through me into him? That fear means you're awake. The men who repeat it are the ones who never turned to face it.

If you're young and single, don't shelve this for later. Somebody's already watching the seat you sit in: a kid brother, a nephew, the new hire.

If you're divorced, I'll say it plainly and leave it alone. You are somebody's empty chair now. Being there is how you begin to answer that. The kid exchange. The ballgame. The call you keep making, through months when all you hear back is "nothing."

The next Saturday

The two of them went back to the lot the following weekend. Before his son pulled out, Curtis told him the truth. “Nobody ever sat in this seat for me. I’m learning it while you learn this.” He let go of the door handle, rested his hand on his knee, and kept it there. The boy swung wide on the first corner. Curtis said, “You’ve got it.” It was the first fatherly thing he’d ever said on purpose.

Years from now, the boy won’t remember the laps. He’ll remember who stayed beside him.

The end of your old table was handed to you. The seats you hold now are your choice. Take them and stay, so your kids study a different man than you did. And step out of the job of fathering yourself long enough for a real Father to get to you. There was more in the seat next to you than you were ever taught to notice.

Before you turn the page

Bring God the chair exactly as it was. No touch-ups. May the One who sets the lonely in families bring you into His. And tonight, at your own table, take your seat and stay in it.

08 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Leave the chair unnamed and it keeps running things from the attic. Out loud, finish this: “The chair at the end of my table was _.” Then name one thing it taught you.

DO THIS WEEK

Grief held in the body comes out sideways, in your marriage and your temper. Write your father a letter you won’t send: what you needed, what never came, whatever thanks is true. Keep it safe. You’ll want it later in this book.

TELL A BROTHER

A hard sentence weighs less once another man has heard it. Read him your finished line. The letter stays private unless you choose otherwise. He may say “me too,” or “I’m sorry.” Let it be enough.

CARRY THIS

Who sat in that chair was handed to you. What you do with it now is yours.



CHAPTER 9

Anger, the Itch, and the Drift

Owen found out on a Monday that the fall contract had gone to someone else. He'd already spent that money in his head. He ran the numbers twice, closed the laptop, and told nobody, God included, in any honest way. He was scared, and he put the fear where men usually put it.

A couple of nights later he spent forty minutes locked in the bathroom with his phone. Nothing on that screen wanted anything from him, which was the whole point. That weekend he went flat on the couch under a ballgame, and when his wife tried to plan July around her sister's offer to take the kids, he gave her "whatever you think" from a long way off. And when his daughter loaded the dishwasher wrong, he shut it so hard a glass bounced off the top rack, and the kitchen went silent the way it had learned to.

Ask Owen and he'd have called it a rough week and a short fuse. It was three escapes from the same fear.

Pain always moves

You've already seen that an empty chair never stays empty. Pain is like that. It won't sit still in a man. It leaves, and it has three ways out.

Anger throws it outward. Appetite pulls it downward. Absence carries it off somewhere quiet. Under pressure a man grabs the escape he trusts, and after twenty years he calls it his personality. Way back, a boy figured out how to stop feeling something, and the trick became a groove. Block the groove he likes and the pain cuts a new one. Owen used all three in under a week.

I've felt every one of these tug at me. I won't soften any of them, and I won't use them to shame you. Shame is lighter fluid on all three.

The drift

Absence is the soft escape. I keep the closest eye on it in men past their peak working years, because nothing looks wrong and nobody's sounding an alarm.

The drifting man leaves without going anywhere. He shows up at home and at work. Nothing has exploded, nothing has been found out. He's just not there. His wife quit asking after the answers dried up into "fine." His kids learn that a father can occupy a couch and still be missing. The chair we looked at earlier, the one that looked occupied and wasn't, gets built exactly this way.

There's usually an injury under it. Somewhere along the way, without saying so, he decided caring was too expensive. Or he was truly worn out, and resting turned by inches into withdrawing. Solomon watched it happen to a house.

Ecclesiastes 10:18 NIV

Through laziness, the rafters sag; because of idle hands, the house leaks.

No one stomped through that ceiling. It leaked because the ladder stayed in the garage and the recliner stayed occupied. By the time someone says out loud that you've drifted, the water stain is already spreading.

If this is your escape, own it to your wife, or to whoever shares your roof. "I'm sorry. My body's been here and I haven't." None of it is news to her. Hearing it from you shifts the whole house. No wife? Tell a brother, since unwitnessed drift just keeps going. Then win back one habit. One evening a week, screens dark and your mind present. One question a day, and you stay until the answer is all the way out. And go find the boy who quit caring because it cost too much. A brother or a good counselor can help you look. That's the ladder.

The itch

The downward escape is appetite. Sex has the strongest hold, so I'll spend my time there, though the same itch drives the drink, the online cart, the betting app, and the feed that never hits bottom. Comfort on a short fuse. No demands. No witnesses.

Behind that bathroom door, Owen wasn't really chasing pleasure. He was chasing relief. Relief from the numbers. Relief from the hush he'd caused in his own kitchen. The screen asked nothing of him, least of all to be a man. That's the hook: a place where nobody needs you. And the lie lives right next to it, because being needed as a man is the very thing that would start to heal him. James describes the slide.

James 1:14-15 NIV

but each person is tempted when they are dragged away by their own evil desire and enticed. Then, after desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and sin, when it is full-grown, gives birth to death.

Dragged. That's how it feels. Nobody plans on two in the morning. And the death at the end is rarely a headline. It's a slow leak. His attention dies, then his hunger for an actual woman, then his ability to hold his wife's gaze. She knows something's off long before she could name it.

Paul's word to the church at Corinth was flee. Joseph sprinted out of a house because a woman inside wanted him. That's the speed. If this is your escape, the work starts with one brother and the full story: what, how often, how long, what it's cost. No hiding behind "I struggle with purity." This thing feeds on secrecy, and once another man knows, it begins to starve. Next, cut off the supply. Filters on every screen, passwords in his hands, your phone charging in the kitchen overnight. You'd do as much for a kid in middle school. Do it for the grown man who acts like one after everybody's asleep. Then go after the loneliness underneath, which was always the real issue. There's more on brothers further on. Short version: a man who's known itches less.

Anger

Most men's favorite escape is anger, because anger looks like strength.

Peel it back and there's usually fear, or shame, or plain helplessness underneath. Money that won't stretch. A particular thing he's ashamed of. Something he loves cracking where he can't reach. Every one of those feels like weakness in the gut, and anger feels like power, so he snatches it the way a freezing man snatches the nearest coat. That dishwasher didn't slam itself because of a bad load. It slammed because of a lost contract.

God's Word takes it for granted that you'll get angry. What it watches is what comes next. Paul gave the Ephesians a deadline.

Ephesians 4:26-27 NIV

"In your anger do not sin": Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold.

Look where it starts: you're already mad. Then the deadline: sunset. Then the risk: a foothold. Sleep on it, wake up with it, carry it to bed again, and the enemy has wedged his boot in the doorway. Your temper becomes the climate your kids grow

up in.

If this is your escape, here's the work. Learn ninety seconds. A surge of anger, left unfed, peaks and starts falling in less than two minutes. So walk to the mailbox and back. Leave the loaded sentence in the chamber. When you come back inside, say the thing under it. "I'm scared about money." A wife can plan with a man who admits he's afraid. Settle it while it's still daylight. A man who learns that becomes the calmest person in his house.

Your season, your escape

The season changes the costume. The doors stay unlocked.

If you're the guy everyone says is killing it, look again. The itch can pass for ambition, and the drift can pass for being laid-back.

Older men, watch for anger and absence traveling as a pair. They usually park themselves in front of the TV. One night this week, turn it off after supper, ask her one real question, and let her finish.

The first stretch after a divorce can fling all three doors open at once. Rage aimed at her. A loneliness you never used to know, feeding appetite. Absence, because caring is how you got hurt. Healing, when it comes, often wears the face of an older brother who phones every Thursday and won't settle for "fine."

New dads, anger will ambush you. Three in the morning, a baby who won't stop, and a voice comes out of you that you last heard from your father. Take your ninety seconds. Then tell your wife the honest thing: you're tired enough that you frighten yourself.

Young and single, the itch is probably loudest. Keep an eye on the drift as well: a job you don't care about, every evening surrendered to scrolling. Numb at twenty-two isn't calm. It's a dashboard light.

The same root

The angry man was wounded by fear as a boy, so he swapped it for something that passed for power. The man with the itch learned no one was going to see him, so he bought comfort that never asks your name. The drifting man learned what caring costs and closed the account. Different doors, one purpose: don't feel the chair. Different doors, one result: he's gone from his own house.

Jesus never used any of these exits. He was angry without sinning. He was

tempted at every point, and He never took the downward way out. The night before the cross, everything in Him wanted another road, and He said “not as I will,” and stayed. If you’ve already gone out one of these doors, He can meet you on the other side and walk you home without shame.

White-knuckling it hasn’t worked, and you know that. Take the pain somewhere it can heal instead of somewhere it can go numb. There’s a Father who stays. Your anger doesn’t rattle Him. Your itch doesn’t repel Him. He didn’t drift away when you did.

Owen’s mailbox

One quiet night Owen put the numbers on the table in front of his wife. He told her he’d been afraid for three weeks, and that the fear had come out at the dishwasher, behind the bathroom door, and on the couch. She’d already sensed something. The fear itself she could stand inside with him. His absence was the part that had hurt them.

She didn’t say any of that gently. She was angry the first night, and not about the contract. She’d spent three weeks in a house with a man who wasn’t in it. He took it without a defense. It was most of a week before the kitchen felt like theirs again.

The good kind of quiet came back eventually, and he walked to the mailbox and back. He’d said the true sentence. The contract was still gone. He just wasn’t hiding from it in his own house anymore.

Before you turn the page

Your escape has a name now, and you can hand a named thing to your Father. May He meet you at the mailbox, at the screen, at the couch. And may the first small no you say this week turn into a habit.

09 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

You'll keep calling it your personality until you admit it's an escape. Write one complete sentence that begins "When things get heavy, I," and name yours: the drift, the itch, or anger.

DO THIS WEEK

Each escape has a first step that fits in seven days. For the drift, one dark-screen evening fully present, plus one question you wait out to the end. For the itch, one man who hears everything and holds the passwords. For anger, the mailbox walk, then the sentence under it.

TELL A BROTHER

Secrecy is what keeps these escapes alive. Tell him yours and the last time you used it. Ask for his. Neither of you is allowed to say "I'm fine."

CARRY THIS

Every escape walks you out of your own house. Pain was looking for a Father, and an exit was the wrong address.



CHAPTER 10

The Father Who Does Not Leave

Three o'clock at any elementary school, the doors bang open and a few hundred kids pour out hunting for exactly one vehicle. Watch their faces. The ones who spot their ride go loose all over. A backpack swings. They're halfway through a story before they've buckled in. Then there are the few still scanning. Minivan, not theirs. Pickup, not theirs. One of them winds up on the curb next to a teacher who keeps glancing at her watch.

Curtis is in that line every afternoon. Twenty minutes early, engine off, radio off. Years ago he swore none of his kids would ever be the one on the curb, and not once have they been. What he's never had is the other side of it: walking out a door and seeing somebody already waiting for him. Nobody came for Curtis. He learned the way home on foot.

This chapter is about a Father who's already parked out front when the bell rings. But for plenty of men, the word father is where the trouble begins, so we'll begin there too.

A borrowed picture

Tell a man "God is your Father" and he'll hear it through whoever sat at the end of his childhood table.

If that seat was empty, father means someone who doesn't show. God exists the way your dad exists. Out there somewhere. Occupied. Not here.

If the seat held a silent man, father means someone in the room with nothing to say to you. Prayer starts to feel like leaving voicemails on a line that's been disconnected.

If the seat was dangerous, father means you check his mood before you speak. Faith turns into a daily inspection for whatever God is upset about, and you've got a

strong hunch it's you.

If the seat held a good man, you started ahead of most. Still, good dads get worn out and miss things, and somewhere under your prayers sits a guess that God will miss things too.

I've prayed to a copy and called it faith. We hold our fathers up to heaven like a photograph and assume God must look like that, and it's spoiled a lot of prayers. Scripture flips the order. God is the original. Your dad was a copy, sometimes a decent one and sometimes a terrible one. Set the copy face down on the table. If you want to see the original, exactly one Man has, and when Philip asked Him to show it, here's what He said.

John 14:9 NIV

Don't you know me, Philip, even after I have been among you such a long time? Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father. How can you say, 'Show us the Father'?

Want to know what the Father's like? Watch Jesus.

Love before the work

Jesus hadn't preached a sermon yet. He hadn't healed anyone or called a single disciple. He came up out of the river, wet from His baptism, and heaven spoke.

Matthew 3:17 NIV

And a voice from heaven said, "This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased."

Notice the order. No assignment came first, and no audition. The Father claimed His Son out loud, called Him loved, called Him a delight, and the public work came after. That's how it runs in God's house: blessing, then work. Some of you had a dad who made you earn every scrap of approval, and the scraps were thin. This Father doesn't operate that way. If you're in Christ, that same voice of love and delight has already spoken over you. You didn't earn it, and a bad week doesn't cancel it. If you've got a newborn, watch yourself at the crib. You adore that baby, and he hasn't done one useful thing. That's how the Father sees you.

He carries, and He stays

Moses described God carrying His people the way a dad carries his little boy, mile after mile, through the heavy years too. He knows what you need before you say it, and your needing doesn't annoy Him. If needing anybody used to be dangerous for you, slow down and let that land. When He corrects you, it's because you belong to

Him. Hebrews calls hard seasons evidence that you're a son. Correction and rage are not the same thing. If He's correcting you, He hasn't left.

And He won't leave. Scripture promises that more than once. On the last night before the cross, with His friends about to see Him dragged away, Jesus said it like this.

John 14:18 NIV

I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you.

Orphans. He picked the word on purpose, because that's what they were about to feel. Some of you have felt it since second grade. His answer to orphans is Himself. He comes. If your marriage is over, you may need this more than anybody. The Father didn't walk out when the marriage did. Some of you quit praying because you figured His disappointment had joined the pile. He never stopped watching for you.

Learning the receiving end

You'd expect this to be the light chapter. For a lot of men it's the heaviest. If you raised yourself, you never got to practice being anyone's son. You can sign off on every doctrine and still lock up the moment the load is supposed to shift onto someone else's shoulders. After enough years alone, leaning feels like falling.

Curtis put it plainly. "I believe God's my Father. I just don't know how to be somebody's son. I never got to be on the receiving end." I'd rather have that than something polished. Men who learn sonship late usually get there through a few simple habits.

Use the name. Keep "God" and "Lord" for your other prayers if you like, but somewhere every day, call Him Father, out loud, alone, while it's still awkward. Paul says the Spirit in you is already calling out "Abba, Father," and Abba is what a small boy calls his dad. You have permission. It'll feel odd. Push through until it doesn't. If you're older and have never once said it, give it a week of feeling silly. After that it starts to feel warm, like your hands thawing when you come in from the cold.

Take Him your escape, whichever one it is. He hears it before any brother or counselor, and He hears it raw. "Father, I'm close to losing it with the kids." "Father, I'm about to pick up that phone." The One listening has been watching for you a long time.

Let Him name you. Each day, read something God says about His children and answer back as though it's true of you, because it is. A man who was never told who

he is needs to hear it over and over. The Father doesn't get tired of saying it.

Let yourself be carried. Sometime this year a load will come that's heavier than you are, and every reflex will say grind it out alone. Pray the opposite, out loud: "This is too heavy for me. Carry it, and carry me." Then let a brother take a corner. Every man is a son before he's anything else, and learning that order is the work.

Stay close to home. His Word is where He speaks. His church is where the rest of His kids gather. Prayer is where He listens. Show up only at Christmas and Easter, and His voice will stay a stranger's on an ordinary Wednesday.

Your dad, seen again

Once God starts fathering you, the man who raised you, or didn't, looks different. Sometimes sharper, and sharper can sting. You quit squeezing him into a shape he never had, and you quit searching his face for it. If you're young and certain you don't need another father, learn this now and skip twenty years of searching faces. You can thank him for what was good, name what hurt, and put down the rage. Forgiveness opens up once you no longer need him to pay you back. You might even reach toward him someday. We'll walk that road later on. But none of it opens while you're still trying to pull out of your dad what only your heavenly Father has. That old chair was always too small for the hollow place in your chest. He's the only one who fits it.

Before the bell

Curtis started practicing in the pickup line. Alone in a parked car, the awkwardness cost him nothing. "Father." The first few days it felt like talking to the dashboard. He kept going, one sentence each afternoon. Somewhere in the second week it stopped feeling like talking to glass. It felt like there was somebody in the passenger seat.

Then one day his youngest burst through the doors, looked down the line, saw their car, and quit searching. Curtis watched that small face change and realized what was being held out to him. For years he'd been the dad holding a place in line. He had never once been the kid who finds his ride. Now he was being told that part was his too.

Jesus told a story about a father like that, whose son blew everything and came home with an apology rehearsed. Look where the father is.

Luke 15:20 NIV

But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him.

A long way off. You only catch someone that far down the road if you've been watching it. In that culture, grown men didn't run. This one did. You don't have to clean up before He comes for you.

That's the Father's work in a man. The searching can stop. The tryout can stop. Your place with Him was settled in His Son, and today's performance was never the verdict. If your career is soaring, hear that one slowly: a title is not a Father, and neither is applause. John marveled at how much the Father loves us, enough to call us His children, and said that's exactly what we are. He was in the line before the bell. Let your shoulders drop. You've been found.

Before you turn the page

He knows sons learn slowly. Say the word clumsily tomorrow morning, and again the morning after. May the Father who kept His eyes on the road for the prodigal keep them on you. And this week, walk out those doors and look for the One who's already waiting.

10 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Your prayers will keep landing on a false picture until you notice you're holding one. Which is yours: the dad who never came, the silent one, the dangerous one, or the good one with gaps? Then write one true thing Jesus shows you about the Father.

DO THIS WEEK

You learn to be a son by talking like one. Every morning, before your feet touch the floor, say "Father" out loud and give Him one sentence about the day ahead. Seven mornings straight.

TELL A BROTHER

Letting another man pray over you is practice in being carried. Tell him which false father your prayers have been aimed at. Then ask him to pray for you, out loud, right there, and don't wave him off.

CARRY THIS

You learned the word father from a copy. The original was in the line before the bell.



CHAPTER 11

When Home Never Handed You Off

Saturday mornings, Nate is at his dad's house with a toolbox. He's got kids in high school and two work vans with his name painted on the doors, and he's still the one on his back under the sink while his father leans over him and narrates. The old man doesn't say "good." He says "should've used a longer screw." When Nate finishes a project at his own place, he snaps a picture and texts it over. A correction comes back, every single time. The next time, he sends the picture anyway.

His older brother went the other way out of that same kitchen. The summer after graduation he walked out in the middle of a shouting match, and he's spent the years since proving something to a father he barely talks to. One son slammed the door. The other one never quite made it through. Ask either of them what day he became a man and you'll get a long pause.

Most of us crossed over like a two-lane road crosses a county line. No ribbon, no one waving, a little green sign you miss if you reach for your coffee. One day there were house payments, or a duty belt, or a baby asleep on our chest, and some quiet part of us still wondered if anybody had ever counted us in. I know that pause. I'm not writing this from the far bank.

Counterfeits

When nobody hands a boy across, the hunger doesn't go away. He goes shopping, and the shelf is full.

Usually he tries a girl first, though she never signed up to make him a man. Then a paycheck, but a boy on a man's wage is still a boy cashing a check. Then the big gesture: the fistfight, the night he drinks too much, the birthday that was supposed to change everything, the exit halfway through an argument. That's Nate's brother. He's trying to throw himself a pass, and nobody can.

Nate took the quieter road. Call it the orbit. All week his crews build on his word,

and one text from his father can still tell him whether the work was any good. A grown man can circle the house he grew up in for decades, waiting for someone inside to say he can stop. And it costs him, because a man who isn't sure he's a man won't shoulder a man's load. He's still waiting to hear it's his. Nearly everything else in this book sits on top of that one missing sentence.

The woman who kept the porch light on

Home isn't only a father. For plenty of men the house that never sent them out was held together by a mother. She packed the lunches and sat in the bleachers and prayed when nobody else did. Maybe she did it alone.

She is not the villain here. A lot of mothers kept a boy close because he was what they had left to hold, and because no man ever showed up to walk him the rest of the way. That's a gap, not a crime. A mother can love her son right up to the edge. Calling him over it was never meant to be her job alone.

But I'll say the hard part as a man who knows the pull to sit still. You can't wait on her to push you out either. If you're forty and her worry still makes your decisions, or you still hide at her table when life gets rough, that's on you now. Love her. Call her Sunday. And quit sitting on your hands until somebody grants permission.

Jacob at the river

One man in Genesis tried the counterfeit route harder than any of us. Jacob wanted his father's blessing so badly he wore his brother's clothes, lied to a blind old man, and ran off with the words. Two decades of scheming followed. A stolen blessing turned out to make a fugitive, not a man.

Then, alone on the road home, a Man took hold of him and they wrestled till sunup. Jacob finally quit working an angle and just hung on.

Genesis 32:26 NIV

Then the man said, "Let me go, for it is daybreak." But Jacob replied, "I will not let you go unless you bless me."

He asked instead of grabbing. He got a new name and a limp, and the swagger was gone for good. In the morning he walked out to face Esau with a man's walk. God gave him in the dirt what all his scheming never got out of Isaac, and he was no young man by then. If it's dark where you're standing, you haven't missed it.

What fathers once did

Jacob got it late, straight from God. It was supposed to come early, through men. For most of history, a boy didn't decide alone that he'd grown up. Older men decided it with him. He woke up counted, because they'd said it out loud and nobody was joking.

Watch an old king do it from his deathbed.

1 Kings 2:2-3 NIV

"I am about to go the way of all the earth," he said. "So be strong, act like a man, and observe what the LORD your God requires: Walk in obedience to him, and keep his decrees and commands, his laws and regulations, as written in the Law of Moses. Do this so that you may prosper in all you do and wherever you go

David on his way out. Words with a spine in them. A kingdom set in Solomon's hands, God's law at its center. Paul did the same for Timothy, and he used his hands.

2 Timothy 1:6 NIV

For this reason I remind you to fan into flame the gift of God, which is in you through the laying on of my hands.

Nobody in that room needed it explained. You're with us. Here's your work. Years later, worn thin and scared, Timothy got a letter sending him back to that day.

Most of us never stood in a room like that. Some got the chores without the words, a dad loading you up before you needed to shave and never once calling it grown-up work. Some got the words without the weight, like the father who announced you'd be running the house now, right as he walked out for good.

Getting it now

The Father goes first. In Christ He's already said who you are, before you've earned a thing: this is my son, and I love him. The word your dad held back has been spoken from heaven. Build on anything else and it'll shift. If a divorce left you feeling your manhood went out with the settlement, a judge didn't overrule the Father, and what you carry is still a man's weight.

Young men need this next part most and get it least. Find someone older who's living what these pages describe and say the clumsy sentence: "Nobody ever told me I was a man. Would you?" Expect a hand on your shoulder while he answers. Lots of gray-haired men have gone their whole lives without anyone asking them something that mattered.

Let a few brothers claim you. If none ever has, go looking for a circle that will.

And take up a man's load before you feel ready. That's Stop Waiting, aimed at your own manhood. Solomon was young and frightened and told God so, and his father's word was still "act like a man." Acting was part of the growing. Give it a year and your feelings will catch up to a life that's already moving.

Write down a date, too. Whichever day it was: when you trusted Christ, when that older voice finally spoke, or when you asked God for it at two in the morning. Jacob limped away. You can carry a date inked inside your Bible's cover, so you're not left half-wondering whether you ever crossed.

When Dad won't

Some fathers never will, and it isn't because you came up short. Maybe nobody handed him off either. Maybe keeping you small is how he still feels big. You can honor him and quit orbiting in the same week (we're about to take up that honor). The drive over just stops being a trip to collect a sentence. You go because he's your dad. The sentence itself you get from the Father, and from older brothers in Christ who'll speak up.

Nate got his at a utility sink. A gray-haired guy from church had asked him to help put in a water heater, and afterward, both of them scrubbing up, he said, "I've had my eye on you for years. You're a good man. There's nothing I've got I wouldn't trust you with." Nate didn't answer. He dried his hands twice. It hadn't come from his father's chair. It came from someone willing to stand where his father wouldn't, and God still puts men like that near the sons who ask.

If you're the older man, you're half of how this gets fixed. You've seen it in somebody younger and kept quiet. Speak. Scripture's handoffs rarely needed a stage. A sink will do.

Saturdays now

Nate still drives over Saturdays, and his dad still narrates. It just lands differently, because Nate isn't going for the sentence anymore. He's going for his father. The week after the water heater he called his brother, and for once the old fight didn't get on the line with them.

You belong among the men. The Father said it first. Find a man who'll say it where you can hear, and then say it to someone else. If you have a son, start with him. A dad who was never handed off can still hand off his boy, and the giving

reaches a sore spot nothing he received ever touched.

Before you turn the page

If nobody has ever said it to you, I will: you're a man. And long before me, the Father who opened the sky over Jesus at the river said something like it over you. May God give you enough nerve to ask, even clumsily, and enough plain courage to tell a younger man what you see in him.

11 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

If you can't point to the day somebody counted you in, you're probably still waiting out at the county line. Say who counted you and when. Or say the plain truth, that nobody ever did. Then say what you did with that: walked out swinging, started circling, or settled in at your mother's table.

DO THIS WEEK

Somebody has to ask and somebody has to offer, and you're standing at one end of that. Younger? Go to an older man whose life looks like these pages and ask him straight: when you look at me, do you see a man? Take whatever answer he gives. Older? Pick a younger guy and tell him one specific thing you've seen him do that only a grown man does.

TELL A BROTHER

A date that only you know about tends to fade with the years. Let him know if anyone ever counted you in. Show him the date going in your Bible, and explain what it marks.

CARRY THIS

Nobody hands himself off. The Father has already spoken, and He still sends men to say it out loud.



CHAPTER 12

Leave Without Slamming the Door

Watch three grown sons walk up to the house they were raised in, and you'll learn most of what you need to know.

The first one doesn't bother knocking. He's got gray coming in on his chin and a mortgage on the other side of town, and he's got the fridge open before anybody says hello, while his wife is still standing out on the step. The second one hasn't come up those steps in years. He can still quote the argument that ended it, and he calls the distance freedom. The house still owns him. The third one might have a key on his ring. He knocks anyway, waits, and when it swings open he says, "Hey, Dad."

Only that third man has gone. The other two are stuck at the threshold, one gripping the knob and one with his back to it, and neither can see it. Knuckles on wood, then waiting. There are two halves to that, and God wrote one of them on stone at Sinai, where no son could miss it.

Exodus 20:12 NIV

Honor your father and your mother, so that you may live long in the land the LORD your God is giving you.

But the other half goes back further, to the first pages, and God says it about a grown son.

Genesis 2:24 NIV

That is why a man leaves his father and mother and is united to his wife, and they become one flesh.

Notice that the going comes before the wedding. A single guy is under this verse too. He doesn't need a ring to be told it's time.

Side by side, it's one motion with two hands. Slam it and you're out, but the honor got dropped on the porch. Grip the knob forever and you've kept something like honor, but you never went anywhere. God wants a son who does both at once.

A knock says it without a speech: I live somewhere else now, and I'm glad you answered.

The slam

Start with the man whose back is turned. Some of you got out of houses no kid should have grown up in. I won't send you back there, and I'll never point you toward someone who's still dangerous. But I've seen what years of a slam do to a man.

That door doesn't stay behind you. Rage is its own kind of attention. The dad you cut off rides along into every room, and pretty soon your whole life is arranged around not being him. You're more tied to him than any Sunday phone call would have made you. You just can't see the rope, because anger braided it.

Your kids are taking notes on how a son treats his dad. That's the playbook they'll grab later. Contempt you show now gets stored up for when you're the one in the recliner. Respect given to a father who never earned it teaches them something no pastor can.

Honor without pretending

Honor goes to the office, not the report card. Scripture never asks you to call a bad dad good, and it never asks you to lie about him.

Picture a lieutenant saluting a colonel he can't stand. He salutes the eagles on the collar, and the salute is still clean.

With a hard dad, honor gets practical. You tell the truth about him without making him a joke. You help look after him when he's old, even if he never looked after you. And you pray, even if all that comes out is, "Lord, I don't even know what to ask for him. You know him."

Forgiveness lives in there too. What he did was real, and God knows exactly how heavy it was. Trust is a separate call. You can forgive him and still never leave your kids alone in his house. Some tables aren't safe, and some never will be. Forgiving means handing the debt to God and quitting the collection business. Your peace stops hanging on a sorry that may never come.

Romans 12:19 NIV

Do not take revenge, my dear friends, but leave room for God's wrath, for it is written: "It is mine to avenge; I will repay," says the Lord.

There's relief in that verse. Getting even was never your job.

Joseph's brothers threw him in a pit and sold him to strangers. Years later he held every card, and what he told them is the cleanest picture I know of this kind of forgiveness.

Genesis 50:20 NIV

You intended to harm me, but God intended it for good to accomplish what is now being done, the saving of many lives.

He didn't soften it. You meant this for evil. Then he pointed to what God had built out of it. He told the truth about the hurt, trusted God with the rest, and never slid an invoice across the table.

The grip

Now the other man, who's sure all this is for somebody louder. If your mom's opinion still beats your wife's in your own kitchen, you're still holding the knob. If one remark from your dad can shrink you back to twelve, and you plan your choices to dodge it, you're holding the knob. Thirty-five, single, and every big decision still clears Sunday dinner? Same. Moving across town didn't change it. Divorce makes the pull strongest, straight back to Mom's table, where her kindness can become your hiding place. She'll make room because she loves you. Building a life is still on you.

Their advice is a gift your whole life, and a wise man keeps asking. But a man whose center of gravity sits in somebody else's kitchen never grows his own, and his kids need a dad whose direction starts with him.

You don't need a fight to do this well. Decide, then tell them. Ask first and you've handed it back. "I love you, and this is how we're doing it." The leaving verse names a mother too, including one who raised you by herself, and under your roof your wife now comes ahead of both. If Mom has a comment about your wife, you stand in that gap, even on days she's partly right. When a baby comes and the grandparents come with it, you leave all over again, and you learn to say where your mother can hear, "We're going with my wife on this one." Keep your voice low and your back straight.

Grant's porch

Grant's father never once said anything kind to his son, and Grant had slammed that door hard years before. When he finally went back, the engine ticked in the driveway a long time before he got out. His dad opened up and didn't speak. Grant said what he'd come to say and then went quiet. There was no apology. Nothing about being proud of him. The old man stared out over the road at the pasture for a while. Then: "You eat yet?" He turned and headed in, and didn't shut the door. Grant went in after him. That supper, he told me, was about as close to a hug as his dad could manage. Grant was grateful for it. He'd quit asking the old man for what wasn't in him.

What did Grant say? Not much, because one sentence lands where ten bounce off, and his was the thing he'd needed and never gotten: "Dad, I always wanted you to be proud of me, and I never heard it." He didn't make an apology the price of coming back. What his dad did with it was his dad's business.

If your father's alive and it's safe, there may be a porch like that waiting for you. That holds for a man in his fifties too, the one whose father is failing and who comes home from every visit feeling twelve. Some men should leave it alone, because a few conversations only rip open what God is already closing. But a lot of men have stood out there for years without lifting a hand. And if he's gone, or too dangerous to go near, say it anyway. God hears it. So does a brother. It needs to come out of you even if it can't get to him.

Knock on the way home

This door asks something of both men. The one gripping the knob has waited years for letting go to feel right, and it won't, so he opens his hand anyway. The one who slammed it left behind the honor he owed. His dad dropped plenty, but that piece is still his to carry. That's Pick Up the Weight, on your parents' front steps. Neither one should wait for the other side to move. And both can quit holding out for his apology to make them whole. What you needed from a father, you already have from the One who adopted you.

He was your dad, whatever kind he was, and the way you treat him now shows on you. Go gently. Pull it closed so it barely clicks. Come back and knock. Then build a house with a door your boy can knock on someday.

And if you're already the dad inside, whose boy stormed off or just faded out, be the father in Jesus' story who went out after both sons. Make the call he doesn't

return. If you let him down, say so once: “I let you down when you needed me. I’m sorry.” When he shows up, pull out a chair.

Before you turn the page

Be honest with God about your dad, and give Him what’s owed. Honor the office as you go, and close the door quietly. May the Father who never walked out on you steady your steps, give you grace for whatever knock comes later, and let your kids learn from you, someday, how to go from your house well.

12 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

You can botch this from either side of the door and never know which side you're on. Which one is you, the slam or the grip? Then say what it has cost you, your marriage, or your kids.

DO THIS WEEK

Leaving and honoring both happen in specific acts, not in good intentions. If you never really left, decide one thing this week without running it past your parents, then tell them, kindly, after. If you slammed it, pray for your dad by name every day, and if he's living and it's safe, circle a day on the calendar for the porch.

TELL A BROTHER

Put the conversation on another man's calendar too, and you'll actually have it. Tell him about your father and about which way you've gotten this wrong. If a porch is coming, give him the date.

CARRY THIS

You can leave home without slamming the door. Give God the debt, and knock when you come back.



CHAPTER 13

A Man With No Brothers

The form wanted two names.

It was a little past two in the morning, and Dale was sitting on the edge of an ER bed in a paper gown that didn't close. For three hours the tightness behind his ribs had seemed like the end of the world. Then the tests came back, and it was nothing. A nurse handed him the intake sheet on a clipboard and went to find a blanket. He wrote his wife's name on the first line without thinking. The second line asked for an emergency contact who wasn't his spouse. He held the pen over it. Nothing came.

His phone had hundreds of contacts. Guys he sold to and bought from. Guys from deer camp. Guys from church. His wife's brother, a couple of states away. His pastor. Any of them would've shown up with a truck to help him move a couch. Not one was a man he could call at that hour and say, "I'm scared."

Years later he told me about it, and his voice went flat. "I had no idea I was alone until the night I needed someone."

Buddies and brothers

If you're thinking this chapter's for some other guy, it's probably for you. Most men don't have brothers. Not in the way that counts. They have buddies, and that's a different job. A buddy is the guy next to you while you're doing something: hunting, fishing, eighteen holes, a game on the big screen. Good men, good times, and none of it is the same as being known. In a lot of marriages the wife ends up as the only person who really knows her husband, and that's more than one person was ever meant to hold. Then he retires from the crew he saw every day, or he buries her, and finds out how quiet a house can get.

Try this on. If your phone rang in the middle of the night, whose name could be on it, and whose number could you dial? Who has permission to tell you, face to face, that you're wrong? Who knows what actually scares you? Ask a room full of

capable men and listen to it go quiet, even though every phone in there is full.

None of this was the design. On the Bible's second page, the first thing God calls not good is a man by himself. His first answer was a wife, and she stays the first answer. But all through the story, men walk next to other men too. David had Jonathan. Jesus had twelve, and three of them closer still. The Teacher in Ecclesiastes says it plainest.

Ecclesiastes 4:9-10 NIV

Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor: If either of them falls down, one can help the other up. But pity anyone who falls and has no one to help them up.

That last line was Dale, pen in hand, on a gurney.

Even Jesus asked

Look at those three closest men on Jesus' last night. He took them along to pray, knowing one of them would swear he'd never met Him before sunup. He brought them anyway, and He asked them for something.

Mark 14:34 NIV

"My soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death," he said to them. "Stay here and keep watch."

The Son of God, who needed nothing from anybody, wanted three friends awake beside Him in the darkest hour He'd ever face. He wouldn't go through it alone. You don't get an exemption He turned down.

The reasons we give

I've asked a lot of guys why that second line stays empty, and I've used most of their answers myself. "I'm fine." That's pride in work clothes. Nobody's fine. "I don't have time." You do; nobody's asked you for a slice thin enough. "I don't want to be a burden." Under that there's often a boy who learned that needing people wasn't safe and decided he'd sink before he'd reach. "Men don't do this." For most of history they did, and when they quit, a slow, quiet dying set in that we decided to call independence. "I got burned." Some of you really did, and I'm sorry. But one bad meal is a thin reason never to eat again. "I've got my wife." Keep her close. She's called to know you, just never to be the only one, and carrying that by herself wears a woman down over the years. Ask her whether it has.

What a brother does

David is on the run, a king hunting him, exhausted and hiding out in the woods. And somebody comes looking for him.

1 Samuel 23:16 NIV

And Saul's son Jonathan went to David at Horesh and helped him find strength in God.

Jonathan didn't bring an army, and he couldn't call off the hunt. The hunter was his own father. He walked out to Horesh regardless, and he pointed David back to God. That's the job. A brother can't fix your life. He can walk you back to the One who holds it.

He also knows where you go when the day turns sour, whether that's anger or a screen or just going silent, and he asks about it. He doesn't steer around the locked rooms: the money, the marriage, the bedroom, whatever your eyes landed on this week, whether you've prayed. You tell him the truth because he asked. If the hospital calls at two in the morning, he's in the waiting room, because to him brother isn't a figure of speech. And when it's his turn, he tells you the truth, kindly, once, with no watered-down version.

Proverbs 27:17 NIV

As iron sharpens iron, so one person sharpens another.

Iron on iron throws sparks. Something he says is going to sting. You walk away with an edge.

One man like that. Two, tops. He might send you to a counselor and still be your brother after. And the guy you have the most fun with isn't always the guy you can trust with the truth.

Kenny's phone

Kenny found out what one man is worth the first year after his marriage ended. He was in a one-bedroom apartment with a mattress and a folding chair, and most of the friends had gone with the house. They'd mostly been hers, or the guys didn't know what to say. An older man from church started calling him once a week. Same time. He'd ask how things were, what was weighing on him, what Kenny planned to do before they talked again, and then he'd pray. Most weeks Kenny said "nothing." The man called again the next week anyway.

These days, every Tuesday, Kenny calls his son. You can draw a line from that

older man's phone to Kenny's.

If you're divorced and your church has not known which row to put you in since, don't wait around for someone to fix the seating chart. You don't need a program. You need one man who calls.

Twenty minutes

Most men want this. What they don't have is a version that fits the week they're actually living. Everything on offer is too big: a six a.m. breakfast, a group with workbooks, a weekend retreat. A guy with a newborn or a business going under looks at that, knows he can't, and does nothing.

So shrink it. One man, twenty minutes, every week, on the same day at the same hour. The sameness matters; a call you keep rescheduling eventually stops happening.

You don't need a script, but you need a direction, or you'll be talking trucks and ball scores inside eleven minutes. Catch each other up on what actually mattered, not the highlight reel. Then get to the part that earns the call, what's heavy and the fear underneath it, while whoever's listening just listens; fixing isn't tonight's job. Before you hang up, each of you says out loud one thing you'll do by next time, and next time that's the first thing you ask. Spend the last couple of minutes praying for each other, out loud.

There'll be weeks when one of you is falling apart and the heavy part eats all twenty. Fine. That's why it's a floor, and the floor doesn't move.

Twenty minutes fits inside April for an accountant, a double shift, a round of chemo, a funeral week. A dad with a newborn doesn't have thirty, which is why it's twenty; he can make the call with his hands in the dishwasher. I've never known a guy who truly couldn't spare twenty. I've known lots who couldn't spare two hours, so they spared nothing. Twenty is a seed.

Finding him

Look for someone who's mostly living what this book is about. He's probably already at your church or on your crew, and nobody's ever asked him anything real. A guy can share a kitchen with three roommates and still have nobody who knows him, so don't assume the one across the hall counts until you've asked. Same age is fine. A little older is often better. Skip your boss, anybody who reports to you, and your brother-in-law; you need to say anything without a paycheck or a Thanksgiving

riding on it. And the team you lead at work, good as they are, isn't this.

Then ask in plain English. "I'm working on growing up as a man, and I've realized nobody really knows me. Could we talk twenty minutes a week for three months and just see?" A three-month window makes yes easy, and makes stopping easy if it flops. Usually it doesn't, and by the end neither of you remembers there was an exit.

It'll be awkward, then it won't. He's been hoping somebody would ask. Men are lonely, and almost none of them will make the first move. You will. That's Go First, with a phone in your hand.

The second line

Dale has a brother now. It took him most of a year to ask. The man had been sitting a few pews over for twenty years, and in all that time they'd never had one real conversation. Now they talk Thursdays, on Dale's drive home. For the first month Dale was sure he'd signed up for the dumbest thing he'd ever done. Last spring he went in for a scheduled surgery and somebody handed him another clipboard. When he got to the second line, he didn't stop writing.

Before you turn the page

Asking might be the most awkward sentence you'll ever say out loud. But nearly every man who's said it gets some version of the same answer: "I was hoping somebody would ask." May the Father give you the nerve to make the call, and may the man who answers turn out to be a brother who shows up when it's bad.

13 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

A man can go half his life without noticing that if he went down, nobody's phone would ring. Fill in the line out loud: "If I fell tonight, I could call _." If it's blank, or the only name is your wife's, you know why this chapter found you.

DO THIS WEEK

Nobody's going to volunteer, and asking is how it works. Pick the man and make the ask before Sunday. Tell him nobody really knows you, and ask for twenty minutes a week for three months. Settle the day and the time before you hang up.

TELL A BROTHER

The brother you'd tell might not exist yet. If he does, show him the twenty minutes and start this week. If he doesn't, the ask is your whole assignment, and if it feels awkward, you've picked the right sentence.

CARRY THIS

One man, twenty minutes, every week. Same hour, no matter what.



CHAPTER 14

Ask the Man

When Travis was young, he had a theory that if you could catch a long-married man after church before he got to his truck, he could tell you how it was done in a sentence or two. One Sunday he tried it on Harlan, who'd been married longer than Travis had been alive. Travis caught him at his driver's door, and he still tells me he doesn't know where he got the nerve.

Harlan studied him for a second, the way you size up a board before you cut it. Then he said, "Ride with me Saturday."

So that Saturday Travis sat in the passenger seat of the truck Harlan hauled feed in and rode his whole route. Around noon Harlan pulled in for fuel and went to the pay phone. He called his wife and told her what town he was in and what time he'd be pulling into the driveway. Travis found out later he'd made that call every working day since they got married. Travis rode two more Saturdays. That cab taught him more about marriage than every sermon he'd sat through.

There's a man somewhere around twenty years farther down your road. He's already been through what you're walking into. He's closer than you think. And the asking is on you.

Both of you are waiting

The young man has reasons for keeping quiet. The older guy looks too busy. A man ought to figure out his own mess. Or his dad was supposed to teach him this and never did, and going to somebody else feels like admitting the hole. The older man has reasons too. Who wants an old man's opinion? Or he's made so many mistakes that he can't imagine anything in there worth handing on. So both wait, and boys grow into men with nobody a few miles ahead to tell them what the road does next.

Nobody's going to pick you off the wall like a kid in gym class. Ask.

Ask small

Don't open with the word mentor. It sounds like a job title, and an older man hears a promise he may not keep, so he says no, or says yes and quietly vanishes.

Ask one narrow thing instead. What's kept your marriage together all these years? He might answer with words, or he might just nod at the passenger seat the way Harlan did. How did you know it was time to leave that job? If you got your kids' early years back, what would you do differently? What did the year after your divorce really cost you? Could I come watch you work sometime? If you're single, ask the marriage question before there's a ring; a year of questions beats three years of learning by crashing. If there's a baby at your house, ask the early-years one now, while you can still use the answer.

One question is a complete ask. If the hour goes well, you've earned another one next week. If he hands you a pair of gloves, show up ready to be useful. And if you want some edges around it, put a number on it: "Could we do twenty minutes a week, by phone, for a couple of months? There are a few things that are foggy from where I'm standing, and I bet they're not foggy from where you are."

Who to ask

You're looking for a man about two decades ahead who's living out what this book describes, unpolished. Not the most impressive guy in the building; leave him to people who need impressing. You want somebody who went down a road like yours and is still standing at the end of it.

Watch his wife while he talks. Thirty years with a faithful man and thirty years with a performance leave different marks on a woman's face, and she knows exactly which one she's got. Be careful with the guy who only tells you about his wins. Either he's hiding the losses or he never noticed them, and either way he can't get you where you need to go. You're there for the scars, and for whatever his version of the noon phone call is.

Pick somebody whose life you'd actually want at his age, and somebody you can reach. If no name comes to mind, you're looking too high. Maybe he's the deacon everybody thanks and nobody asks anything. Maybe he's the man in the back row, married longer than you've been alive, who hasn't had an honest talk with anybody your age in years. Maybe he's the retired guy who hangs around the hardware store counter a little longer than he needs to. If you're divorced, shame will tell you to skip this, and you need a man ahead as much as anyone. Find one who's lived through a

marriage ending, or a long-married man who won't turn you into a project.

After the yes

Picture the young man who helps with a fence once, then keeps showing up with nothing but a coffee and time to kill. By the third Saturday the older man is busy. Now picture the one who brings a real question every time. He gets the toolbox and the story behind the scar. The question is what honors the older man.

Then there's what you do with the answer. Plenty of older men have poured good advice into young men who nodded and changed nothing, and eventually they stopped pouring. Try what he said, even once, and come back and tell him how it went. Do that and he'll hold nothing back.

Just don't ask him to be your dad. He can't fill the exact shape your father left, and leaning that whole weight on him will wear him out.

And thank him, out loud and specifically. "I tried what you said with my dad, and something actually moved." Men his age can go years without hearing a sentence like that.

If you're the man ahead

About half of you reading this are the older man. The young man who doesn't have anybody needs you. In the middle years you face both ways: a man ahead you've never asked about the quiet house, and a younger man behind you whose marriage is fraying.

You're not finished. Nobody graduates. Even Paul, years into his ministry, wrote that he hadn't arrived yet and was still pressing on. Somebody younger is just now entering country you crossed years ago. He doesn't need a clean record. He needs the truth about where you blew it, and the plain, everyday habits that held your house together anyway. Paul told Titus as much.

Titus 2:6-7 NIV

Similarly, encourage the young men to be self-controlled. In everything set them an example by doing what is good.

An example, with a few words alongside it, in an ordinary week. That's the whole plan. No program required.

He probably won't come to you; you look busy and you make him nervous. So make yes easy. "I'm hanging a gate Saturday and could use a second set of hands, if

you want to learn how.” Once he’s there, skip the speech. Ask what work is doing to him, how things are with her, what’s weighing on him. Ask, then be quiet, and a young man will tell you things he’d never tell a guy his own age.

Tell him where you failed. When a young man hears somebody he respects admit he almost lost his marriage and that it was his own fault, something unlocks, and he can quit pretending. Your scar is the lesson. And if your own father never did this for you, you’re not disqualified. The life you’ve lived is the thing you have to give.

Work side by side; a shared job teaches more than a table. Keep it small, twenty minutes a week or a project every other Saturday. A young man who never had anyone dependable will learn more from eleven weeks of you just showing up than from the best talk you’ll ever give.

You’ll get more than you give. The older men who do this all say it: I thought I was helping him, and mostly he kept me going. If the badge or the hard hat is hanging on a hook now and the mornings are quiet, here’s what they’re for. God sets lonely people in families, young and old together.

A chain with gaps in it

Scripture pictures this as a chain. Moses went ahead of Joshua. Elijah went ahead of Elisha. Paul went ahead of Timothy, and he made sure it didn’t stop with Timothy.

2 Timothy 2:2 NIV

And the things you have heard me say in the presence of many witnesses entrust to reliable people who will also be qualified to teach others.

Paul, Timothy, the reliable men, and whoever they teach: four generations in one sentence. In a lot of churches and a lot of homes, the ends of that chain are just hanging loose. Your brother knows your trouble because he’s standing in the same weather. The man ahead knows it because he walked out the other side and can tell you what’s there. You need both, and one can’t stand in for the other.

Ride with me

That first summer turned into years of Saturdays in Harlan’s truck. Hundreds of questions, Travis guesses, and a lot of the answers came as a downshift and a long look out the windshield. Harlan’s been gone a while now. On Travis’s wedding day he sat in the very last pew, and afterward he took Travis’s hand and said, “Well. You paid attention.”

Travis had asked, and Harlan had opened the door. Neither of them stood around waiting on the other to make the first move.

Ask him. Someday, be him. The chain won't mend itself just because time goes by.

Before you turn the page

The broken links aren't some private guilt you have to fix before you're allowed to move. Mending them is the work of the men holding this book. If you're younger, bring one honest question. You'll feel foolish for about eight seconds. Then come back the next week. If you're older, open the passenger door. May the Father who gathers men together put a Harlan within reach of you, make you that man for somebody coming up behind, and show you both how thin your excuse of busyness always was.

14 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

You can know a man for years and still never have asked him anything that mattered. Write down the name of the man about twenty years ahead of you whom you've never really asked. If you're the one that far ahead, write down the younger man you've noticed and never approached.

DO THIS WEEK

The chain gets repaired one question and one yes at a time. Younger? Put one question to him this week, in person or by phone, and then go do what he says. If you're older, make it easy for one young man to say yes, whether it's breakfast, a job you could use help with, or a phone call.

TELL A BROTHER

The man ahead of you and the man beside you do different jobs. Let your brother in on the question and the answer, and give him permission to check that you followed through and went back to tell the older man.

CARRY THIS

Somewhere down the road a man is waiting for your question. Ask it, and when he opens the passenger door, get in.



CHAPTER 15

The Problem Inside

Cody's first truck had a bubble on the front fender about the size of his thumbnail. Every spring he sanded it to bright steel, primed it, sprayed on the closest match the parts store sold, and told himself it was handled. By every fall it was back, wider, with a couple of smaller ones gathered around it.

Third year, he gave up and drove it to a body shop. The man didn't say a word about Cody's handiwork. He pushed on the bubble with his thumb and the fender gave like soggy cardboard. Rusty water dribbled out. "Paint's not going to fix that," he said. "It's coming from the inside." Behind the panel, where none of the touch-ups had ever reached, the steel had been rotting all along. Cody had spent three years making the front of the problem look nice.

This is the hinge of the book. We've spent a lot of pages on what got handed to you: fathers who stayed or left, a blessing no one spoke, brothers who weren't there, older men you never went to. All of it shaped you. But I know men who've done every bit of that work. They left home. They asked the older man. They named the empty chair. Then they walked into the next room and wrecked it anyway. If this book ended with your father, I'd be giving you a can of primer and a pat on the back.

The trouble is in you. It's in me. Scripture has a one-syllable word for it, and as long as you won't put that word on yourself, you'll keep sanding.

Say the word

It's sin. And men find two ways around saying it.

The first way is to trade it for something gentler. Struggle. Baggage. An issue. A struggle is weather; it lands on you. Sin is a choice; you did it. Weather you manage. A choice you repent of.

The second way belongs to men who heard the word used on them like a belt

when they were boys. I'm sorry that happened. Those preachers never owned it, though. The word is God's, and when He says it, it's a doctor reading an X-ray, not a man winding up a punch. The body man wasn't insulting Cody. He was the first person to tell him the truth about his truck.

Sin bends a man inward. Left alone, it curls him around himself like a fist.

Before Cain lifted a hand against anybody, God told him sin was crouched at his door like something hungry, and that he had to rule over it. That warning cuts two ways. It's yours to answer for. It also isn't stronger than the God who's telling you to stand against it. Cain shrugged Him off, the crouching thing got him, and Abel never came home from the field. Same animal sits at every man's door.

Even with a perfect father

Give yourself the dad you always wanted. Home at six. Gentle and strong. Said he loved you and you never doubted it. Put a hand on your shoulder at eighteen and blessed you. Surrounded you with brothers and found you an older man to walk behind.

You'd be steadier for it. You'd still lie to your wife about what the card got used for. You'd still take the second look. You'd still keep that private list where you rank a notch above the man in the next pew.

Adam is the proof. No wound, no bad father, a flawless garden, honest work, a wife who was pure gift. And he reached for the fruit, then hid in the trees and blamed her. What's broken in a man didn't begin with his dad. It passed through his dad, from Eden on down. The best home in the world couldn't have filtered it out. Jeremiah called the heart crooked beyond a man's own repair, and Jesus told men who polished their outsides daily where the real trouble lived.

Mark 7:23 NIV

All these evils come from inside and defile a person.

Your father, the culture, the wound: those may have opened doors. They didn't build what came through them. A newborn's sleepless months work the same way: they strip a man down to what was already there, but they don't put it there.

Here's why that's mercy and not just a hard word. If every bit of it was done to you, you're stuck, because there's no getting a new father. And you've got an excuse that never runs out. You can't repent of your dad's sin. You can only stew in it, repeating Adam's line about whoever God gave him. But when you own what's

yours, God has something to forgive and something to rebuild. He isn't offering you a tidier account of your childhood. He's offering you a new heart.

If you're divorced, I'm not going to hand you the whole blame. God has the whole picture, and so do the two of you. You do have a share, and the healing starts when "I did this" can stand without "but she" stapled to the back.

Romans 5:8 NIV

But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.

He didn't wait for us to get our story straight. He saw what was there and went to the cross for it. Use His word, then. The cure travels with that word.

Wade

Wade's turn came in a twenty-minute check-in. Another man asked him what was weighing on him. He opened his mouth to say the job, then didn't. A long quiet. The evening before, his little girl had gone small in front of him. He hadn't hit her. He hadn't needed to. His voice climbed, she shrank, and he saw his own boyhood in her face. For years he'd filed that under temper. Sitting there, he called it sin.

The man across from him didn't look away. He said thank you. He asked what Wade was going to do about it. Then he prayed. Wade had expected to feel stripped. He felt washed, and he couldn't remember the last time.

James 5:16 NIV

Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person is powerful and effective.

Notice the word healed. Forgiven is a verdict. Healed is what happens to a man after the verdict, when somebody who loves him has heard the worst and stayed in his chair.

What actually holds

Paul wrote down every man's week. I want the good thing and don't do it. I hate the bad thing and do it again. You promised yourself patience with the kids and you barked. Then he asks, who will rescue me? A who. You don't get rescued by a method.

I've watched a lot of men run programs, and most of them land on try harder, which is just primer with a new label. A capable man can run his life on skill for years, and a polished résumé still isn't a pure heart. What holds is plainer.

Say it to God, out loud, specifically. Not “I’ve had a rough stretch.” I lied to her about the money. Reading the Sunday confession along with everyone isn’t the same as naming your own sin alone in the cab, and a man who’s kept the paint fresh for fifty years can forget there’s steel underneath. David said that keeping quiet dried him out to the bone, and that when he finally spoke, forgiveness met him. One sentence stood between the two.

Tell guilt and shame apart. Guilt points at the deed: that was wrong, and it was me. Shame points at you: you are the wrong thing. Guilt is the rusty water on the fender, ugly and accurate, and it settles once you’ve said it. Shame never settles. It keeps up its lies and herds a man back to his temper, his bottle, his screen, or his long silence, the very things he leans on to dull it.

Then change direction. Feeling rotten can go on for years without the feet moving. Repenting moves them. Confess. Repair what you can. Put something in the way of tomorrow’s door. Get back to your work. Do it again tomorrow if tomorrow needs it. From the inside, following Jesus looks a lot like a son who keeps drifting and a Father who keeps opening the door.

And ask for a new interior. Fresh off the worst thing he ever did, David didn’t ask God to fix his situation.

Psalm 51:10 NIV

Create in me a pure heart, O God, and renew a steadfast spirit within me.

Rot coming from behind the steel shrugs off another coat. The panel has to be replaced, and only God does that kind of bodywork, at any age.

New steel

The body man cut the rotten section out and welded in a new one. That fender stayed smooth. Cody stood in that shop feeling like a fool for three springs of wasted paint, and lighter than he’d felt in a while, because somebody had finally said the true thing, and it had a fix.

Letting go of the case against your dad and naming your own sin goes about the same way. A short sting of foolishness. Then a deep relief. The trouble inside has a name, the name has a cure, and the One who saw behind your panel all along has already covered the cost.

Everything this book asks of you from here on starts with the paint can put away and the word said out loud.

Before you turn the page

I've asked you to aim the hardest word in the language at yourself. Under it is very good news: God does His work from the inside, and the price is already paid. May the Father who forgave David the instant he confessed meet you the instant you do, and once the foolish feeling passes, may you know the lightness of a man who is finally fixing what was really wrong.

15 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

One honest sentence is all that stands between hauling it around and having it forgiven. Tell God, out loud, with the real thing in the sentence: “I sinned. I _.” Leave “struggle” out of it. If you’ve spent years naming your father or the old house, say the other true thing as well: the problem is also in me.

DO THIS WEEK

Confession that only happens when things blow up never becomes a habit, and a single man who builds it now brings into marriage what some husbands only learn from wreckage. Each night this week, right before sleep, give God two minutes and name that day’s sins, one at a time. Thank Him, since the forgiveness is already yours in Christ. Pay attention when shame tries to take over the conversation.

TELL A BROTHER

Sin can’t stay hidden for long once a man who won’t walk out on you has heard it. Give him one, in person or over the phone. Tell him your next step, and ask him to pray for you right then.

CARRY THIS

Paint was never the fix. Name what’s inside you. The cure comes with the name, and it’s already paid for.



CHAPTER 16

How That Looks on a Man

Watch him in the church foyer. He wants to know what you thought of the message. He spots the new guy alone by the coffee and walks over, and the welcome is warm because he means it. Now follow him home. Somewhere between the front door and the stove his voice crosses a border. Same shirt. Same ring. The weather in that house is something else entirely.

That's what the trouble we just named looks like on a man. It doesn't need a wreck. A nice finish works fine, and being capable works even better. Sin is cut to fit men in particular ways, and if you can't recognize the pattern, you'll stand at the bathroom sink every morning and tell the guy shaving that he's all right.

What it wears

Here are the shapes I run into most. One of them fits you.

The locked drawer. A second set of books. A search history. A friendship he describes at home with the wrong word. Sometimes there's no object, just a fear he's posted No Trespassing over. A boy's secret corner becomes a man's bolted room, and that's where things go bad. If you're single, give a brother your passwords and permission to ask, and empty the drawer while it's nearly empty.

The fortress. How are you? Fine. Need anything? No. The whole family leans on him; nobody gets leaned on in return. It's pride in a work jacket calling itself strength. From the road it can pass for Pick Up the Weight. But a man carrying his own load still lets a brother grab the other end. The fortress exists so that never happens. Gray in the beard makes it worse, because long years make a man expert at needing nothing. Around a table of brothers, "What do you need from us?" may be a question nobody has ever asked you, and your answer could change the table.

The scoreboard. In his head he's always tallying. Whose truck, whose title, whose wife, whose kids, whose bonus. Another man's good news stings, and his own life

never feels like enough. Saul kept that tally, and it had him throwing spears at the young shepherd who'd just won his war for him. After a divorce the scoreboard moves right in: her place against yours, whose holiday table looked fuller. Put the board down. Your Father sees in secret, and He isn't comparing your table with hers.

The podium. Sin in its Sunday best, the one Jesus seemed angriest at. Gentle in the lobby, a thunderhead on the drive home. Jesus said men like that perform for people who barely know them, and that audience is all they've got.

The throne. Every disagreement at home ends with him on top, by volume or a cold shoulder or a line that bruises. He calls it leadership. His wife would tell you her real job is handling him. The kids read the mood of his truck pulling in the way ranch kids read a sky. Paul fences the whole thing with one line.

Colossians 3:19 NIV

Husbands, love your wives and do not be harsh with them.

He knew that husband was coming. With a new baby, the throne gets loud. Worn-out men turn sharp, and she's more worn out than you, so apologize before bed every time.

There's a quieter version of the throne. The smirk. The eye roll while she's telling a story at dinner. Looking down on a gentler man in the next pew, or a son who cries.

The recliner. Laziness disguised as rest: a tired guy cashing in an evening he figures he earned, while the house pays in loose shingles and quiet kids. Boil it all down and some men skip the house, some run the room, and some answer "who are you" with a job title. If you're winning at work, notice whether your title has started answering questions only your soul should.

Holding up a mirror

Sin lies to whoever has it on, so use checks that don't run on feelings.

What would you hate for a brother to see? Phone, history, accounts, calendar, that one friendship. Whatever is inside, having a drawer at all is the problem. Hide nothing and there's nothing to defend.

When did someone last tell you no and you took it? If you can't think of a time, you're up on a throne.

Married men, pick a calm hour and ask your wife where you hide and where you

come across harsh. Don't argue. Listen, then thank her. Single men, ask the brother who knows you best, or your mom.

What do you only do when someone's watching? Who are you in the lobby, and who are you alone in the cab at eleven on a Tuesday night? The distance between those two men is the act.

Leave respect out of it: who in your house is scared of you? If any name comes to mind, step down. Get on your knees in front of the people who've had to learn your weather.

The king on the roof

One man in the Bible wore several of these in a single season, and nobody in his generation stood taller. If David could go down this road, you can. It started with staying home.

2 Samuel 11:1 NIV

In the spring, at the time when kings go off to war, David sent Joab out with the king's men and the whole Israelite army. They destroyed the Ammonites and besieged Rabbah. But David remained in Jerusalem.

Spring was fighting season, and David had always ridden out with his men. This year he sent his general and left his own boots by the door. Nobody in the palace would have called that sin; the king had put in his years. If you want the spot where a mark first gave way, it's here. Stop Waiting was the call, and David sat it out. Empty hands, long evenings, and one of those evenings he went up to pace the palace roof. You know what a bored man and a blank evening can get into.

He saw a woman bathing and asked who she was. Bathsheba, he was told, wife of Uriah, one of his own soldiers, who was out at the siege that very night. David sent for her anyway. When a king summons you, saying no isn't really on the table. He took her, because in that hour the hour was all that mattered to him.

Weeks later word came: she was pregnant. David pulled Uriah back from the front, poured him wine, and steered him toward home so the baby could be passed off as his. Uriah slept at the palace door instead, out of loyalty to friends sleeping on the ground near the enemy. So David sent him back with a sealed letter for Joab. Put him where it's hottest, then fall back. Uriah carried his own death order to the wall. Once the mourning was done, David moved the widow into the palace, and to anyone at court it looked settled.

2 Samuel 11:27 NIV

After the time of mourning was over, David had her brought to his house, and she became his wife and bore him a son. But the thing David had done displeased the LORD.

The kingdom hummed, and hardly anybody knew. For close to a year David ran Israel with a dead soldier hidden and the soldier's wife under his roof, and by every outward measure he ran it well. That's where skill and holiness part company. A church, a business, or a family can look solid while the man at the center goes soft with rot.

David wrote about that year later. His body wasted. God's hand pressed on him day and night. A good lock doesn't keep the drawer from working on you.

The prophet's finger

Conscience never won on its own. God sent Nathan.

2 Samuel 12:7 NIV

Then Nathan said to David, "You are the man! This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'I anointed you king over Israel, and I delivered you from the hand of Saul.'

Nathan began with a story: a rich man with whole herds took a poor neighbor's one pet lamb to feed a guest. David came out of his chair. Then Nathan pointed. You. Four words, spoken to a king's face in his own hall.

Men rarely blow their own cover. Usually a wife stops keeping quiet, or a brother won't accept "fine," or a bank statement lands on the counter. David's road was the ordinary one.

Everybody needs a Nathan, and every man ought to be willing to be one. That's why you sit with brothers: someday one of them will have to look across at you, enthroned and comfortable, and point.

Then David answered.

2 Samuel 12:13 NIV

Then David said to Nathan, "I have sinned against the LORD." Nathan replied, "The LORD has taken away your sin. You are not going to die."

One short sentence, and a period. No mention of where she chose to bathe. No complaint about Uriah. No speech about the weight of the crown. A confession ends where the sentence ends. Forgiveness came on the next breath. The consequences came too, and they were brutal, but David didn't have to outlast them

before he was right with God. The drawer opened, and he was restored.

Nothing locked

Jesus had no drawer. Nothing in Him was held back from His Father. On the night of His arrest He reminded the high priest that every word He'd taught was spoken in public, and His accusers had to go looking for false witnesses. Nobody could find a hidden room in Him, and He had nothing to be ashamed of.

That's the man God is shaping in you. Private and public start to match. Your wife, your brothers, and your God can look straight at you without wincing, since what you hid has been said out loud and forgiven.

Let your Nathan in. Confess, and stop at the period.

Before you turn the page

You've likely spotted your shape. A prophet pointed, David answered with one short sentence, and he was forgiven before he could draw another breath. May the Father seat a brother beside you who'll point when you need it, and give you the plain nerve to say, I have sinned, and stop talking.

16 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Whoever has the shape on is always the last to see it. Choose yours from this chapter's list, the drawer or the throne or one of the others. Then point to where it showed up in the real hours of this past week.

DO THIS WEEK

Someone close to you already knows. Married, ask your wife where she sees you hiding and where you come across harsh. Single, ask a brother. Let them say all of it. Don't defend yourself. Thank them.

TELL A BROTHER

David needed a Nathan, and so do you. Tell him what's in the drawer, even if it's only keeping what you really think to yourself. Then give him permission to point when he sees the shape on you.

CARRY THIS

A man can run a kingdom well and rot inside it. Open the drawer while it's still your choice.



CHAPTER 17

No Fixed Star

He keeps the two-foot level on top of the dryer. Today he's putting up a laundry-room shelf, and he's hung enough of them to know a wall can look square and lie to you. He sets the level down on the plank. That little bubble wanders, settles, and stops just outside the lines. The shelf he'd have bet money on is crooked.

He doesn't argue. The bubble has no opinions. It only knows which way is down.

Masons use the old version. Tie a weight to the end of a cord, let it hang beside the brick, and wait for it to quit swinging. Every time, the cord points dead at the center of the earth. Gravity doesn't poll the crew. If the wall has wandered, the plumb line says so.

Most of us measure our lives against things that wander.

As they saw fit

Judges closes with a line I'd put up against any sentence in the Bible for sheer sadness.

Judges 21:25 NIV

In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit.

What makes it sad isn't that every man was a villain. It's the yardstick. Each man's own judgment was his north, so whenever he turned, north turned with him. Drive a farm-to-market road in heavy fog, steering by whatever fence post is in your headlights, and you can end up miles off without feeling a single curve.

That's a lot of the men I know. Capable. Booked solid. No heading. So we grab for something to steer by, and most of what we grab moves.

Dad usually comes first. Whatever he was, that's what a man looked like. Then you got older and realized he'd been drifting too. And if he walked out, or never

really showed up, you didn't even get a post to sight on. Learn from your father. Don't steer by him. If you're single, the same goes for the wife you're hoping for. Marriage is a good gift. It isn't the heading.

Next come the guys around you. I earn more than my brother-in-law. I'm home for supper more than anybody on my crew. At least I never pulled what that deacon pulled. That's one leaning wall grading itself against another. You can own the straightest wall in the neighborhood and still be off plumb. At nineteen, guys your age usually set the measure, and how you treat a woman becomes whatever got the biggest laugh at the job site. A chapter of Mark read in your truck before the shift won't change its mind when the laughter does. If you're divorced, the wall you'll grade yourself against is hers. Quit sighting off it and hang the line against your own.

Then the culture. What made a man in your granddad's eyes and what your boy's phone is selling him are two different norths. An older man may have steered by the world that raised him, and now he hears it mocked on every channel. Scripture will fix what his generation got wrong and keep what it got right. The cord doesn't care what year the wall went up.

Then feelings. It just doesn't feel right anymore. I sense God moving me somewhere else. Feelings are real, but they rise and fall with your sleep, your lunch, and your last argument. Steering by them is navigating by clouds. A new dad on three hours of sleep concludes the marriage is failing when it's only worn out. Ten minutes in Scripture before anyone picks up a phone does more than an hour of building a case against your marriage after the kids go down.

And then success, the most convincing of all. The company's growing, so I must be okay. We're still married, so we must be fine. I know a man whose work kept telling him he was doing great, year after year, while at home his wife was quietly building a life that didn't include him. A profit-and-loss sheet can't do a plumb line's work. Remember David, running a kingdom smoothly for a year with a murdered soldier hidden away. Success just means the wall hasn't come down yet. It can't tell you whether it's true.

Proverbs 14:12 NIV

There is a way that appears to be right, but in the end it leads to death.

Appears to be right. That's drift, seen from the driver's seat. The road only tells you its real name at the end.

The line that holds

There is a fixed point, and Amos got a look at the One who holds it.

Amos 7:7-8 NIV

This is what he showed me: The Lord was standing by a wall that had been built true to plumb, with a plumb line in his hand. And the LORD asked me, "What do you see, Amos?" "A plumb line," I replied. Then the Lord said, "Look, I am setting a plumb line among my people Israel; I will spare them no longer.

God hung His cord right in the middle of His people, against their actual lives, and no wall got a vote. That's Scripture. It has commands in it, but more than that, it holds still, so a drifting man can finally see how far he's gone.

Psalms 119:105 NIV

Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path.

A lamp at your feet doesn't light the whole county. It shows you the next step, and that's all a Tuesday morning asks for. Paul described the same thing in working terms.

2 Timothy 3:16-17 NIV

All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness, so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work.

Teaching shows you what's true. Rebuke is the cord hanging beside a wall that's started to lean. Correction walks the wall back. Training keeps coming around until your own hands lay brick straight. Equipped like that, you quit borrowing other men's wandering norths.

Take everything this book has asked of you so far and hang it against that cord. You'll find out fast which part of your life has started to lean.

The house that stood

At the end of the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus told a story every man who's ever poured a foundation already gets.

Matthew 7:24-25 NIV

Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock. The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house; yet it did not fall, because it had its foundation on the rock.

Hears, and does. The wise builder didn't take the best notes. He acted on them.

His slab sits on ground that doesn't shift, so when the storm hits, the house stays put.

The other man built on sand. His place looked fine until the weather turned, and he'd been checking his walls against neighbors on the same sand.

Why the level stays in the drawer

Most men were never shown how. They open Genesis on New Year's Day, bog down in Leviticus by February, and quit. That's a gap in training, not character, and four weeks of a different habit will close it.

Some say it feels like homework. Then stop reading it like an assignment and start reading it like a son listening to his Father. Read it aloud in the cab. Walk in with one question: what's this asking a man to do?

Some say there's no time. There's ten minutes. Most of us already spend them on the weather and the box scores. Give the same ten to the one thing in your life that doesn't move.

Some say they don't feel anything. Feeling wasn't the point. A level never gave anybody goosebumps either. It just tells you whether the plank is true.

Where to start

For the short Gospel, Mark. For the deep one, John. A section a day, and within a month you'll have spent real hours watching the Man you say you follow.

After that, try Proverbs, a chapter each morning for a month. Hugh started there somewhere in the middle of life, on the morning it dawned on him that his dad's opinions had been steering him for decades, and his dad had been in the ground for years. He read one chapter aloud every day on his drive in. His copy is coming apart at the spine. A younger guy once asked how he always knew how to handle money, women, temper, and friends. One chapter a day, Hugh said. Proverbs is a father talking to a son, and nobody outgrows that.

When you can't find words to pray, open the Psalms and pray one aloud as if you'd written it. David meant them to be used that way.

Whatever you read, carry the same question: what does this ask of me on an ordinary morning with nobody watching, and will I do it before lunch? Read with a brother if you can, each of you bringing the verse that wouldn't let go of you that week. Say it aloud where you'll hear it: the cab, the porch, the supper table.

The bigger story

God knows your story, the shapes we traced earlier and the locked room included. But your chapter isn't the whole book, and if it's the only part you read, you'll read it wrong. The harm done to you isn't the first page. Your sin won't be the last. Using the fixed point as a rulebook and nothing more is using it small.

The whole account opens in a garden with a man made for work, and it closes with the Man who finishes what the first one dropped. Lose your fixed point and it's worse than a bad week. You lose your place in the story, and you forget what you were made to do.

You don't have to understand everything about why a fixed thing holds before it can save you. Hang the cord. Let the weight settle.

Before you turn the page

You may hit February with a lot of Bible still unread. That's fine. Hang the line against your own wall and begin there. May the Father light the next step under your feet this week, and be patient with you while your hands get used to the work.

17 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Any north you won't name keeps steering you long after you think you've let it go. Write one honest sentence about what you actually measured your life by this year: your father, the men around you, the culture, your feelings, or your success.

DO THIS WEEK

Scripture only becomes your fixed point once you open it and ask it something. Read a section of Mark every day this week, aloud when you can, and each time write one line about what it asks a man to do.

TELL A BROTHER

Two men holding the same line catch a lean that one man can explain away. Tell him which north you've been steering by. Read him one verse from your week, tell him what obeying it would cost, and be honest about whether you did.

CARRY THIS

You don't need to know why it holds. Put the string on the wall and trust the weight.

PART THREE

The Story That Names You



CHAPTER 18

Before the Fall

A seed packet is stuck to the fridge with a magnet, and it knows more than the backyard does. Tomato. Full sun. Plant after the last frost. Without that packet, the bare stretch in the third row is plain dirt. With it, you know a plant belongs there. A row can't fail until you know what it was meant to grow.

Get men talking and it comes around to their marriages, their tempers, their sons. Underneath, they're nearly always asking one thing: what was I supposed to be before I got bent? If you've never looked at the original, you can't sort damage from personality.

So let's go back to the first week, before anybody hid or blamed. What did God make when He made a man, back when He was still calling everything good?

Dust, and breath

Start with the dirt.

Genesis 2:7 NIV

Then the LORD God formed a man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living being.

If you've ever knelt by a fire pit the morning after, found one orange coal under the ash, and put your face down near it to blow until it caught, you've seen a picture of this. Clay in His hands. Then His face close enough to breathe. Nobody assembled you at arm's length. God leaned in.

And what that dust was shaped to look like is the very first thing the Bible says about you. Sinner is coming. It isn't first.

Genesis 1:27 NIV

So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them.

Before your first trophy or your first wreck, you were made to resemble God. Nobody earns that, and failing doesn't erase it. Women bear it as fully as men. Manhood doesn't lift you a step above the women in your house. It's one of two ways of carrying one likeness, and God dreamed up both.

Blessed first

God's opening words to the people He'd made weren't instructions. They were a blessing.

Genesis 1:28 NIV

God blessed them and said to them, "Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it. Rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky and over every living creature that moves on the ground."

Identity, then assignment. The Father keeps that order at the Jordan, calling Jesus His beloved Son before Jesus has preached a sermon or healed anyone.

And the assignment is no small one. Raw ground was meant to come alive under a man's care. That's why a fence line you set true, a faucet you finally fixed, or a table you built from rough boards makes you feel like you for an evening. That's the original wiring.

Subdue was never permission to bully. God governs by making things grow. Ruling only curdled into grinding people down after the fall. In Eden, ruling looked like tomatoes coming in.

If there's a new baby in your house, you're living inside be fruitful right now. Bone-tired doesn't mean you're off the design. It means the curse got heaped on top of the blessing.

A place, and a job site

Look where God set him down.

Genesis 2:8 NIV

Now the LORD God had planted a garden in the east, in Eden; and there he put the man he had formed.

Adam wasn't turned loose to roam until he found himself. He had an address, and the address was part of how he was made.

So do you. Most men treat theirs like an accident, or a waiting room until real life starts. The apartment, the job site, the small town you keep meaning to leave: that's

the plot God handed you. A man forever squinting at the next county never tends his own.

And that plot was a workplace from day one.

Genesis 2:15 NIV

The LORD God took the man and put him in the Garden of Eden to work it and take care of it.

Nobody has sinned yet. No curse has been spoken. And already there's soil under the man's nails.

Thorns came later. Work came first, and it was good. So a man with nothing worth doing isn't really resting. He's idling rough. A layoff, a retirement with no purpose in it, a back that can't do the old job anymore can flatten a man, because he was built to tend a garden and someone took it. Abe went hunting in that verse for a retirement clause once the paychecks quit. He stopped introducing himself as let go. "Same job," he said. "Different garden." Grandkids now, and younger men, and a wife who's carried plenty.

Take care of it means watch over it, guard it. The man who turned the soil also walked the fence. And part of what he guarded was a boundary God Himself set.

Genesis 2:16-17 NIV

And the LORD God commanded the man, "You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat from it you will certainly die."

Listen to how God opens: free. The whole orchard is open except one tree. Adam got that straight from God before Eve was there, and keeping the garden meant keeping that line too, against any voice that might talk them over it. Something is about to slip through the fence.

A day to stop

Men tend to skim this part.

Genesis 2:2-3 NIV

By the seventh day God had finished the work he had been doing; so on the seventh day he rested from all his work. Then God blessed the seventh day and made it holy, because on it he rested from all the work of creating that he had done.

God wasn't tired. Rest is where good work is headed. He put the stopping day into the calendar before the man ever lifted a tool, and He called that day holy.

Picture a shop on Saturday evening. Every tool wiped and hung back on its painted outline, floor swept, lights off. That isn't a lazy shop. It's a shop that knows what it's for. You aren't a machine. Six days on, one day off the clock. Grinding through the seventh isn't a promotion. If the whole outfit calls you on Sunday, hear this: a business that can't spare you one day in seven has started to own you. A man who never stops goes numb, and numb isn't holy.

Not good

Then, with all that good stacked up, God says something that stops you cold.

Genesis 2:18 NIV

The LORD God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone. I will make a helper suitable for him."

Every day so far had ended good. Then God looked at one man in a flawless garden, with meaningful work and God's own voice in his ear, and said, not good.

He hadn't sinned. He had God. And God still said solitary wasn't good. Needing people isn't a weakness that crept in after things broke. It was drawn into the plans.

His first words

So God walked the animals past him.

Genesis 2:19-20 NIV

Now the LORD God had formed out of the ground all the wild animals and all the birds in the sky. He brought them to the man to see what he would name them; and whatever the man called each living creature, that was its name. So the man gave names to all the livestock, the birds in the sky and all the wild animals. But for Adam no suitable helper was found.

God let the man's words count. What he said, stuck.

Yours stick too. A boy grows toward whatever his father calls him. In a marriage, a husband's words become the walls she lives inside. Even a quiet man's few sentences land like hammer blows.

None of the animals was the answer. A good dog is fine company, but he needed someone like him and not like him. So God put him under, shaped the woman out of his side, and walked her over. Then, for the first time in Scripture, a human being speaks.

Genesis 2:23 NIV

The man said, "This is now bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh; she shall be called 'woman,' for she was taken out of man."

The first recorded words of a man were poetry, and the poem was about her. Ask a husband when he last said something to his wife that wasn't logistics, and watch him squint. The design is a man so taken with his bride that words come out of him. He leaves home and clings to her. Marriage is in the plans before anything breaks, and the clinging was his to do.

But hear not good wider than a wedding. Brothers. An older man out ahead of you. A church that knows your name. If you're divorced, I know that sentence can sting. God hasn't torn up the plan, and He isn't pushing you toward the altar either. This is what He's handing you. If you're single, you're inside that sentence, not outside it. Almost everything in this chapter was given to Adam while he was still on his own. A wedding doesn't make you a man. Tend your plot and walk your fence now.

Nothing to hide

Then, right before it all breaks, one more line.

Genesis 2:25 NIV

Adam and his wife were both naked, and they felt no shame.

Fully seen, and not afraid. That's a man before the fall.

Think about closing day on a house. You walk through before the movers come. Empty rooms, late light across bare floors, not a scuff anywhere. Then the years happen. Crayon down the hallway, a dent where the dresser hit, a water ring under the window. One day you catch yourself talking as if the stains were the house. They aren't. It was good before the marks, and its Builder remembers exactly how it looked. Every locked room in a man since Eden is a long, sideways try at walking around unashamed again.

What comes next

Picture him at the end of that first week, walking with God in the cool of the evening, hiding nothing from Him or from her. That's what you were made for. Next, we see what he did with it.

Before you turn the page

Sit here a minute while the garden is still whole. Shaped by hand. Breathed into. Blessed before you'd done a thing. Given ground to tend and a day to stop. May the God whose likeness you carry remind you before you sleep tonight what He made

you for.

18 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

An original you've never studied is hard to head back toward. In one full sentence, say which part of that first week feels most bent in you now: being made and wanted, your place, your work, the rest, the people, your words, or living with nothing hidden.

DO THIS WEEK

This design was made to be read out loud, not boiled down. Some ordinary morning, read the first two chapters of Genesis aloud in one sitting. Write a single sentence on why God made a man, and then tend one thing you've been given, as a gift.

TELL A BROTHER

Your brother may spot a bend you've never noticed. Tell him the part you named and what moving back toward it would take this month. Then ask him where he sees you bent.

CARRY THIS

Work came before the curse. You were made to tend it and keep it, and the design still fits.



CHAPTER 19

Two Men, Two Ways

Most nights, once the kids are finally down, he walks out to the strip of dirt beside the garage. Boots, no socks. He pulls the hose over, straightens the tomato cage that leans after every rain, and stands there awhile. Drive by and you'd never guess anything that matters happens there. Same for Eden from the road, and for an olive grove outside Jerusalem, the night a Man lay flat on that ground and prayed.

The Bible hangs the whole human story on two gardens and two men. Each had a night when everything rode on him.

The first man was given everything and lost it in one afternoon, mostly by keeping his mouth shut. The second Man arrived at His garden with almost nothing left except a choice. He made it lying on the ground, and that choice rescued the world.

Romans 5:19 NIV

For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous.

Which of those two are you standing in? And which way are you walking this week?

Eden

The serpent slides in and skips Adam. He goes to Eve, and he goes after what God said. Did He really tell you that? A small bend in the words, and a suggestion that God is tight-fisted. And where's the man?

Genesis 3:6 NIV

When the woman saw that the fruit of the tree was good for food and pleasing to the eye, and also desirable for gaining wisdom, she took some and ate it. She also gave some to her husband, who was with her, and he ate it.

He was right there. Men have lived under that phrase ever since. Adam heard the command first, before Eve had been made, so guarding that ground was already his job. Then the thing he was put there to keep out came right in, and he listened to God's word get twisted and said nothing. Then he ate. The Bible's first sin has a silent man standing in the middle of it.

Most of us know that silence from the inside. Something false got said at the table, answering it would have cost the evening, and we let it ride.

When God comes looking that evening, the two of them duck out of sight.

Genesis 3:10 NIV

He answered, "I heard you in the garden, and I was afraid because I was naked; so I hid."

Fear, then cover. The man who should have stepped out to meet that voice crouched behind leaves. And when God asks him plainly what he's done, Adam's answer starts with her. The woman. The one You gave me. Count the names in that sentence. One is missing, and it's his own.

Under all of it sits the grab. You'll be like God, the snake had promised. Adam wanted the gift and was willing to lose the Giver to get it.

Nobody had to teach you that groove. You found it the way rainwater finds the low spot in a yard.

Thorns follow, and death, and a shut gate. But inside the curse sit two mercies. God makes them clothes from an animal's skin, so the first covering for shame cost a life. Then He turns to the snake and speaks a curse with a promise folded inside it.

Genesis 3:15 NIV

And I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and hers; he will crush your head, and you will strike his heel.

A son is on the way. When the enemy comes to His garden, He won't stand there mute. It will cost Him a wound, and He will crush the thing that got in. Before the first garden stopped smoking, God was announcing the second Man.

Gethsemane

Night, and a hillside He knows well. His friends come along, and He brings three of them in closer. Then He goes on by Himself and falls forward.

Matthew 26:39 NIV

Going a little farther, he fell with his face to the ground and prayed, "My Father, if it is possible, may this cup be taken from me. Yet not as I will, but as you will."

In Eden the offer was fruit that promised to make a man a god. Here it's a cup that will make God's Son look like a cursed criminal, and everything in Him pulls back. Luke says the sweat came off Him like drops of blood. And still He prays what Adam never prayed. Your will, Father, not Mine. That cup held sin He never committed, and He drank it with our guilt laid on Him.

Three times He prays it. Then torches come up the path, and He stands.

Matthew 26:46 NIV

Rise! Let us go! Here comes my betrayer!

Rise. Let us go. He walks straight at them.

John 18:4 NIV

Jesus, knowing all that was going to happen to him, went out and asked them, "Who is it you want?"

He went out. No search party needed. An hour after sweating blood, He met the clubs and lanterns in the open, His mind on His men.

John 18:8 NIV

Jesus answered, "I told you that I am he. If you are looking for me, then let these men go."

Let these men go. Seconds from being bound, He points to His own chest. Take Me. Leave them. He plants Himself between the soldiers and the friends His Father put in His care.

If you're divorced, sit a long time with that line. Adam's instinct is to aim a finger, at her, at the lawyers, at the God who brought her into your life. Jesus said, Me, not them. Your kids shouldn't have to haul your war around. Shield them. Name your own part out loud. Hand hers to God.

Then the cross. And at the end He doesn't cry for rescue. He reports in.

John 19:30 NIV

When he had received the drink, Jesus said, "It is finished." With that, he bowed his head and gave up his spirit.

It is finished. Every piece done, and He says so before He dies. The crowd filed Him away as one more failed teacher on a cross. Three days later the Father answered

by raising Him.

Whose you are

The Bible doesn't stop at, go copy the second Man. It says you already live inside one of the two.

1 Corinthians 15:22 NIV

For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive.

Birth put you in Adam. That's why going quiet comes easy, why blame stays loaded, why ducking feels like plain sense. You were in him the way a whole family carries the name of the man at the top of the tree.

So you aren't told to try harder. Willpower never pulled one man out of Adam. God offers a transfer. By faith He lifts a man out of the first and sets him inside the second, and the second garden is counted as his. Christ's obedience goes on that man's record, and "It is finished" gets spoken over him for good. Jesus called this being born again. It's the gospel, and there isn't another door.

Galatians 2:20 NIV

I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The life I now live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me.

That's a new address. The Spirit who raised Jesus lives in a man who belongs to Christ, and that's where his strength to stand comes from. Not grit. Life.

If you've never done this, do it now. Tell God that Eden's way is the only one you've ever lived and you're finished with it. Ask Him to put you in His Son, Christ's garden laid over yours, Christ's record where yours used to be. The door's open, and He's the one who opened it.

If you've already done that, hear the rest. Everything this book asks of a man, Jesus did first, and He did it for you. The marks in these pages aren't a ladder you climb so He'll take you. You're already His. They're the family face, starting to show on a son who belongs.

Small gardens

Yours won't look like an olive grove. One will look like a kitchen. She says something that isn't quite fair, and going cold or firing back would both feel good. That's the garden. The other way might be one calm sentence: that one stung, could we sit down once the kids are in bed?

Another looks like a phone at eleven, with the charger down the hall where you could just walk it. That one comes with or without a ring on your hand. The second Man never married, and nobody has ever been more of a man.

With a baby in the house, a lot of them happen at 2 a.m. He asked the Father to take the cup away, and then He stood up. You can stand up too, even if it's only to get to the end of the hall.

Or a project gone sideways at work with your prints on part of it, and a room that would happily let the vendor take the blame. The other way is five words: that piece is on me.

Eden came down to one piece of fruit. Most of your days will come down to things about that size.

Last Adam

1 Corinthians 15:45 NIV

So it is written: "The first man Adam became a living being"; the last Adam, a life-giving spirit.

Paul's word is last, not next. Nobody comes after Him. He did the job the first one dropped, all the way through. Now He's drawing men into Himself and leading them through ordinary gardens, His Spirit inside them, His record covering them.

Adam's last words in Eden were an excuse. Christ's were It is finished. Cal started praying something new in his later years: Lord, whatever's still mine to do, let me finish it. The road gets shorter, and there are still gardens on it.

You were born in one man. You can be carried into the other. Tonight, stand where you are as someone who's in Christ. And if you've never asked Him to bring you in, don't go to bed without asking.

19 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

The two ways only show up clearly in a real moment. Pick the most recent one from this week, the kitchen, the late phone, the 2 a.m. hallway, and write down honestly which man's way you took.

DO THIS WEEK

His words in that garden were meant to be spoken, not only admired. Each morning, picture the moment you're most likely to face that day and say the Gethsemane line that fits it, out loud. Rise, let us go. Not as I will. Let these men go. Then head out the door.

TELL A BROTHER

Whose you are is the largest question this book asks. Give him your real answer. If you've never trusted Christ to bring you out of Adam, say so and let him help you take that step. If you have, tell him about one moment this week when you went Jesus' way instead of Adam's.

CARRY THIS

You were born in the first man's garden. In Christ, the second Man's "It is finished" is the last word on you.



CHAPTER 20

Destiny Is Not a Vibe

Warehouse 2. Dock C. A crate of brass fittings, already tagged for a shop across the river, and a young guy with the slip in his fingers hoping this hour might finally feel like what he was born for. It didn't. He set the paper on the pallet and stared past the truck toward the lot, like the answer might pull in and honk. The crate didn't care. Those fittings were crossing the river whether he felt anything or not.

An older hand walked over, lifted the slip off the pallet, and put it back in the kid's hand.

"Here's your job," he said. "Quit waiting to feel a different one."

I've thought about that dock a lot. God hands a man his destiny. The man does it somewhere specific, with the people of his own time, mostly on days that look like nothing, and then one day it's done. Feeling significant is something else entirely. So is that low hum telling you the big moment meant for you is still out there somewhere. Every man on that dock had an assignment. You've got one too. A lot of us keep waiting to feel chosen with the work sitting right in our hands.

What we tell ourselves

Three stories keep men standing at the edge of the dock. Each one sounds wise. Each one's a lie.

The first says you'll know it when you feel it. Out there is a life that will finally fit, and until it does, every restless Sunday night is proof you're on the wrong road. Feelings tell you about the weather, though, not the road. Moses pushed back at the bush. Jeremiah said he was only a boy. Gideon asked God for a sign three separate times. Jonah paid good money to sail away from Nineveh. If feelings got the vote, not one of them leaves the house. Men obey, and the feelings sometimes show up later, and sometimes they don't. God honors the obedience either way.

The second says it has to be big. A stage, a following, something people still talk about after you're gone. So a man frames houses for twenty-five years, coaches his boy's team, is the guy the whole street calls when a pipe bursts, and quietly decides he missed it. Jesus said well done to the servant who'd been trustworthy with a little. The little was the test. When the temple was a half-built foundation, the prophet asked who dares despise the day of small things, because people would rejoice to see the plumb line in Zerubbabel's hand. Small days aren't the waiting room for destiny. They're the building.

The third says it's somewhere else. Another job, another state, after the wedding, after the kids are grown, after you retire. The real life is always one move off, and the move keeps sliding down the calendar. If you're single and sure a wedding or a bigger title will finally unlock your work, go back to that dock. Whatever God has put next in front of you is it. God set the first man down on one piece of ground and said work this. Paul stood in Athens and told the city that God decided when and where each nation would live. Your county wasn't an accident. Neither was your decade.

David's epitaph

If I could give you one line from the Bible on what a man's life is for, it would be a sentence Paul spoke in a synagogue in Asia Minor, walking his listeners down through Israel's kings.

Acts 13:36 NIV

Now when David had served God's purpose in his own generation, he fell asleep; he was buried with his ancestors and his body decayed.

That's a whole life in about twenty words. David took God's purpose, not his own, and carried it out with the people God surrounded him with, across the years God allotted. After that he died, and the grave did what graves do. Paul doesn't skip the decay. He wants you to see that the man was never supposed to be permanent. The purpose was.

And notice the verb. Served. David had a Master. When David went his own way, with Bathsheba and with the census, he nearly lost everything. Paul leaves all that out of the epitaph and keeps the one thing God gave him to do.

That sentence is true about you whether or not you can feel it tonight. And if you're older, in his own generation still means now, not back then. The psalm says the righteous still bear fruit in old age. A Saturday breakfast with a younger man. A Sunday class. A few words over a tailgate. None of that waits on a feeling.

What's actually true

Your destiny was assigned before you got here. You don't go find it like a man looking for a parking spot. God prepared the work ahead of time.

Ephesians 2:10 NIV

For we are God's handiwork, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance for us to do.

Prepared in advance. That means you don't have to sniff out one hidden purpose and live terrified you chose wrong. You can trust that the next good work is already set in your path, and go do it. Pick up the slip.

It also lives at an address. Your wife's name, if you're married. Your kids' names, if you have them. With a new baby at home, your destiny right now weighs about twelve pounds and has opinions about sleep, and the fact that it doesn't feel grand is part of the lesson. The cul-de-sac, the night shift, the small church where people know how you take your coffee. David's field was Israel. Mordecai's word to Esther still lands on men who'd rather lie low: if you keep silent, deliverance will come some other way, and you'll miss your part in it. Maybe you're right where you are for this exact moment. This desk. This kitchen. This year.

And it gets done by faithfulness. Moods start things. They don't finish them.

John 4:34 NIV

"My food," said Jesus, "is to do the will of him who sent me and to finish his work."

Finishing the Father's work fed Him. Paul wrote from a prison he'd never have chosen and said it plainly: fight fought, race run, faith kept. Those are the words of a man who got to the end.

The day is coming when the only Judge whose opinion lasts says well done, a Father's voice to a son who was His before the work began.

So start with what you're already holding. Adam never had to go looking for his garden. God planted it, walked him into it, and told him to work it. Yours is already planted too. Write down your place, your actual town and street and job and church. If God wants you somewhere else, let Him do the moving. Write down your people, by name. Those names will outweigh anything you could hang on a wall. Use the gift that's really in your hands. Live inside the years you were given.

Three years on the dock

The young guy stayed. He never did get the feeling. What he got was the older man telling him to give it three years, feel it or not, and see what God would do with somebody who quit walking away. That was a good while back. He leads a crew now. Two men on that crew started going to church because of how his shift treats people. Ask him about his calling and he'll wave you off. He'll talk about purpose, though. He says it was sitting right where he kept putting that slip down.

God hadn't hidden a thing from him. It was printed. It just needed picking up.

Not your name

If your marriage came apart, the story isn't over, and the good chapters aren't either. Joseph's purpose went through a prison. Peter's went straight through the night he swore he never knew Jesus, and Jesus had already prayed about the far side.

Luke 22:32 NIV

But I have prayed for you, Simon, that your faith may not fail. And when you have turned back, strengthen your brothers.

Turned back, then strengthening others. His worst night became equipment. There are men who'll never tell their pastor what they'll tell you, because of where you've been. God can serve His purpose in this generation through the exact history you assumed disqualified you.

Every man collects labels along the way. The kid whose dad walked out. The guy whose marriage failed. The one who got passed over. They happened, but they're not your name. Those labels belong to Eden's fig leaves. God's story gives you different ones: made in His image, placed on purpose, given work, a son with a Father who doesn't leave, a man in Christ, a servant of God's purpose in your day.

Revelation 2:17 NIV

Whoever has ears, let them hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who is victorious, I will give some of the hidden manna. I will also give that person a white stone with a new name written on it, known only to the one who receives it.

One day He'll put a white stone in your hand with a name on it no other person has ever heard. Whatever your history kept calling you won't follow you there.

Most of what God assigns a man gets carried out under his own roof, so from here the book goes home. A wife, if God has given you one. Children. The marriage bed. The supper table. Rooms already full of the people you love, or rooms you're still

building toward.

Pick up what God handed you. Do it right where you are, for the people in front of you, and see it through. Destiny is not a vibe.

Before you turn the page

Chasing a feeling is like chasing heat lightning across a field. The assignment was never out there. It's been in your town, your people, your hands, and these years. May the Father who planned your good works before your first breath put the next one squarely in your path this week. Do it whether you feel anything or not. It counts.

20 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

The lie that steers you rarely introduces itself. Write down which story has had the wheel: it has to feel right, it has to be big, or it has to be somewhere else.

Then write one sentence, using real names, about what serving God's purpose looks like where you actually live.

DO THIS WEEK

Your assignment is usually already in your hands. On one card, write four headings: place, people, hands, and these years. Add a line under each. Before Sunday, do one thing from that card.

TELL A BROTHER

Another man can often see your purpose more clearly than you can. Tell him which feeling you've been waiting on and for how long. Read him your card. Then ask him where he sees God pointing your life right now.

CARRY THIS

Do what God handed you, where He put you, for the people He gave you, until it's finished. Destiny is not a vibe.

PART FOUR

The House



CHAPTER 21

If There Is No Wife Yet

A lamp sat on a moving box, long enough to press a ring into the cardboard. KITCHEN, in black marker, still faced the bed. In the box: two plates he'd bought for a table he didn't own, a skillet with the price sticker on the bottom, and a dish towel he was saving for later. Micah said he was waiting for his life to begin. I asked him what he'd call the room he wakes up in every morning.

Press him and he'll tell you real life kicks off when some woman agrees to marry him.

A good stretch of what's ahead is about marriage. If you're not married, this chapter is yours before it's anybody else's. Then stay. Everything that follows is something you can build on now.

Three different men

"Single" covers at least three men, and their years look nothing alike.

One has never been married. Maybe he aches for a wife. Maybe he's halfway in, or he's quit looking. With nobody real in the picture, it's easy to dream up a woman no actual woman could match. If you're young, hear this: these years count. Rooms you can live in, money you can account for, a brother, a clean conscience. A husband needs every one of those. Start now.

The second man was married, and it ended. You're mourning what was taken, or what you wrecked, or both, with your life split across two addresses while the church tries to figure out where to seat you. All I say to the first man, I'm saying to you.

The third man stood at his wife's grave. You lived in that house together, and then her side of the bed went still. People don't know what to say, so a lot of them say nothing. I'll say something: keep working, and keep showing up. We want you here.

If you're in the divorced seat

Single again is single. Everything this chapter says about building a home, feeding people, finding brothers, and keeping clean is yours, plus fathering in two houses.

Grief comes with the seat, whether you filed or fought the filing. Something died, so bury it. Men who skip the funeral build the next house on soft dirt. Cry. Tell a brother what's gone.

Then own your share. Healing starts when "I did this" comes out of your mouth with no "but she" behind it.

Your kids before any new woman. Dating hard while they're still finding their feet puts things upside down.

Stay at church even if people are clumsy with you. Don't race toward another wedding. Sit down with your pastor. A man who remarries in the first raw year to make the pain stop usually just passes the pain along.

If she died first

It's not good for a man to be alone. You know that in a way young men can't, because you had the answer and now she's gone.

Grieve, out loud, as long as it takes. Keep hold of what remains. The garden. Grandkids. One close friend. Scripture, and your seat on Sunday. Drift loves a widower, and it nearly always shows up calling itself rest. Mr. Pruitt didn't let it in. Married fifty-one years, he planted forty pecan trees the spring after he buried his wife, and Ed still comes for coffee on Wednesdays.

Marrying again is between you, God, your grown children, and her, if there's a her. Some men remarry. Some never do, and those years are full anyway. Your life didn't end when hers did.

This isn't a lobby

Churches can love single men and still preach over their heads. Every illustration starts with "your wife," and nobody looks at the guy alone in the third row. Give it a few years and he starts to think manhood gets handed out at the altar.

The Bible won't back that. Jesus never married, and no one has ever lived a fuller life. Paul was single, and so was John the Baptist. Plenty of the Bible's most fruitful men never had a wife or a child.

Look at the order in Genesis. Adam got nearly his whole assignment while he was

still alone. Made in God's image, blessed, set on the ground, given work and a command, naming each animal as it came by. He was a man with a full job before there was any bride. God brought the woman because He'd named the one thing that wasn't good. She didn't come to flip Adam's switch.

If you have no wife yet, you're already living your life. The ground already has your name on it. If God brings a wife, she'll walk into work you've already started.

If you want to marry

Most of you do, and that's good.

Proverbs 18:22 NIV

He who finds a wife finds what is good and receives favor from the LORD.

Finding means moving. Charm fools people and beauty fades, and Proverbs praises the woman who fears the Lord. Attraction counts. Just weigh it last. First find out how she talks to God, whether she's honest, and whether she's kind to people who can't do anything for her.

Pursue her out loud. Name the evening, and give her a reason she can understand. Circling her for twelve months is a stall. So is an endless text thread that never becomes a plan. She can tell pursuit from hanging around.

Then decide. Seven days is too quick for a lifetime. Seven years without an answer burns through hers. If you know her character and you're still standing in the doorway, the true name for that is passive. That's what Stop Waiting is for, and it applies to courting too. Move toward a covenant, or let her go honorably.

Let an older man get to know her. Watch how she treats her father and her friends. You're getting a preview.

Keep your hands off. Sex outside the covenant clouds your judgment and trains both of you to treat vows as optional. I've never met a man who regretted waiting.

Marry when you can carry it. Feeling ready won't steer you. Steady work, an honest budget, a place to live, brothers, a body you've guarded, and a prayer life. When those are there, and she fears God, and older men say go, go. Paul said it's better to marry than to burn. If you can lift it, lift it.

Build while you wait

Tend the place and guard it. That pattern still holds when the lease has one name on it.

Live in your home instead of camping in it. Clean enough that a brother could crash on the couch. Meals you made. Bills paid on time. If a woman comes along, your apartment will tell her more than any speech on a date.

Feed people. You don't need a marriage license to put chili on the stove. Have the younger guys over. Invite the old man from church who eats alone.

Get brothers now. You need them more than the married guy does, because an empty apartment won't notice when you disappear for a week. Find one man who's further down the road, and don't give drift a whole year.

Give the Lord the hours this season hands you.

1 Corinthians 7:35 NIV

I am saying this for your own good, not to restrict you, but that you may live in a right way in undivided devotion to the Lord.

A dad with three kids under six can't spend a Thursday evening like you can. Burn those hours waiting and you've wasted the one real edge this stretch gives you.

Be a father to somebody. Boys at your church are missing a man, and you've got Saturday afternoons. Toss a ball. Fix his bike. Pray with him in the truck before you drop him home. Paul called Timothy his true son in the faith. The floor plan's different. The work is the same.

Stay clean. The marriage bed is a covenant, and keeping it starts years before the wedding. What you do with your eyes and your hands now is either saving something for her or spending it early.

1 Timothy 5:1-2 NIV

Do not rebuke an older man harshly, but exhort him as if he were your father. Treat younger men as brothers, older women as mothers, and younger women as sisters, with absolute purity.

That covers every woman you aren't married to, including the one you're hoping you will be.

The day he cut the tape

Micah opened that box on a Saturday. No woman had called. An older guy from church had told him to quit asking permission and stop living like a guest in his own place. So he hung the skillet. He set out the plates and cooked for a few men who actually came. He wrote a budget and stuck to it. He started picking up a fatherless boy from church every week. He still wanted a wife. He just stopped treating her like the switch that would make him a man.

None of it took hold in a week, and some Saturdays the skillet never left the hook. But he'll tell you that's where it started, years before any woman said yes.

Not yet is an honest answer. If it's yours, say it. Then open the box. Hope and work can share an apartment.

Why you stay for the rest

Read what's coming like a man framing a house before the family moves in. A lot of married men are patching walls. You can set yours plumb the first time. And there's a fatherless kid somewhere in your church who's watching how you live.

Most of you will marry. Until you do, the ground is yours, and the Father's well done doesn't wait for a second name on the mailbox.

So stand up. Somebody has to build this house.

Before you turn the page

Shut this book without the old whisper that you're only half of something. The most complete Man in history never stood at an altar with a bride. Today your ground is asking for you. And if papers or a casket are what sat you in this chair, your sorrow is real and you still belong here. May the Father, who saw that a man shouldn't be alone, put brothers on your porch and settle the matter of a wife on His own timetable, while you open the box and go to work.

21 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Plenty of men spend years in a waiting room and call it patience. Which seat is yours: never married, divorced, or widowed? Write it down, and then write how long you've been talking as if your real life is still coming.

DO THIS WEEK

Houses go up one task at a time. If you've never married, get one thing done before Sunday: your rooms, a meal for someone, a call to a brother, an afternoon with a fatherless boy, or the honest ask. If you're single again, pick one of those, and tell God two true things, one about what you lost and one about what you did.

TELL A BROTHER

Nobody drifts faster than a man whose week no one sees. Let him know what seat you're in and what you picked to do. If you're divorced and starting to think about dating, ask him straight whether you're ready, and listen to the answer.

CARRY THIS

No wife yet still leaves you a man, with ground to work and a Father who already calls you son.



CHAPTER 22

Know Her

On the windowsill over his sink there's a spiral notebook. When the wrens returned this spring, he logged it that same morning: date, weather, which box they chose. He can hear one note through the glass and tell you chickadee or nuthatch. He's been at it since boyhood.

But if you asked him what scares his wife this year, all those pages wouldn't help him.

Years of meals across from her. He could point to her chair blindfolded. Somewhere along the way he started thinking the chair was her.

Before we talk about a husband laying his life down, or what a wife actually needs, there's something underneath both. You have to know the woman you married.

The Shepherd who knows

Start with how Jesus does it, because that's the pattern.

John 10:14 NIV

I am the good shepherd; I know my sheep and my sheep know me—

Christ knows His church down to the name: the fear, the old wound, the thing she's never said out loud. And what He knows doesn't run Him off. He stays, keeps drawing it up into the light, and the sheep end up knowing Him back.

That's what a husband is aiming at. Not a file on her. A shepherd's attention that doesn't quit.

According to knowledge

Peter wrote one line aimed straight at husbands.

1 Peter 3:7 NIV

Husbands, in the same way be considerate as you live with your wives, and treat them with respect as the weaker partner and as heirs with you of the gracious gift of life, so that nothing will hinder your prayers.

Be considerate. Older translations stay nearer the Greek: dwell with them according to knowledge. Live in that house as a man still learning the woman in it.

Most men read right past the end of the verse. So that nothing will hinder your prayers. A man who lives with a woman and won't bother understanding her has a problem bigger than the marriage. It reaches God. How you know her and how heaven hears you sit in the same sentence.

Men will pore over the things they love for decades. Fishing. Engines. Box scores. Plenty of husbands studied their wives just long enough to get along, shut the book, and have run on those early notes ever since. She kept changing. He kept the notes. Sharing an address won't do the studying for you, and a woman can sleep beside a man for thirty years and remain unknown to him. Stop Waiting, in a marriage, looks like study.

How you learn her

Ask, then wait. Most of us ask and start loading our answer before she's through her first sentence. When she stops, count to ten in your head. She probably isn't done. The true part tends to come after the pause.

James 1:19 NIV

My dear brothers and sisters, take note of this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry,

Listen before you fix. Everything in you will want to solve it. Sit on that. Tell her you're still with her and ask what else. A man who repairs every sentence teaches his wife to stop handing him sentences. A man who listens gets let all the way in.

Watch her. What she does when she's worn out. What gets a real laugh out of her when nobody's performing. Where she turns when she's low.

Write things down. Her sizes. Her friends' names. Something she wanted and mentioned once, back in March. The date her dad passed. The fear she finally admitted. When a thing she said one time comes back to her from you months later, she notices.

Ask her what you get wrong about her. Don't defend yourself. Take notes. Thirty

minutes of that beats a year of guessing.

And pick one night a week to ask her something you can't answer for her. When did you feel most like yourself this week? What do you wish I'd noticed? Take your turn too, so it's a conversation and not an interview.

What there is to learn

"Know your wife" is advice men nod at and never act on, so let's get specific.

Her story. How her dad was with her, and what that taught her to expect from men. What happened before you that she's never told you all of. Ask her to tell it slow. You'll finally see why she flinches at things you'd filed under nothing.

Her actual fears. Ask what scares her most right now, then be quiet. Given room, most wives name something that was nowhere on the husband's list. It's rarely money. It's being left. It's the kids. It's turning into her mother. It's whether he really sees her.

What fills her up and what drains her. A packed room lights some women up and empties others out. Plan the wrong weekend enough times and you'll start calling her difficult, when you just weren't paying attention.

How love lands on her. Men tend to give the love they'd want back: doing, fixing, providing, handling it. Some wives feel that. Others feel it somewhere smaller: you remembered the name of the coworker who's been wearing her down, or you saw she'd gone quiet at the party and took the long way home. Ask her when she's felt most loved by you. Then do that again.

Her body, without getting cute about it. Her cycle, so you pick up more in the week she has less. Pregnancy. The months after a baby. The later changes plenty of husbands sail right past. She lives in that body every hour.

Her walk with God. How she prays, what she's wrestling with, which verse she's holding on to. Then you can pray for something real instead of a foggy "bless her."

Her ordinary day, hour by hour. Three in the afternoon with the kids. The worst stretch of her shift. A man who's never asked will say things that land like a slap and then wonder why she went quiet.

Her people: her friends, her mom, and what those ties cost her. And what she still wants, what she set down, what she quit mentioning because nobody asked. Honor those. Look for ways to hand a few of them back.

Proverbs 20:5 NIV

The purposes of a person's heart are deep waters, but one who has insight draws them out.

She won't float all of it up for you. Drawing it out takes attention, attention takes time, and time takes deciding she's worth it.

Where you are right now

New baby in the house? Then the woman you married is hauling a load you can't see. Months of broken sleep, maybe. Sorrow over the life she had before, and guilt for feeling that sorrow. Shrink your question down to the next sixty minutes: what would help right now? At 3 a.m. nobody can answer the big ones. Keep track of the basics for her: food, a shower, some sunlight, one laugh. If she pulls away from your touch, take her tiredness at its word. It's the load talking, and loads lift.

Pay attention, too, for a darkness that runs deeper than fatigue. Doctors see it all the time and know how to treat it, and the husband is often the one who spots it first. Weeks of her not seeming like herself. Lying awake while the baby finally sleeps. Saying things about herself that scare you. Don't wait it out. Make the appointment and sit in the room with her. Knowing your wife includes guarding her.

A mother of a newborn once said a sentence I wish every husband had taped to his mirror: "I do not need you to fix it. I need you to know how hard this is."

If you're in the middle stretch, juggling jobs and kids and a mortgage, odds are you haven't updated much since the honeymoon. Whatever question you've been avoiding is probably the one the marriage needs.

Married a long time? Then the risk is that you know who she used to be. Your picture of her froze somewhere back there while she kept on living, with a body that changed, new worries, and losses piled on losses. Ask what she hopes for in the time you've got left. Be ready to be surprised.

If the marriage is over and you can see now that you never really knew her, let that be part of what you own when you say "I did this." You're not done learning her, either. Raising kids together without a war means knowing their mother: her worries for them, what lights her fuse, what brings her back down. And if God gives you a wife again someday, open the notebook on the first day.

Single? Get your reps with the women God has already put around you, treating them as sisters. Ask your mom something real and don't interrupt. Do the same with your sister, or a sister in Christ at church. Or ask a married woman you serve

alongside, with her husband right there, what she wishes men understood. No fixing, no flirting, just listening. The man who learns to hear his sister is learning to hear a wife.

A clean page

The man with the bird book finally asked her. Nothing clever. What are you afraid of this year? She gave the easy answer first. He waited it out, and she kept going. He wrote while she talked. Then he turned to a fresh page and put her name across the top.

He's still filling it in. He told me it felt like meeting her all over again, in the same house where they'd stood side by side the whole time.

Those years beside her weren't the study. The study is the page you keep open.

Before you turn the page

Feeling late to this? Nearly every husband is, and late isn't too late. She's watching to see if you'll ask. May the Shepherd who calls each of His sheep by name make you patient enough to keep lowering the bucket, one question at a time.

22 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Some husbands live for decades on a first impression. How much of what you'd tell me about your wife comes from the early years? Write that down, then circle your weakest area: her past, her fears, her body, her faith, her everyday, or the wants she's stopped saying. Single? Write what you'd hope to know about a woman before you make her a promise. Divorced? Write where you knew her least when it fell apart.

DO THIS WEEK

A wife gets known one honest question at a time. Pick a question from your weakest area, ask it, and let her answer all the way through without fixing or defending. Then write down what she told you, on a new page if you need one. Single men, try it with a sister in Christ or a couple you serve with. If the marriage ended, ask your kids' mother one question about them and let her finish.

TELL A BROTHER

Two husbands who think they know their wives can coast for years unless one of them speaks up. Tell him one thing you learned that surprised you. Then ask when he last really studied his own wife, and don't either of you settle for "we're good." If you're single, tell him what you heard and ask if he's ever listened that way.

CARRY THIS

She kept living after you stopped taking notes. Ask her one more question.



CHAPTER 23

Lay It Down

She started crying, and for a minute he honestly didn't know why.

Back up ten minutes. Two people in a bathroom, water over the tile and soaking into the baseboards. Months ago she went with the cheaper plumber. He said the repair wouldn't hold. It didn't. The other quote, the one he pushed for, sat folded in his back pocket like a winning ticket. He could feel the line climbing his throat, the one that settles it. Five words and he wins.

Instead he took out the paper, crumpled it, and tossed it in the wastebasket by the sink.

"I'm sorry I got loud," he said. "We'll figure it out."

That's when the tears came. Later he worked it out. Through every year of that marriage he had never once walked away from an argument he was winning. She was looking at a husband she'd never met.

You've already spent time learning her. This costs more. You lay your life down for her. The wedding, rented tux and flowers, was the easy hour of the vow. A soaked floor on a night when you're the one who's right is where the vow stops being words.

The other half of Ephesians 5

Guys know which line in that chapter they like. It's the one telling wives to submit. It's in the Bible, Paul meant it, and I won't tiptoe around it. But read one more sentence. The part for husbands is longer than the part for wives, it asks for more, and I've never seen a man highlight it with the same enthusiasm.

Ephesians 5:25 NIV

Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her

Christ didn't wait for the church to clean up first. He loved people who kept failing Him, and He kept going until it killed Him. Plenty of us would like the headship without the dying. You don't get to split them. Headship is a cross. The one in front absorbs what's coming, and he does it for her sake, not to guard his position.

Philippians 2:5-7 NIV

In your relationships with one another, have the same mindset as Christ Jesus: Who, being in very nature God, did not consider equality with God something to be used to his own advantage; rather, he made himself nothing by taking the very nature of a servant, being made in human likeness.

Think about who's being described. No one in history stood on higher ground. He stepped down off it, tied a towel around Himself, and washed feet. Paul says: that mind, in you. Picture it with your socks wet and your proof in your pocket.

What it isn't

First let's clear out the fake. It has wrecked as many homes as the bully has.

The fake says, "Whatever you want, babe," and goes back to the couch. He quits making calls, quits stepping out ahead, quits deciding anything, and labels it sacrifice. It's leaving while still sitting in the house. She'll feel the hollow even on nights she gets her way. That's Stop Waiting run backward: a husband who waits forever and gives it a humble name. Jesus gave Himself up and kept leading the whole time. He led on His knees with a basin. He led nailed to a beam. Strength picks her good over its own comfort. Weakness picks a quiet house over doing the job.

The doormat is the same fake in a different coat. Jesus told people He loved things they didn't want to hear. If you never tell your wife a hard truth, you haven't laid down your life. You've abandoned your post. Love waits its turn, listens to the end, picks a good hour, keeps its voice soft. Then it says the thing.

And some men just disappear and think it's godliness. She said yes to someone with a spine and a heading. Sand yourself down until nobody's left and she's lost her husband. Let your rights go, and your comfort, and your pride. Don't let you go. She needs a man in there.

So here's how to tell, after you've given something up. Look at her. Did she get stronger, or did her load get heavier because you went missing? If she's more settled, more like herself, more awake, it was the genuine article. If the house got harder and you called your vanishing humility, it was the counterfeit.

The small deaths

“Lay down your life” sounds like one heroic afternoon. In a marriage it mostly happens in installments, on days only she will remember.

The money might be first. If the accounts are your private country and she gets a visitor’s pass now and then, that’s governing her. Open the books. Give her full sight and a full vote.

Then the argument you’re winning. You’ll win plenty on the facts. Most of those victories charge her more than they pay you. Nobody’s asking you to say the facts changed. You just decide the marriage outweighs the point. Notice the first word of “we’ll figure it out.” That “we” is the thing you’re protecting.

Then your phone. Flip it over at the door, and pocket it while she’s telling you about her day. A buddy of mine once stared at his screen through an entire hard conversation with his wife and then insisted he’d heard every word. She didn’t believe him. Neither did he.

Then your mom’s vote. If the two women in your life land on opposite sides, your wife gets the tie, and Mom hears it from you. You left that house on your wedding day.

Then the audience. When the kids, your parents, or the guys from work are watching, you take her side. She can survive a tough conversation in private if you stood with her in public. Make her the joke and she learns she’s alone, even at a friendly table.

Then your rest. When she’s sick or the baby’s screaming at two, you’re the one out of bed. A man who protects his sleep while she runs on nothing is using her up to keep himself fresh.

Then your weekend and your preferences. Golf isn’t sin, and neither is picking the restaurant. But when home needs you, those lose, without a sulk or a scoreboard. The first fifteen minutes after you get home go to her, not the recliner.

Then the heat. Don’t unload it in front of her. Take it to God, to the cab of your truck, to a brother, and come back with whatever was hiding under it.

For the high performer it’s often the title, being the one who decides. And for nearly all of us it’s the next ten years we mapped out in our heads with her nowhere in the room. Tear that map up. Draw a new one at the kitchen table with both your hands on it.

The promise in it

Jesus said one sentence about this that sounds like losing and is actually a promise.

Matthew 16:25 NIV

For whoever wants to save their life will lose it, but whoever loses their life for me will find it.

Read it as a husband. Give up winning, and you find a wife who brings you the truth because she's learned you won't use it against her. Give up the Saturday, and two decades on your marriage is still alive. Give up the sleep, and she never forgets who got up.

Not one of those gets lost. Your Father notices the fight you threw, the 2 a.m. bottle, the bath she won't remember by lunch. This isn't a pay scale. You're already a son by grace, and what's coming is a Father's "well done." The Son who gave up everything will look at a husband who gave up a little and say, that's how I did it.

Wherever you're standing

If your marriage ended, you might be staring at everything you wouldn't give up while you had the chance. Let that hurt. Tell God your share of it. Then take the next right step. Stop trying to beat your kids' mom. You'll be right sometimes, and they still need parents who can sit in the same row at the recital without a scene. Somebody has to make that happen, so let it be you. Drop the story where she was the whole problem. Leave the rest with God.

If you're single, or nineteen with a ring nowhere close, now is when you practice. A man who's never given up a preference won't suddenly learn between "I do" and the cake. Let the roommate choose dinner. Spend a Saturday helping an older man from church whose gutters are overflowing. Little deaths, on purpose, on regular days. That's how you train.

With a newborn at home, take the night shift before she has to ask twice. Stop keeping the silent ledger of who's had a shower. Do something unpaid and don't advertise it. Leave the bedroom alone until she's ready. Put the gym and the guys on a shelf this year. Love the tired woman in front of you. Your Father sees you at three in the morning.

Decades into a marriage, give up the retirement you dreamed up alone. Ask what she wants those years to be, then go build it. Hand over the remote, and more of the decisions too; she's able, and she's been waiting. When sickness arrives, the illustrations stop working. Mr. Alvarez married his wife in 1968. For three years

now, since illness took most of her away, he has bathed her every morning. Her mind has let go of his name. He has never let go of hers. He promised “in sickness” long before he’d seen that room. The Father sees those mornings.

Back on the wet floor

He was right that night. He threw the proof away anyway. Months later his wife told me that’s when she started bringing him the things that scared her. A husband who’ll let go of a fight he’s winning is a husband who won’t turn her honesty into a weapon.

Sometime this week, you’ll be right. Let it go.

Before you turn the page

You find your life by losing it, and the Father wastes none of the little losses no one else sees. May the One who watched His Son give up everything make you strong enough to let one thing go this week, and may you come home to a different house because of it.

23 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

She feels whatever you're clutching long before you'll admit you're clutching it. Write it down in one full sentence. Maybe it's the money, the argument, your phone, your mother's say, your side in public, your sleep, your Saturday, your temper, the title, or a plan you made without her.

DO THIS WEEK

One grand gesture won't hold a marriage up for a year. A laid-down life gets lived a day at a time. Put that one thing down every day this week, quietly, without keeping score. Single? Give up one small preference a day for someone who's already in your life. If the marriage ended, set down your need to win against your kids' mom at the next handoff.

TELL A BROTHER

You can't see your own grip, and he can. Tell him what you're letting go of and how it went. Then ask him what you're still holding that you've stopped seeing.

CARRY THIS

Being right is not the same as being a husband. Lay it down.



CHAPTER 24

What She Actually Needs

Russ had one boot off and the other in his hand when he heard Renee through the mudroom door, talking to her sister. “Oh, he’s a good provider.” She said it kindly, the way you’d talk about a furnace that has never quit on you in January.

Nothing in it was false. He’d worked the sixty-hour stretches to make it true. But standing there with the boot, he heard it two ways at once. It was the nicest honest thing she had. And if nothing ever got added to it, it was his eulogy.

“You know where people say that?” he asked me later. “About a man at his funeral, when nobody can come up with a second thing.” I’ve sat through enough funerals to know that silence. The room waits for the next sentence, and it never comes.

The part you can count

I will give you the whole chapter in two sentences first. She needs you. A bigger paycheck can’t fill the spot where you’re supposed to be standing.

“Good provider” is a furnace sentence. It tells you the house stayed warm and not much else. Good men get turned around right here, because a paycheck can be counted and being there can’t. Scripture honors the work, and so do I. Pour all of yourself into what’s measurable, though, and you’ll end up with a lovely house and a wife who’s lonely inside it.

The trap for the guys doing a lot right

You work hard for your family. The job wants more, so you hand it more, and it feels like love. Then the signs show up. She stops asking when you’ll be home. You learn what’s going on in your own house from the kids. By eight at night you’re too spent to be anybody. And you’ve decided she wants this life without ever once checking with her.

Russ checked. He sat down across the kitchen table and asked one question: “What do you need from me that you’re not getting?” Renee didn’t have to hunt for it. “Look up when I walk in.” The man had paid for every room in that house, and somewhere along the way he’d stopped raising his eyes when she came into one.

He kept the job. What he changed was smaller and harder.

He laid down a floor, a few things that stay put whatever the job does. Supper at the table four nights a week. Sunday mornings. Bedtime prayers with the kids.

He gave her an hour and kept it. Six forty. Then six forty again the next day. When it was going to slip, he called before he was late, and he called her, not the family thread. A husband who’s predictable about the hour is half home while he’s still on the highway.

He quit handing her the leftovers of himself. For the first hour the phone lives on top of the fridge. She gets the opening fifteen minutes, while there’s still something in the tank.

And he stopped playing to the crowd. Work claps for you. Home mostly doesn’t. Russ quit chasing the clapping and started doing the job for a Father who notices a supper table.

This spring Russ came in through the same mudroom and caught Renee on with the same sister. She didn’t say provider. She said, “He’s here,” and went right on to something about their mom, like that was the most ordinary news in the world.

Eyes up

Being home and being present aren’t the same thing. A man can sleep under that roof every night and never really be with her, and she won’t be able to explain why she’s lonely. Your attention has to walk in the door with your body. Phone away. Ask her something, then stay for all of the answer. She can tell a husband from a warm shape in a chair. In the newborn years, that means being awake beside her at three even when there’s nothing for you to do, and her sleep beats any gift you could buy.

Say it where they can hear

She needs words from you, out loud and specific, sometimes with the kids in earshot. There’s a husband in Proverbs who says it in front of everybody.

Proverbs 31:28-29 NIV

Her children arise and call her blessed; her husband also, and he praises her: "Many women do noble things, but you surpass them all."

That's not a greeting card. It's a man telling his wife she's the best there is, with witnesses. Find your own version and say it before Sunday. If the marriage ended, the kids still need to hear you back their mom up, dependable and civil. Tearing her down from the other house might win a round. Your kids pay for it.

Quit helping

Retire the word "help." The dishes are yours. So are the practice schedule and the dentist appointments. A husband who "helps out" has announced that the house belongs to her and he's a volunteer who drops by. That's Pick Up the Weight, standing at a sink: you carry what's yours without being asked. Eve was called a helper, and that's a strong title, not a small one. Christ came to serve. Neither of those gives a man a pass to sit while she runs the place around him.

Touch that wants nothing

She needs your hands on her in ways that aren't heading anywhere. A palm on her back at the counter. Her feet in your lap after a long day. Your arms around her while she cries, with every fix you can think of left in your pocket. She already knows the bump in the hallway, and she knows the touch that's angling for the bedroom. Give her the third kind.

Nothing to brace for

She needs to not be afraid of you, and I don't mostly mean your fists. I mean the voice that drops, the three-day silence, the sarcasm with an edge, the truck leaving the drive too fast. A wife who checks your weather before she speaks is on guard in her own kitchen.

Proverbs 15:1 NIV

A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger.

A soft answer takes more strength than a loud one. Once she knows your anger won't land on her, she gets a freedom a lot of wives never taste.

No exit in pencil

She needs to know you're staying. A wife can sense an "unless" tucked behind the vows even if you've never said it, and nobody rests in a marriage with a door sketched on the wall. Erase it. Then tell her, plainly and more than once, that you're here for good and you'll face whatever comes side by side. Keep that in the weeks it costs you, and let her watch you keep it. Staying includes your body, too. Book your physical. One fear she won't say out loud is coming home to find you on the floor.

Malachi 2:15 NIV

Has not the one God made you? You belong to him in body and spirit. And what does the one God seek? Godly offspring. So be on your guard, and do not be unfaithful to the wife of your youth.

Chased, and steered

The guy who first asked her out should still be asking. If chasing her was only how you won her, it quit at the wedding, and she knows what it feels like to be put on a shelf. Plan a Thursday and tell her early so she can look forward to it. Press a decent shirt. Get caught watching her across a crowded room. Decades in, she still wants to be noticed as a woman with a name and wants of her own, long after the kitchen has her routine memorized.

She also wants to know where the house is headed so she can finally fold up the map. Tell her what you see coming, and plan the later years together. Make the hard call yourself and own how it lands. Leave her as the only grown-up and she'll steer because somebody must, tired and second-guessing. Once a week, hold her hand and pray out loud. Hearing her husband bring her name to God settles something in a woman.

Someone worth walking with

We've already done the heavy lifting on knowing her, so only this: keep wanting to, and stop acting like the first few years taught you everything.

And let her see you move. A husband who's frozen in place, same guy as ten years ago only grumpier and wider, is one more load on her back. A husband who's changing, slowly, with failures on the record, is a man she can walk next to. Much of a home's hope rides on whether he's becoming someone. If you're single, you're building that man right now. If the marriage ended, lay this chapter next to it, not to beat yourself bloody but so whoever you are next is different.

He did it first

Look back over this chapter and you'll see Christ in every line of it. He doesn't leave. He's with His people always. He calls Himself gentle and humble in heart. He went looking for the lost and still says follow me. He knows His sheep by name. He spoke over bread, this is my body, given for you, and then He knelt with a towel and a basin. He cried at a friend's grave. Even He grew in wisdom and stature and favor.

What your wife wants is a little version of Him, under one roof, on a plain Tuesday night. It will cost you. That's the gift she's been hoping for.

Before you turn the page

If your stomach just dropped, take heart. Hardly anything in this book turns around as quickly. Mostly she's asking you to lift your eyes. May the Bridegroom who never once left His bride give you the courage to ask her one plain question this week, and the patience to listen until she's done.

24 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Many of us are working overtime on a question she never asked. Imagine her sister asks how you're doing as a husband. Write down Renee's kind of answer, the one you'd hate to overhear. Single, or the marriage is over? Write the answer she would have given.

DO THIS WEEK

Only she can see the gap. Sit down and ask her Russ's question, "What do you need from me that you're not getting?" No defending, no explaining. Then do whatever she names first, before Saturday. Single? Call your mom or a sister in Christ and make the call about her life, not yours, or quietly carry one load for a married couple you serve alongside. If the marriage ended, put a kid-sized version of that question to your children and act on their first answer.

TELL A BROTHER

Most of us assumed we knew and never checked. Tell him how she answered. Find out whether he's ever asked his own wife, and admit where each of you has drifted toward the louder applause. If there's no wife, have him tell you which of these you already give the people near you and which ones you're holding back for someday.

CARRY THIS

She doesn't need more of what you make. She needs you.



CHAPTER 25

The Bed Is a Covenant

“I’m doing my part, and she isn’t doing hers.”

That’s how Mitch put it one night, after the game was over and the other guys had gone home. Get married men talking honestly and you’ll hear some version of it when the bedroom has gone cold, usually tired and a little defensive, like a man reading off a balance sheet.

So I asked him what he’d promised her on the day itself. He knew it cold: better or worse, sickness and health, till death. Then I asked him to point to the way out in that sentence. He went back over it, slowly. There wasn’t one. That vow has a single ending, and a man only reaches it standing at a graveside.

Two kinds of promise

Contracts are built around exits. You sign for a set period, both sides watch to see whether the other delivers, and if somebody doesn’t, you leave clean. Plenty of us run the bedroom on those terms without ever being taught to.

A covenant is a plan for staying. In a contract you trade goods. In a covenant two people hand themselves over, which is why it always comes with something you can see and touch. A ring. A cup. A body.

Grooms in the old English service used to put it into words while they slid the ring on: with my body I thee worship. Worship there meant honor, worth-ship. He was promising that his body would spend the rest of his life telling her what she was worth. That’s what the marriage bed is for. It’s the covenant sign, said again every time the two of them are able.

Before anybody got it wrong

Our culture's loudest story says sex is recreation. Both people willing, both eager, that's the whole rulebook, and the other person becomes a means to an end. Plenty of churches told a different story for a long time, that it's faintly dirty, something decent men hurry through and feel odd about later. God told His story first, back before the fall.

Genesis 2:24-25 NIV

That is why a man leaves his father and mother and is united to his wife, and they become one flesh. Adam and his wife were both naked, and they felt no shame.

One flesh, nothing hidden, no shame, and He called it good. The God who designed it isn't embarrassed by it. He stands guard over it.

Hebrews 13:4 NIV

Marriage should be honored by all, and the marriage bed kept pure, for God will judge the adulterer and all the sexually immoral.

Pure means set apart for its purpose and for those two alone.

Paul quotes that same one-flesh line and then says there's a mystery folded inside it, and the mystery is Christ and His church.

Ephesians 5:31 NIV

"For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh."

So the bed preaches. It's meant to say true things about God: He keeps one people, He gives Himself gladly, and He never punishes with silence. When a husband breaks that covenant with his body, or only with his eyes, the sermon starts lying about God.

Keeping it

It's never leverage. No pulling away to punish her. No treating it like a bill she owes. The moment the bed becomes a bargaining chip, the covenant has walked out and two people are just negotiating. A cold bed doesn't warm up because you made her pay. Find out what broke. The break is usually older than the bed, and it runs wider.

Mitch had been keeping a count, and Dana could feel the number in his hands. I asked him if he'd try putting the ledger away for a season. Nothing started with a

payoff in mind. Touch that wanted nothing back. And one calm conversation, in the truck on the way home from her mother's. That's when she said it: "I want to stop feeling like a bill that's past due." It went slower than he wanted. Some weeks he caught himself counting again, she felt it, and they lost ground. Most of a year went by before the house felt warmer, and he'll still tell you it isn't fixed. But he'd had the debt pointed the wrong direction. What he owed her in that bed was the truth about what she's worth.

It's generous. Paul wrote a sentence a lot of men only quote halfway.

1 Corinthians 7:4 NIV

The wife does not have authority over her own body but yields it to her husband. In the same way, the husband does not have authority over his own body but yields it to his wife.

Read the second half again. In Paul's world, that flipped everything. You're there for her delight; your own finish is the lesser goal. Learn how she's made. Ask what would bless her. The husband who asks ends up receiving more than the one who grabs.

It takes its time. Her clock doesn't run like yours, and she knows when she's being hurried toward your finish line. Rushing grabs what the vow promised to give. Slow tenderness is the vow wearing skin.

It talks. Away from the bed, and not in the sting right after a letdown, ask her gently what she'd like more of and less of.

It shows up in the everyday touch. Neglect quiets a marriage bed years before age gets the chance. If your hand only appears when you want something, a day comes when she flinches, and you taught her that.

And it belongs to the two of you alone. Proverbs tells a husband to drink from his own well. Jesus pushed that into the chest: a lustful look is adultery already happening in the heart. A man can keep his body at home and still be leaking out through his eyes. His wife feels the water level drop even if she never finds the crack.

The screen

You already know the tools. One brother who knows everything. A filter whose password he holds and you don't. A charger on the kitchen counter. What changes is why you fight. A living woman is holding your covenant, and each image rips it a little while she sleeps beside you. Those pictures teach your appetite to crave whatever's new, and they whisper that she's the shortage. She isn't. You've been

somewhere else.

None of this is off the clock once the lamp clicks off. Guard your eyes. Trust the Father who sees what's done in secret. He isn't running a debt you're working off. You're His son by grace, and every faithful night is a son living like the family he's in.

No wife yet

Single, and hoping to marry someday? Then what you do with your body now is already shaping a covenant you haven't entered. Either you're saving toward it or you're cashing it in ahead of time. Paul said to learn control of your own body, and learning means it takes reps and time. Where good men tend to fall is the long relationship that never moves toward an altar. Late at night, behind a closed bedroom door, alone together, nobody holds out. If she's the one, and you're ready to carry what marriage asks, go marry her.

Eli showed up at the very start of the book, phone glowing, ten o'clock. If you're single, that hour is the whole battlefield for this chapter, not some wedding night years away. A Tuesday, roommates behind their doors, nobody needing anything from him. Wanting to win didn't win it. He lost that fight a lot first. What finally turned it was dull stuff. At night his phone now sleeps on the kitchen counter. For a year he'd hoped somebody at church would offer to keep his filter password, and nobody ever did, so he went and asked a man eleven years older to hold it. That's Stop Waiting, and it was the hinge. Some nights he'd still get up and walk back out to that counter. Then he'd text the older man, and the older man would answer. At nineteen, self-control looked like that. No victory feeling. A cord plugged in by the toaster and a friend who picks up.

A wife once

Divorced, you're single again, and memory makes it harder. You'll hear that a guy who's done his time in a marriage has earned some freedom. He hasn't. Former husbands don't get an exception. Sex waits for a new covenant, and "we're practically married" isn't a reason to share an address. Use the same tools Eli does. The stakes are higher, too, because your kids are learning from how you handle desire when it aches.

Widowed, you're held to the same line, and I'm sorry it's so heavy. Decades of faithfulness, and still that empty pillow catches you off guard some nights. God doesn't want you calling the loneliness small. He's asking you to honor the bed through these years too. Every faithful night you gave her, He saw. He sees these.

Her seasons, and yours

When a baby comes, remember what her body just survived. Whatever you think you're owed, drop it. She's emptied out and tired of hands on her. Quit the count. Hold her in ways that want nothing back. When she's ready, take it slow, check in, and stop the second she asks. The faithfulness you show her at her most fragile is what she leans on later, when she's strong again.

Sickness can rearrange a covenant without ending it. Gentleness that never gets as far as the bed still counts as keeping the vow.

Somewhere in midlife, her body will change in ways neither of you expected. It isn't a rejection of you. Ask her about it. Sit in the waiting room with her. Men who stay faithful to their own well still drink from it in old age, slower and still sweet. And if a day comes when making love isn't possible at all, faithfulness doesn't end. The two of you are one flesh yet.

Mitch came in hunting for a way out. The vow never had one. What it has is everything you are, already pledged, and a bed where you get to pledge it again.

Before you turn the page

Plenty of good men have fallen here and kept it to themselves. If you're one of them, drag it out where it can be seen. David confessed, and God gave him back his footing. You can begin keeping faith again tomorrow. May the God who calls this bed honorable give you joy in your own wife, guard you from every counterfeit, and make your marriage a true sermon about Him.

25 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

The weak spot you keep hidden stays strong until you confess it to God. If there's one, write it down. Wandering eyes, the phone, rushing her, a scorecard in your head, the cold shoulder, or plain neglect. Single, or the marriage is over? Then write honestly: are you saving yourself toward a vow you haven't made, or spending it ahead of time?

DO THIS WEEK

Promises get said out loud, in the open, long before anybody keeps them in the dark. Married? Sit down with your wife in daylight, somewhere other than the bedroom, and ask her what she'd want more of there and what she'd want less of. Single or divorced? Give a brother the filter password and plug your phone in on the kitchen counter tonight.

TELL A BROTHER

This hunger feeds on secrets. Tell him the weak spot you wrote down. If a screen is involved, give him the specifics: what, how often, and since when. Then hand him the password.

CARRY THIS

A contract keeps score on her. A covenant uses every year you've got to show her she's worth it.



CHAPTER 26

Your Daughter Is Watching

From the second pew at a wedding, you catch a moment most of the room misses. The bride gets to the end of the aisle. Her dad's hand is still on her arm. And before she turns to the groom, she glances at her father. It lasts maybe half a second. She's been giving him that glance since before she could talk.

Most dads think she's asking permission. She's doing something bigger. She's checking the face she learned the world from. That face told her what a man is, what a woman ought to be able to count on, and what she herself is worth. The groom standing two steps away got picked with that face as the reference.

Your daughter is watching you. She's already learning three things from you that she'll carry the rest of her life, and none of them waited for you to sit her down.

A face in the stands

Wade, the man we met earlier whose little girl shrank when his voice climbed, found this out on an aluminum bleacher at his daughter Nora's softball game. She struck out to end the inning, and before she made it back to the dugout she turned, found him in the stands, and studied his face. He'd watched her do that a hundred times. He'd never asked himself what she was looking for.

She was checking what the strikeout cost her. Hits made Wade light up and get loud. Misses made his face sink a little, nothing cruel, just a dad who wanted it for her. But she'd learned to watch for the sink. As far as she could tell, her value went up and down with the box score.

On the ride home he said, "I don't come to watch you hit. I come to watch you." Then he went to work on his own face, which was harder than any speech, because kids can spot gladness that's put on. Before every pitch, Wade decided what his face would do next. Whatever she saw after a strikeout had to match what she saw after a double. It took a season. She quit checking after the misses. These days she looks up

after the hits, because she wants somebody to celebrate with. Wade says that's the gap between a girl who's still checking and a girl who already knows.

What she's learning

She's learning what she's worth. Nora read it off a face in the stands, and your daughter reads it off yours. Attention she has to earn with grades or trophies or looks teaches one thing. Attention she gets for being yours teaches another. A father's delight settles the question so she doesn't have to go hunting for the answer. Hold it back and she'll go find a guy who's eager to say what you never did. The ones who volunteer for that are seldom men you'd have chosen.

She's learning what a man is. You're the first definition she gets, and every man after you is measured against it. Gentle at home, and a harsh man will shock her. Stormy at home, and she'll either marry the weather or spend her life bracing for it. When she watches you walk first into the hard apology, the awkward phone call, the conversation everybody else is avoiding, that's Go First, and she's the one taking notes.

She's learning what a woman can expect, from how her mother gets treated under your roof. Thanked or ignored. Defended or corrected in front of company. Heard out, or met with the eye roll and the three-day freeze. She's keeping notes, and the man she marries will line up with them. Want a preview of the guy who'll come for your daughter someday? Watch how you treat her mom between now and Sunday.

What she needs from you

Delight comes first, and it has to be visible. Approval is something a kid earns by performing. Delight is something she receives for being herself. That's how God is with His own. He takes joy in His children and sings over them.

Zephaniah 3:17 NIV

The LORD your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you; in his love he will no longer rebuke you, but will rejoice over you with singing.

Let your face change when she walks into the kitchen. Gladness that never leaves your chest gives her nothing to read, and she's reading anyway.

She needs time with you, or the delight stays a mood you were in once. A standing breakfast. A drive with the radio off. A walk after supper that survives the years. And she needs a father with backbone when she pushes him away. Plenty of daughters go through a stretch of wanting nothing to do with Dad, and wounded men take the

hint and drift off. She's testing whether you'll stay. Keep the breakfast through the silent months. Say "I love you" through a shut door. When that season ends, she'll know who didn't go anywhere.

She needs words. Girls grow toward the names their fathers call them. Beautiful, meaning all of her. Strong. Mine. "I love you," out loud, every day. One day some boy is going to use that sentence as a key, and it opens fastest on a girl who's been starved for it. Job did something unheard of in his day: he gave his daughters an inheritance right beside their brothers. His name and his weight backed up what they were worth.

She needs to see you honor her mother. Thank her at the table. Take her side. When you blew it, apologize where the kids can hear. Few things will count for more with a girl. Divorce doesn't end that lesson; she's listening to how you talk about her mom from across town. When she tries to recruit you to a side, have one answer and keep giving it: "Your mom loves you. She's doing the best she can. And I won't talk about her like that." You'll see her shoulders drop. She'd been scared she would have to choose.

She needs a guard. God told the first man to keep the garden, and nothing in your keeping matters more than she does. Lock her in a tower and she learns she's breakable and men are the bars. Better is an open yard with a gate where you stand watch. You know what's on her phone and you've told her why. Any boy who wants an evening with her gets an hour with you first. Long before she needs it, she knows the plan if a date's hands wander: say no, get out, call you, and you'll come. And you guard her from yourself, too: the temper, the sarcasm, the bad day that lands on her because she's nearby. Paul has a word for fathers about exactly this.

Ephesians 6:4 NIV

Fathers, do not exasperate your children; instead, bring them up in the training and instruction of the Lord.

She needs to see you pray, and to see where your eyes go. Bring her name to God and let her know you did; a girl whose dad kneels learns to recognize that in a man. She notices when your gaze drifts at the pool or the restaurant. Roving eyes tell her women are scenery. Faithful eyes tell her it's sane to hope for a faithful man.

The Man who took her hand

Jesus was tender with daughters. A synagogue leader's little girl had died, and Jesus went into the room where she lay.

Luke 8:54 NIV

But he took her by the hand and said, "My child, get up!"

Then He handed her back to her father. Follow that Man. He was gentle with a girl who wasn't even His.

If your season looks different

If you're divorced, you'll miss some breakfasts. Don't run down her mother, whether she baits you, whether the complaint is true, whether you're worn out. Half of that girl comes from her mom, so every shot you take hits your daughter. Show up for every hour the custody order gives you, and fight for a few more. Call on the same night each week, even through the long run of "fine" and "nothing." The night she finally opens up was bought by all the nights she didn't. Give her a real place at your house, her own room, her toothbrush in the cup. The divorce shook the ground under her. A dad who's present, clean, and still growing gives her somewhere solid to stand.

If she's grown, she's still watching. Did Dad change? Will he show up for my kids where he didn't for me? Your blessing doesn't expire when she moves out. If you failed her, tell her so plainly, with no excuse stapled to the end. If you've never told her you're proud of her, the call is overdue. Make it anyway. It'll mend a crack she stopped noticing years ago.

If there's no daughter at your house, you're still teaching. Some of you are nineteen with a little sister who reads every move you make. Girls at your church are short on this, so let them see a good man up close. Honor women where they can see it. Coach a team. Be the uncle who shows up and stays in the light. Never alone behind a closed door with a girl who isn't yours. Stay visible, stay above reproach. One of the things they need to learn is that a good man can be safe.

Worth looking for

She's been studying your face since before she had words. The end of an aisle may be the last time she checks it, and she'll find there what she's always found. Make it worth finding.

Before you turn the page

A face that's been teaching the wrong thing can learn the right one, and beating yourself up won't speed that along; she reads guilt as easily as gladness. Wade rebuilt

his the way you rebuild a weak muscle, rep by rep, on ordinary afternoons. May the Father who lights up when His children come home light up your face this week, and may your daughter see how glad you are she's alive.

26 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Your face is her first classroom, whether you ever meant to enroll her or not. Write what she sees from you when her mother walks in, what she sees when she fails, and what you've been calling her lately. If the honest answer is nothing, write that. Silence teaches too. No daughter of your own? Picture a girl in your church watching you with the women around you, and write what she'd conclude.

DO THIS WEEK

Delight that she never gets to see doesn't teach her anything. Tell her one specific thing you love about who she is, nothing to do with what she did, and honor her mom in front of her every day this week: a thank-you, a gentle hand, taking her side, an apology. If she's grown, call her and say the thing you assumed she already knew. No daughter? Once this week, honor a mother or a sister where a girl can see it.

TELL A BROTHER

Dads of daughters almost never talk about this kind of thing with each other. Walk him through what she's learning from you and admit which lesson you've been teaching worst. Then turn it around and find out what his girl is picking up. No daughter? Read him what you wrote about the girl at church, and give him permission to watch you this Sunday and say what he sees.

CARRY THIS

How you treat her mother this week is a preview of the man your daughter will marry.



CHAPTER 27

Give Your Son a Name

The hospital gives you a clipboard and a cheap pen on a chain. You fill in the lines while the baby sleeps through his own paperwork, and it feels like the big moment. It's the smallest one. The real naming starts once you get him home, and it runs for years, mostly in sentences you won't remember saying.

A boy grows toward whatever he's called. Call him trouble and he'll find ways to prove you right. Call him nothing and he'll go door to door until somebody fills in the blank for him. Plenty of people are lined up to do it. Most of them don't love him.

Four seconds of video

Ray didn't think he had a naming problem. Then his wife pulled up a clip from their son's birthday. Candles, a pile of kids, everybody off-key, and under the noise, a little left of the camera, a voice Ray knew was his. "What is wrong with you, bud?"

He couldn't place the moment. That scared him more than the line did. A man forgets what he says on autopilot. On the screen his boy flinched, then his face went smooth again, like he'd filed it for later. Ray ran those four seconds back so many times he quit seeing the cake.

Most of us have a version of that, and it isn't always words. A long breath out through the nose. The look over the top of the phone. I know men past fifty who can still repeat the exact thing, and their voice goes quiet when they get to it.

He's getting named everywhere else too. Kids have handed out labels since recess was invented: slow, weird, scrawny, too much. And failure talks to him all day, because boys miss far more than they make. If no man interrupts that voice, he'll take its word for it. I'm just bad at stuff.

I'm not above any of this. I've got a sigh that comes out before I've decided

anything, and I've watched it land on people.

The name under all the others

Under everything you call him, there's one name, and it sounds different on different days.

Most days it sounds like belonging. You're mine. He hasn't earned it and he can't lose it, and you aren't leaving. Before Jesus had done one public thing, before a miracle or a sermon, a voice came down over the river.

Mark 1:11 NIV

And a voice came from heaven: "You are my Son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased."

The Father said whose He was before anybody had seen what He could do. A boy who's sure he's wanted can strike out, flunk, back the car into the mailbox, and still come home. A boy who isn't sure turns his whole life into a tryout.

Some days the name sounds like I see you. He sends a ball through the neighbor's window, then walks over and knocks on the neighbor's door. "That was honest. You're an honest guy." Now he's got a word for what he just did and something to grow into. Hear it often enough and lying starts to feel like a shoe on the wrong foot. Paul talked to his churches the way a good dad talks, comfort and push in the same hand. Push alone wears a boy out. Comfort alone leaves him soft. You're still mine after that mess. And I know there's more in you than that.

And at some point the name has to say man. Most of us never heard this one from our fathers. Your son needs you to tell him, at an age he'll remember, that he's becoming a man, and what you mean by it. Don't recite anything. Talk like you do on a long drive. Maybe, "A man doesn't sit around waiting to be told. He sees what's his and gets after it. And when he blows it, he owns it and fixes what he can." That's Stop Waiting in a dad's voice. The question is already in him. Am I there yet? A girlfriend, a fistfight, a paycheck, or a lifted truck will answer it if you don't. Get there first. And if your son is grown and never got that word from you, it isn't too late. Tell him you're proud of the man he is.

Saying it until it sticks

You can't hand this over in one talk. It gets in by repetition.

Daily is the small stuff. He carries his grandmother's groceries without being asked, and you tell him, "That's what a man does." Five seconds. Over a few years

they pile up into a floor. Start before he can follow the words; a newborn knows your voice, so leave the phone on the counter and say it over him. Dads of infants often feel like spare parts. This is the job. And a grandson can hear “that’s what a man does” from Grandpa and believe it in a way he won’t from his worn-out dad.

Weekly is a blessing. Pick a night and protect it. Hand on his head, a few honest words in your own voice. It might come out, “You’re my son, and I’m not going anywhere. I watched you own up to that grade on Wednesday, and I was proud of you. God made you for something, and I’m going to help you find it. Now get some sleep.” You’ll feel silly. Say it anyway. Moses told Israel’s fathers to keep God’s words in front of their kids at every hour.

Deuteronomy 6:6-7 NIV

These commandments that I give you today are to be on your hearts. Impress them on your children. Talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up.

Impress is a stamp pushed into leather, again and again, until the shape holds.

If you’re divorced, he’s hearing names in a house you don’t run, maybe a stepdad’s, maybe your silence. You can’t fix the other address. You can own the Tuesday night call and make it the blessing, closing it the same way every time: you’re my son, I love you, I’ll call next week. Never use him to carry messages or report back on his mom. Go-between isn’t a name he should have to wear. He’s yours wherever he sleeps.

Yearly is a letter. His birthday, one sheet, your handwriting. What he’s like right now, what changed in him this year, where you think he’s headed. Put it in a shoebox and keep going, and someday you’ll hand him the box.

Brag on him in public. “My son helped me hang the gate Saturday. Stuck with it till dark.” Keep the correcting behind a closed door, because shame in front of people turns into a label, and so does honor. No son in your house? Some boy at church or on the ball field hears nothing from anybody. Catch him doing one thing right and say it where his friends can hear.

When he fails, pull apart what he did from who he is. Don’t shrug off the lie. Call it what it was, then show him the way back. “You’re my son, and that was a lie. My son goes and makes it right. Come on, I’ll drive.” Tell a boy he’s a liar and he’ll either fight the word for years or become it. Tell him he’s honest and just did a dishonest thing, and he can see the road home.

Then point past yourself. Your name over him is good shade, but it isn't the tree. You'll let him down, and one day you'll be gone. Tell him God made him on purpose, and that the Father who never leaves claims him too.

Ray started late and awkward, with nobody to copy. Once he went looking for things to name, he found plenty. A few months in, his daughter dropped a lamp and burst into tears, and Ray heard his boy tell her, "You're not bad. You did a bad thing. Go tell Mom." The boy had started naming people himself.

His name over you

Everything you say over your boy is borrowed. God said it first, over His own sons, and He hasn't stopped saying it: you're Mine, and I'm glad you're home. He says it over every man in Christ, including you, whether your father ever got a sentence out or not.

Psalm 127:3 NIV

Children are a heritage from the LORD, offspring a reward from him.

Your son is a gift the Lord put at your kitchen table. He's asking who he is all day, mostly without words. You get to answer. Give him a name sturdy enough to hold him when he's old.

Before you turn the page

Nobody named you? You can still name him. Ray didn't feel qualified the night he first put his hand on that boy's head. Putting it there is part of how Ray grew up. The sigh and the "bud" can be swapped tonight for a few plain words. May the Father who called Jesus beloved before He'd done anything give you the nerve to say the same over your son, and may your boy stand his whole life on a floor that won't give way.

27 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Men rarely hear their own sighs. Write down, honestly, what your son has been called by you lately: the words, the looks, the good ones and the bad ones. If you're a man nobody ever named, write that down too.

DO THIS WEEK

One talk won't do what a hundred ordinary days will. Each day, catch one thing worth naming and say it. One night, put your hand on his head and bless him in words that sound like you. No son at home? Find a boy who's missing a dad and tell him one good thing you saw.

TELL A BROTHER

Another man will catch the names you can't hear yourself saying. Tell him what you've been calling your boy. Ask what his dad called him, and what he's calling his own kids now. No son? Tell him the name your father gave you, and about the boy you spoke up for this week.

CARRY THIS

Your boy will grow toward whatever he's called. Make sure the voice doing the calling is yours.



CHAPTER 28

Give Your Son a Hill

Lyle figures he was eleven or twelve. An October morning, and the faucet over the kitchen sink gave a cough and went dry.

That house drank from a spring on the rise behind it. His grandfather had boxed the spring in concrete a generation back and run a line down through the pasture, one branch to the house, one to the cattle. No water meant somebody was walking up there.

He'd been up there before, but only as the kid holding the bucket. This time his dad looked out the window and said, "Spring's quit. Go see to it." That was it. No "come on." No "I'll show you."

Lyle told me this at seventy-something, the place long since sold. He got to the gate at the edge of the yard and froze. The lid on that box was heavier than he was. He turned to say he couldn't, and his dad had already carried his coffee outside and settled onto the back step. He wasn't getting up.

So the boy climbed. It ate the morning. The lid slipped and pinched his fingers. A possum had drowned in there and lay across the screen, and nobody else was going to move it. His arms went numb from that water while he dug out the mud. He fit the pipe wrong, saw it, did it over. Every so often he looked back toward the house. His dad hadn't moved.

Before he reached the yard he could hear water running into the trough. He walked up soaked, filthy, a couple of knuckles split open. His dad studied him a long second. "Well. I figured you could."

It took Lyle years to understand why the man sat. If his dad had walked up with him, Lyle would have come home believing he needed help. Because his dad stayed put, he came home knowing he didn't.

Lyle's rule

He's been sending boys up hills ever since: his own, his grandkids, a Sunday class full of other men's sons, some with nobody ever waiting at the bottom. He says grandsons are easier. He's got time, tools, and a patience he didn't have at thirty. I asked him what he'd learned. "Pick the right hill. Stay on the step. Say the right thing when he comes down." Then he grinned. "And don't tell his mother what was in the box."

You named your boy. Now hand him something steep enough to make the name true. Calling a son strong and never giving him anything heavy is just being nice.

Sitting on the step

Start with your part, because it's the hard one. Hand it over. You'd be faster. That's the point. If you finish it, he doesn't get it. The man who fixes things for a living has it hardest. You could solve it with one call, and he'd learn that Dad is the answer.

Let it be hard for him. Let the lid pinch. That starts in diapers: let him wrestle the toy a minute before you rescue it. A man who can't bear the baby's crying usually can't bear the teenager's sulking either. His mom may find this harder to watch, and that's love in her, not weakness. Decide it together, gently. Rescue a safe boy and he learns he needs saving. Leave him to work and he finds out he can manage. Sitting there empty-handed is the work, even when it looks like you've wandered off.

That's Stop Waiting, and here it flips. The thing that's yours to do, starting now, is to give him the job and keep your seat. The passive father is the one who grabs the shovel. Everybody's more comfortable. Nobody grows.

Losing a little now is a gift. Forty bucks gone because he didn't plan is cheap tuition. Shield him from every scrape and his first real one shows up alongside a wife, a house payment, and nobody watching from the porch.

When he gets back, ask. How'd it go up there? What did you figure out? What would you change? Let him think. Then name it. I figured you could. You stuck with it. Without that sentence, a hard day is only a hard day.

Then make the next one steeper, and the young man who leaves your house will have a man's hands.

Hebrews 12:11 NIV

No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness and peace for those who have been trained by it.

Neither of you should expect pleasant. You're both waiting on later.

Why he needs it

Boys turn into men by facing things slightly too big for them while a man they trust watches and refuses to jump in. Protect a boy from all of it and you starve him. Watch Abraham and Isaac going up the mountain.

Genesis 22:6 NIV

Abraham took the wood for the burnt offering and placed it on his son Isaac, and he himself carried the fire and the knife. As the two of them went on together,

The heavy, awkward load is on the boy. The father keeps the dangerous things, fire and blade, and stays alongside. Then there's Jesse, who didn't give David a pep talk. He gave him sheep.

1 Samuel 17:34-35 NIV

But David said to Saul, "Your servant has been keeping his father's sheep. When a lion or a bear came and carried off a sheep from the flock, I went after it, struck it and rescued the sheep from its mouth."

The lion wasn't a drill. It came because the job was real. By the time the giant showed up, David had a history of hard things behind him. Even Jesus grew up learning a trade under Joseph's eye, and Luke tells us He grew in wisdom and stature. Growing takes something to push against.

A boy who gets affection and nothing difficult goes hungry, and he'll feed himself. What boys pick on their own tends to be dangerous. The fight. The dare. Gravel at night with the headlights off. Or he disappears into his room for years, because nobody showed him how to climb and every slope looks bottomless.

How you know it's a hill

Somebody besides him has to need it. The house really has no water until he's done. Boys know when a chore is fake. Make him sweep a spotless garage for his character and he'll sweep it and roll his eyes.

It should stretch him without breaking him. Harder than what he handled last month, nowhere near a grown man's full weight. If it's easy, nothing happens. If it's impossible, he learns to quit.

He has to be able to fail. A pinched finger is allowed. Coming back down with the job undone is allowed. Take away every way he could fail and there's no hill left. Lyle's dad knew that box, and he knew the snakes were already holed up for the cold. He picked the hill. Then he picked the step.

The finish has to belong to him. A boy says, "I tried." A man says, "It's done," or, "It isn't yet, and here's my plan for tomorrow." Up there he learns that trying isn't a finish line. The trough fills or it doesn't.

And somebody has to speak when he comes down. Whether he nailed it or made a mess, you say something. Before the climb, "you can do this" was your hope. After it, he's got proof in his arms.

Fit the hill to the actual kid, not the number on his cake. Two brothers a year apart might need very different ones. Your daughter needs hills too, and a dad who calls her strong when she comes down. Hers may look different. The way you hand it over doesn't. It could be hauling in the groceries, every last bag, however many trips. It could be something that's his start to finish: a row of tomatoes, a dog, the trash to the curb on Thursday with nobody reminding him. It could be a summer working for a man who won't grade on a curve. Money he could lose. A choice you'd have made differently that you let stand. A night in the woods that feels scary and that you've quietly made safe. Someday the hill is his whole life, and your part is answering the phone.

Some things only look like hills. A sport where it's really the dad who needs the win. And screens, which hand him the rush of climbing with none of the weight. He can beat level after level and the sink is still dry.

Where fathers miss

Some dads start with a cliff, and the boy decides climbing means getting crushed. Some hand their sons the dream they never finished. Some swoop in at the last minute, calling the coach or covering the bill, and every swoop tells the boy, you couldn't. Some mock the stumble, and from then on he steers around anything hard. A divorced dad has his own version: weekends only, guilt in charge, anything tough edited out so the boy will want to come back. Give him real work at your house instead, and leave something half-built so it's waiting for him. The lid caught Lyle's fingers. He set the pipe crooked. His dad didn't comment on either.

I figured you could

Paul told Timothy, his son in the faith, to expect hardship the whole road.

2 Timothy 2:3 NIV

Join with me in suffering, like a good soldier of Christ Jesus.

That's who hills make. A tested man who can walk up alone and fix what's broken.

Your boy is standing by that gate right now, looking back to see what you'll do. Sit down. Stay put.

Before you turn the page

Keeping your seat is hard obedience, and most of us stand up too soon. If you have, he isn't ruined. Boys are tougher than we think, and it's not too late to hand him one. The Father who watched Abraham load wood onto Isaac, and who one day laid a cross on His own Son, knows what it costs to watch a son carry weight. May He help you choose the right hill this week, give you the stubbornness to sit through it, and put Lyle's dad's words in your mouth when your boy comes down.

28 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

A boy can be loved and never stretched, and he'll feel what's missing. Write down whether your son is climbing anything right now that's real, a stretch, and his to finish. If not, write what's been in the way. Too much protecting, or doing it for him.

DO THIS WEEK

One hill teaches the whole lesson. Before Sunday, give him one that fits him, then sit on your hands. Afterward, get him talking about what he figured out, and tell him what you watched him do. No son? Find a fatherless boy, give him a real job, and sit where he can see you.

TELL A BROTHER

By yourself, you'll misjudge the size of it. Tell him what you handed your son and how hard it was to keep still. Ask what hard things his father gave him, and what he's handing out now. No son? Tell him about the boy you sent up a hill, and whether you managed to stay seated.

CARRY THIS

Praise with no climb behind it doesn't hold. Give him the hill, keep your seat, and speak when he gets back.



CHAPTER 29

Give Your Son a Day He Will Not Forget

There's a boy I know who keeps a brass plumb bob in his pocket. It's small and surprisingly heavy, with his name and a date cut into the side. His dad says he'll pull it out in a grocery store parking lot for no reason, just to hold it. A few miles from his house, on a gravel bar under a county bridge, sits a little pile of creek rocks nobody has moved. Some afternoons he rides his bike down there to look at them.

His dad told me about the morning both of those things happened. Before I pass it on, here's why it matters.

Why give him a day

Most of us never got one. We kept waiting for somebody to tell us we'd arrived, and the waiting quietly turned into a whole life. Your son doesn't have to wait like that.

God has always given His people things to bump into. When Israel crossed the Jordan, Joshua had men haul stones out of the riverbed and stack them on the bank, and he said why.

Joshua 4:6-7 NIV

to serve as a sign among you. In the future, when your children ask you, 'What do these stones mean?' tell them that the flow of the Jordan was cut off before the ark of the covenant of the LORD. When it crossed the Jordan, the waters of the Jordan were cut off. These stones are to be a memorial to the people of Israel forever.

A pile of rocks built to start a conversation with a kid who hadn't been born yet. Passover had a child's question built right into the meal. And Jesus heard His Father speak over Him, out loud, at a river, before His work began.

Most Christian homes have nothing like this for a son. Birthdays, graduation,

sure. But no morning when the men in his life look at him and say plainly, you're a man now. So he grabs a marker from whatever's lying around. A girlfriend. A drunk night. A fight. Hand him the real thing instead.

The creek

His voice had started to crack that year, and he'd taken to studying grown men the way younger boys study trucks. His dad told him to be dressed by five, and wouldn't say why. They drove out in the dark and parked by the bridge where he'd been baptized two summers before. Nobody talked on the walk down.

Five men stepped into the creek. Alton, his grandfather, went in ahead. His dad. His dad's brother. The friend his dad meets with every week. A neighbor who'd taught the boy to fish, a single man who'd never been asked to anything like it. The water barely covered their ankles and it was cold enough to knock the air out of you. Each man bent, came up with a stone, waded back, and set it at the boy's feet.

Alton read the Joshua passage. Then the men talked, one at a time. His uncle told him the worst thing he'd ever done, and what he did the morning after. When it came around to his dad, he laid his hand on the boy's shoulder and said the name he'd been saying over him since the hospital: my son. Then something new. "You're becoming a man. That's what this morning is about." Then what he meant by it, in his own plain words. "A man does what's his to do, even on the days nobody's looking. That's most of it." He'd written it all out by hand on a card so the boy could keep it.

Alton reached into his coat, came out with the plumb bob, put it in the boy's palm, and told him what it was for. After that, every man laid a hand on him and prayed, and they all went to breakfast, where the men talked to him like a man. His dad says the boy heard the difference.

A line that doesn't lie

Alton had hung a plumb bob against every wall of the house the boy's father grew up in. You already know what a plumb line is for, and Alton didn't give a lesson on it. He kept it to a few words. "The weight's on purpose. A light one drifts in any breeze. Be the heavy kind, hard to push off true." The name on the side, he said, is for the day the boy forgets who he is.

His dad says it's already come out of that pocket a few times, once over going along with the crowd at school, once over the truth about a grade. Your boy's

keepsake doesn't have to be brass. A Bible with the date inside, a great-grandfather's watch, a good tool. Pick weight over price, and say what it means when you hand it over.

Putting the morning together

The turn in him tells you when: the voice, the shoulders, the way he's started watching men. If you've missed it, give him the morning anyway. Keep it small, a few men he already looks up to who'll still be around long after breakfast, because a crowd turns everybody into a performer. Don't have those men yet? Start looking now. Go outside, early, somewhere that means something, and make him work a little to get there. Tell him something's coming, not what. Let his father speak last, in words that sound like him and nobody else, and if he chokes up, let it show. A boy who watches his dad cry while blessing him learns what no program could teach him. And know going in that the weeks after matter more than the morning. The leader guide at walksteadfast.com has the planning details. If you want one verse read aloud, I keep coming back to this one.

1 Corinthians 16:13 NIV

Be on your guard; stand firm in the faith; be courageous; be strong.

The Monday after

The morning doesn't finish anything. I know a family that poured everything into one beautiful day and went right back to treating him like a little kid by Monday. What makes it true is how he's treated afterward. Bigger hills. His opinion asked for and then actually used. Grown-up work, grown-up correction, a grown man's standard, and mercy when he blows it. The day marks the spot. The weeks after it do the handing over.

Alton worked for the county most of his life. He says his retirement dinner was the best night of his working life, and the morning after was the worst. Applause, then nobody needing him. So the very next week he called his grandson to come help pour a footing. The creek told the boy he was a man. The footing started making him one. Granddads, that's your opening. You've got standing, maybe a keepsake in a drawer, and the years to make the weeks afterward real.

If no one gave you one

Maybe nobody ever did this for you, and you can feel it in your throat. You may think you can't give what you never got. That's fair to feel, and it's wrong. Giving it heals the same place receiving it would have. I know fathers who never heard a word from their own dads, who stood by the water, came apart halfway through blessing their boys, finished anyway, and drove home changed. Want it closed out?

Afterward, ask a man further down the road to lay a hand on you and say it. You're a man. You did right by that boy. It isn't too late for you.

What do these stones mean

Someday a grandson will pick up that brass bob, or ask about the rocks under the bridge. The answer will be a gray morning, a cold creek and the men who waded it, a card in a father's handwriting, and the bob a grandfather hung beside every wall he built. And if we've done our part, whoever's telling it will go set up a morning for his own son.

The day is where it starts. Every week after it is the rest.

Before you turn the page

Even if no one ever gave you a morning like this, there's a word I'd want said over you, and it isn't too late. May the Father who stacked stones beside a river give you the men, the morning, and the nerve to say the new word out loud. May your boy carry something heavy in his pocket that keeps reminding him whose he is.

29 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

A man nobody marked tends to leave his son to make up his own mark. Write down whether anyone ever gave you a day, and if not, what you grabbed instead. Then write the honest answer for your son: is a day coming, or is he left to guess? Ask it for your daughter too. Hers may be supper instead of sunrise, with her mom and grandmother there, but mark your son and leave her guessing and you've done half.

DO THIS WEEK

You can decide this week even if the morning is months off. Pick the date, the men, the place, and the keepsake. Write out what you'll say with your hand on his shoulder. Divorced? You can still do this, and you should. Talk to his mom first, before he hears a word, and keep it about the boy. A good stepdad might be worth inviting. If she pushes back, use your own time and your own men, and keep the old fight out of that morning. Single, or no son? You can be the neighbor at another boy's creek. Find a dad you trust, or a mom raising a boy alone who'd be grateful, and offer to stand in the water. Talk to her before you plan a thing.

TELL A BROTHER

Nobody ends up standing in that water without being asked. Ask him to wade in with you and come with something true to say to the boy. If he's got a son, ask when that boy's morning is, and offer to come.

CARRY THIS

One morning tells him he's a man. A hundred ordinary weeks afterward are what make it so.

PART FIVE

The Long Road



CHAPTER 30

You Were Made for a Work

After a hard rain, Gil's out on the county motor grader before sunup. Same machine he's run since his youngest was born. Forty miles of gravel, and after every storm he scrapes the ruts back out. School buses use those roads. The ambulance does too.

One Sunday he cornered me after church. Every sermon he'd heard on calling had cut his week in half. The real stuff happened in the building. His hours behind the blade just paid for the privilege of showing up.

"I'm just running a blade," he said. Then he asked me straight out whether any of it counted with God.

Think about who rides on that road. God saw it before Gil did. Underneath his question is one most of us carry: is my job part of my life, or the toll I pay until life starts? If it's only a toll, most of your waking hours don't matter. The Bible won't let me say that.

Does it count?

Yes. Paul answered that question for people whose jobs were far worse than Gil's. He was writing to slaves, men with no say at all over their work.

Colossians 3:23-24 NIV

Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for human masters, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving.

That's Work for God's Pay, at five in the morning in a county truck. Nobody in that county knows Gil's name. The Lord does, and He's the one Gil is really working for. A time card turns into an offering.

Hear the word pay correctly, though. It isn't a wage. The pay is the inheritance

the Lord gives His children, handed over by grace to sons already in the family, never a paycheck that buys your way into heaven. Nobody earns an inheritance. You get one because you belong, and in Christ you do. Gil doesn't grade roads to get saved. He grades them because he's already the Father's son, and sons like doing their father's work well.

It also means the job isn't who you are. You're a son first, maybe a husband and dad, a man God trusted with some ground. Your job is one plot of it. Make it your name and you'll die a little when it ends. And watch the quieter trap. Work applauds in a way home rarely does. One more hour at the office sounds awfully reasonable when the new baby won't stop crying. Stay late because it's easier than walking in the door, and a good gift has turned into a hiding place. Providing is holy. Ducking out isn't.

Why I told Gil yes

Work isn't part of the curse. Before anybody sinned, God put the man in a garden to work it and take care of it. Thorns showed up later. Read only the fall and you'll think God barely puts up with your paycheck. And God Himself works. When the religious leaders complained that Jesus healed on the Sabbath, He told them plainly.

John 5:17 NIV

In his defense Jesus said to them, "My Father is always at his work to this very day, and I too am working."

You bear the image of a God who stays on the job. That's why losing the work cuts so deep. And for most of His years, Jesus worked with His hands for paying customers. We talk about three years of ministry. The rest was sawdust.

Work feeds people. Paul said whoever refuses to work shouldn't eat, and he meant refuses. The man who can't is under grace. A divorced dad may be feeding two households and a lawyer. Take the hours if you must, and stay reachable. A two-minute call from the truck costs nothing, and a dad who goes to work and comes back gives shaken kids ground to stand on. Work serves people, too. Forty honest hours are forty hours of loving your neighbor, and careless work is careless love. Paul even told thieves what to do instead of stealing.

Ephesians 4:28 NIV

Anyone who has been stealing must steal no longer, but must work, doing something useful with their own hands, that they may have something to share with those in need.

The taker becomes a giver. And leave a thing better than you found it and you get a small taste of what God felt on the sixth day. That good tired feeling is the image showing through.

After the last shift

You met Alton at the creek, and heard about the morning after the retirement party. The Bible doesn't hand you a recliner. It hands you a new shift.

Numbers 8:25-26 NIV

but at the age of fifty, they must retire from their regular service and work no longer. They may assist their brothers in performing their duties at the tent of meeting, but they themselves must not do the work. This, then, is how you are to assign the responsibilities of the Levites.

The older Levites set the heavy loads down and stayed Levites, standing beside the younger men still hauling the poles.

Alton never turned off his alarm. Sleep in, he says, and drift owns the morning. He reads a chapter aloud on the porch. Every day he finds one thing somebody is counting on, a footing, a widow's gutters, the church van. "A man with no job by noon," he told me, "is a man in a chair by two." He spends time with a couple of younger men who need somebody out in front. His grandson gets hills.

Sometimes the body quits before the calendar does. I know a man who can't leave his wife for more than an hour, so he uses that hour to call widowers and ask how they're holding up. Drift likes older men, and anger rides in with it through the TV. Carry less. Help more. Keep passing along what you know.

When it's taken

They call you in on a Thursday. By Friday there's nothing on your calendar. The money usually isn't the first thing that hurts. For years you've introduced yourself with a sentence, and now it ends at "I'm."

Tell your wife that same day, before you have a plan. Men sit on a layoff for weeks, and she ends up hurt more by the hiding. Tell a brother that week, and when he asks what's heavy, answer him. Then make the search your job. Same alarm, shave, at the kitchen table by eight. Take temporary work if it keeps the lights on. Nothing honest that feeds your family is beneath you. And refuse the shame. Guilt points at something you did. Shame points at you. Losing a job is neither. It's a thorn, and it didn't surprise your Father.

When you hate it

Some of you can't stand your job, and hearing that it's worship sounds like a slap. Fair. Bosses who don't know what they're doing, people who lie to your face, systems built to grind you down. Solomon had every comfort there is, tried every sort of labor, and still landed here.

Ecclesiastes 2:24 NIV

A person can do nothing better than to eat and drink and find satisfaction in their own toil. This too, I see, is from the hand of God,

You can still find something to hold. Get good at the craft, because skill belongs to you. Notice who's beside you. A younger guy is learning how to handle a rotten Tuesday by watching you. Somebody on your crew is losing his marriage and needs one person to talk to. And settle who you're working for. Work for a manager and his moods own you. Work for the Lord and they don't.

If it's time to go, go well. A bad week isn't a resignation letter. Make a plan, talk it through with your wife if you're married, line up the next job or enough savings, and let a brother test your reasons. Some men storm out. Others stay thirty years somewhere that's burying them and call it faithfulness.

When the work is at home

Some work doesn't look like work, even to the man doing it. The budget worked out so you're home with the kids. Or you run the house while your wife works the long shifts. Nobody hands you a check for it, and it's as real as any job in this book. That's the keeping half of the garden. Tend it. Guard it. Your Father notices what's done in private, and He doesn't measure you by how many people drive past.

Finished

On His last night before the cross, Jesus prayed this.

John 17:4 NIV

I have brought you glory on earth by finishing the work you gave me to do.

The bench, the preaching, and the cross were one assignment, and He saw it through. Every man wants to say something like that when his time's up. Yours might be a grader, a classroom, a crew, or a kitchen full of kids.

Gil still runs the blade. Last spring he started praying for each house as he crowns the road in front of it. People drive his gravel every morning with no idea the man

who smoothed it asked God to keep them safe.

Go do your work.

Before you turn the page

If you've figured your hours were wasted on God, carry a different picture in tomorrow: Jesus with sawdust on His arms for most of His life. Laid off, worn out, or holding a retirement plaque, you haven't been set aside. You've been moved to a different plot. May the Father who never stops working put one job somebody needs into your hands before lunch tomorrow.

30 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Men punch a clock for decades and never ask what it was all for. Write which purpose your work has mostly served: worship, feeding your family, helping people, or leaving things better. Then be honest about the drift. Is the job becoming your name, your escape, or your idea of how you get saved? Single? It may be your biggest plot right now. Work it like ground you'd be glad to share someday, but don't marry it.

DO THIS WEEK

A task quietly done for the Lord is worship you can actually finish. Choose one part of your job this week, do it for Him, and keep it to yourself. Between jobs? Then Monday is a full workday of looking. Retired? Decide tomorrow's job before bed and have it done before lunch.

TELL A BROTHER

The man hiding in extra hours almost never sees it himself. Tell him whether work has been your way out, and what it's cost at home. If your paycheck years are over, show him how you're spending your days and ask him to keep you honest.

CARRY THIS

God handed man work before anything went wrong. When the old plot is gone, He gives you a new one. Finish yours.



CHAPTER 31

Feelings Are the Dash, Not the Wheel

My friend Clay learned to drive a tractor from Vernon the summer he got big enough to be worth something out there. Vernon rode the fender and Clay got the seat. Before Vernon would let him steer, Clay had to call out every gauge, oil, water, amps, like a pilot running a checklist. “Those don’t lie about the machine,” Vernon told him. “Read ’em every pass.” Then he pointed at the line he’d cut the trip before. “That’s your road. Put your right wheel in that and leave it there.”

So of course Clay stared at the gauges like a ballgame was on and put a curve in the whole field. Vernon didn’t yell. One knuckle on the glass of the water gauge, then a finger aimed back at the furrow.

Weeks later they were dragging a disc up the long side and the engine started heating. Clay’s row looked perfect, so he watched the needle climb and kept going. Vernon heard it in the motor. “You looking at that?” Yes sir. “Then why haven’t you done anything about it?” Clay had nothing. He says he’s still chewing on that question.

Here’s what Clay eventually figured out. The gauge was honest about the motor. It had no clue where the fence was. Ignore it and you cook the engine. Steer by it and you’re all over the pasture. Feelings work the same way. They’re the dash. They report. Somebody else has to drive.

The One who felt everything

This chapter isn’t about shutting feelings off. Look at Jesus. He cried at a friend’s grave. In the garden He told His closest friends the sorrow was about to kill Him. Hebrews remembers loud cries and tears. Every needle on His panel moved.

None of them took the wheel. He asked the Father for another way, laid His will

under His Father's, and walked toward the cross, the exact thing every reading in His body wanted to avoid. Felt, spoken, obeyed. That's the pattern for this whole chapter.

Two ways into the ditch

Nearly every man I know ends up in one ditch or the other.

One man tapes over the dash. Ask him and he's "good." He says frustrated when he's enraged, worn out when he's grieving, busy when he hasn't had a real conversation since spring. The tape doesn't stop the readings. They leak out sideways, as temper, as appetite late at night, as a man who's home but not really there. He swears he's not emotional. His emotions have had the keys for years. Often he's the man who's best at work. He overrides every feeling from eight to six, and his family gets the leaks after the garage door closes.

Plenty of older men were raised with electrical tape over the whole cluster. It isn't too late to learn the names: grief as friends die off, fear of what your body's doing, a widower's loneliness. Go be with the people you still have.

The second guy gives the keys to the needle on purpose. "I don't love her like I used to." "God feels far, so maybe this faith thing isn't for me." Honest words, disastrous turn. Marriages end because a mood moved. Pews empty because a warm feeling cooled. He gets praised for his honesty and ends up nowhere.

Scripture gives us another way through. Say every reading out loud, to God and to a brother who knows you. Then take your direction from what stays put when the forecast changes.

What the readings mean

Nobody explained the panel to most of us, so here goes.

Fear: something you love feels exposed, and you're not sure your arms are long enough. Ask what you're scared to lose. Anger: a wrong, real or perceived. Dig under it, because anger is usually fear or shame with its jaw set. Sadness: a loss. Grieve it on purpose. Men skip this reading most, and unattended grief turns into a slow drift. Loneliness: God looked at a man alone before sin ever entered the world and said that wasn't good, so this one is as trustworthy as they come. It's an instruction to go find men, not a verdict on what you're worth. Single men, let it point you at brothers, and turn down whatever promises the fastest relief. Numbness: you've redlined so long the sensor fried. Quiet isn't always peace. Shame: not "I did wrong,"

but “I am wrong.” Hold it to Scripture, because it’s the biggest liar on the panel. Guilt is working fine when it points to a thing you did. Joy: you’ve come close to the work God built you for. Notice what your hands were doing.

Open the Psalms and you’ll find strong men reading their gauges out loud. David said things to the Lord most of us wouldn’t say to our wives.

Psalm 42:5 NIV

Why, my soul, are you downcast? Why so disturbed within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise him, my Savior and my God.

First breath, he reads the gauge. Second breath, he grabs the wheel and turns toward God. That’s the manual.

What steers instead

Four things don’t swing with the weather.

God’s Word. If your heart says one thing and Scripture says another, Scripture is describing what’s real. Your heart is describing your morning.

Your vows. You made a promise in front of God and people. Promises exist for the days the feeling goes missing.

Your brothers. They ride in the passenger seat, so they read your dash from an angle you never get.

The marks. They don’t drift with your mood either. When you can’t tell what to do next, one of the four is usually lying at your feet. Pick that one up.

Back to Vernon’s field. The water temp rises on a long pull. You can’t pretend you didn’t see it, and you can’t drive toward it, because a gauge isn’t a direction. So you name it: she’s running hot. You ease out of the row, let her cool, check the radiator, and slide back into the furrow you’d already started. Your driving adjusted. Your destination didn’t move an inch.

What a mood can’t settle

Your forgiveness. Christ settled that on a cross. “I don’t feel forgiven” is a reading, and readings don’t reopen closed cases.

Your marriage. Every couple married long enough hits a stretch where that needle sits on E. Drive by it and you’ll end up in a lawyer’s office. Keep your grip on the covenant, and a decade on it can lift again over a marriage your feelings never could

have built. Married men, your wife is not your dash. You don't steer by her mood, and she shouldn't have to steer by yours. Young and single, the same goes for the wife you hope for. She's not your thermostat. Freshly divorced? For a year or two you'll see readings you didn't know the panel could show. Take every one to God and your brother, and leave the big controls alone: no move, no quick remarriage, no quitting the job or the church. Broken gauges mean slow and straight until they're fixed.

God's will. "I feel led" can be a holy sentence, and it can be a mood wearing a robe. Put it next to Scripture and in front of the men who know you best. Ask whether it lines up with the marks or just points at the exit.

Proverbs 28:26 NIV

Those who trust in themselves are fools, but those who walk in wisdom are kept safe.

Hunger, exhaustion, and a gray week bend every needle. Midnight decisions belong to the weather. Sleep, then talk it over in daylight with a brother. A new dad lives in that weather, every gauge pegged and none reliable. No marriage talks at 3 a.m. Pick a phrase together now: "That's the tired talking. We'll pick this up after a nap."

The broom bush

This is the heaviest end of the panel, and men die there. For some of you this isn't a blue week. It's been dark for months. Elijah was a day removed from calling down fire on Carmel when he ran into the wilderness alone and prayed this.

1 Kings 19:4 NIV

while he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness. He came to a broom bush, sat down under it and prayed that he might die. "I have had enough, LORD," he said. "Take my life; I am no better than my ancestors."

Look how God answered. No rebuke. An angel woke him with bread and water, let him sleep, then fed him again. Only after the meals and the rest came God's voice, a new assignment, and a companion.

So tell God what you're reading, and then tell a person. If your reading is "I'm done," a human being needs to hear it from your mouth this week. And look after your body. God's opening move with a suicidal prophet was a meal and a nap.

Psalms 103:14 NIV

for he knows how we are formed, he remembers that we are dust.

Then get real help. Doctors and counselors aren't outside of faith. They're how God still delivers bread and water. If the dark has lasted weeks, if you've gone numb and stayed there, if you've thought about ending your life, see a doctor and tell them all of it. If they write a prescription, fill it like insulin. You're repairing a gauge so it works. Scripture still holds the wheel.

If you're thinking about killing yourself tonight, put this book down and call somebody. A brother. Your pastor. If there's truly no one, dial 988. Someone will answer whose whole job is sitting with men in the dark. Elijah prayed to die and God served him breakfast. Let someone find you under your bush. Elijah didn't wait to feel better before going back to work. He went with a friend, in small steps, and his heart caught up later. Food. Rest. A brother. One small assigned thing. Stay there until things come back into range.

Before you turn the page

If your gauge has read dark for a long stretch, you have one job today: tell a man. If it hasn't, tell God the truth about your dash in a single sentence tomorrow morning, then take hold of the wheel. He knows how you were formed. He remembers you are dust. May He give your body rest and keep your tire in the furrow.

31 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

A reading you refuse to look at is still driving. Which ditch is yours, tape over the gauges or the needle on the wheel? Then put one word on today's dash: joy, fear, shame, anger, numbness, sadness, or loneliness.

DO THIS WEEK

A good driver checks his dash every morning, not only when smoke is coming out of the hood. Start each day with two lines to God: "Father, I'm feeling _," and "Here's what I'll do anyway: _." If it's been dark for weeks, book the doctor before Saturday.

TELL A BROTHER

Kept secret, a reading is what drives men off the road. Show him the full panel, including the ugly gauges. If you're sitting under the bush right now, call him today.

CARRY THIS

Your feelings read the engine. The Word drives the truck.



CHAPTER 32

Every Season Still Counts

Most of us carry a picture of a man's life we never chose. It's a hill: climb, stand on top a while, roll down toward a recliner. A divorce, a diagnosis, a wife's funeral all get treated as detours, things to get past so you can rejoin the hill. You won't find that hill anywhere in Scripture. David served God's purpose in his own generation, the one he was handed, not the one he'd have picked.

Now drive by a cotton field in February. It looks abandoned. Gray dirt, snapped stalks, a wire fence around nothing. Any farmer will tell you it's busy. The soil is resting while old stalks break down into it. Winter rain is working its way deep, down where roots will reach for it in August. February has a job. Plant out of impatience and you throw the year away.

Ecclesiastes 3:1 NIV

There is a time for everything, and a season for every activity under the heavens:

I promised near the start not to split this book by age on every page. Here I break that once, on purpose, because our culture puts the seasons of a man's life in rank order, and that ranking has stolen years from a lot of us.

Same marks, new ground

Passivity at twenty-five is a tailgate and a phone. At seventy-five it's a recliner and a remote. A young father stops waiting and gets up for the 2 a.m. bottle. A widower picks up the weight of a shovel and a bundle of bare-root pecans. The pay is the same in every season too: a son's inheritance, by grace, never wages. You work because you're already in the family.

The four marks hold in every season. Gardens change. Learn the motions once and your hands will find them again when the ground shifts. So let's walk the seasons: who from these pages stands in each, what God asks of you there, and what

tries to pull you off it.

Single, with time on your hands

Solomon wrote these words with white hair, looking back over everything he'd wasted and everything he hadn't.

Ecclesiastes 12:1 NIV

Remember your Creator in the days of your youth, before the days of trouble come and the years approach when you will say, "I find no pleasure in them" —

You're young, strong, and your evenings are your own, which can build a life or burn one. Micah sat six years at the back table, and he'll admit he spent half of them just waiting, for a wife, a career, somebody to say he'd arrived. Waiting-room thinking is one trap. The other one keeps quieter hours: free nights with nobody checking on you put a young man about as close to the edge as he'll ever stand.

So build. Meet the Father at twenty-four and you won't spend your fifties scanning bleachers for somebody's nod. Whoever you become right now gets handed to every later season. And hear me: marriage is good, but it isn't the starting gun for your life.

New husband, new dad

A wedding takes an afternoon. The plain weeks after it pour the floor you'll live on. Study her. Give up a few preferences. Ask what she needs instead of guessing. And keep your weekly time with your brother, or your wife ends up carrying what she was never built to carry alone.

Then a baby comes, and that first stretch breaks more young couples than anything else. Tomás had a four-month-old when you met him. A tiny person needs everything, and you both secretly assume it'll feel like this forever. It's a year. Protect the marriage inside the mess; after bedtime, ten minutes together at the counter is worship enough. There's no calmer season coming. Watch her for the postpartum dark, which has a name and a treatment. When the year was over, Tomás told me he'd learned he could still act like a man on no sleep, and his wife had learned she could lean on him.

Mid-career

Anthony lives here, frozen in the doorway between garage and kitchen. People call it the prime. Careers climb, homes slip, and the temptations wear a tie. Hiding

inside provision. Labeling drift as fatigue. A middle-aged itch once the marriage gets quiet.

What God wants here is a man who's present. A steady floor at home. A wife you keep learning, because she's changed, and the woman across the table deserves to be known as she is now. Brothers, because men in this stretch have the fewest friends of anyone. Hills with your kids. And a straight answer about what the work is for. This is where Work for God's Pay gets tested, when the office applauds and the family gets leftovers. Your kids are watching which way you turn in that doorway.

The season nobody plans

I've got one man in mind. He never wrote divorce on a calendar. This season has a job anyway, and it runs longer than anybody warns you.

Here's where it can go. Give it three to five years and the ground usually firms up. A real place to live, crayon drawings stuck to the fridge, and guys walking into the same fire start asking you to coffee. I can't promise another marriage. I can promise this stretch isn't wasted. The Father who never walks out sat in that courtroom with you, and He's still there.

Getting there is another matter. Early on, staying upright is the win. Grief ambushes you at custody handoffs and on Sunday nights. You're mad at everyone. Loneliness brings the itch with it. Everything in you wants to swerve: new town, new woman, new job, whatever makes it quiet. Don't. Steady and slow. Grieve within earshot of someone. Own your share and leave hers with her. Kids before any new relationship. One brother on the phone weekly. Keep walking into church even when church is awkward about you. That's the second Adam's road: cover your kids, own your part, refuse every exit. Men follow someone who came through.

When the house empties

Walt sold part of the company and started chasing his wife again, and he'll tell you it's been the best stretch they've had: the first time since '94 it's been only the two of them, and he's finally present for it. That's the move for this season.

Because the danger is real. The last kid drives off, and twenty years of dinner talk about the kids goes with them. Some couples settle into polite roommates. Some men drift into an affair. Overlooked at home and admired somewhere else is a bad combination. So pursue her, and then turn outward and hand some hills to younger men. If what emptied was a co-parenting schedule, these years are still yours, and

God still has work in them.

After the job ends

You already know how Roy spends his mornings. Biblical retirement isn't stopping. It's moving from hauling the load to helping others haul theirs. The temptations are aimless fishing trips and anger pumped in through a screen. Help instead. Mentor younger men. Clean a widow's gutters. Be there for the wife who's waited decades to have you around. Be like Caleb. At eighty-five he walked up to Joshua and asked for the roughest ground in Canaan.

Joshua 14:12 NIV

Now give me this hill country that the LORD promised me that day.

That's an old man who still figured he had work left. Roy put it to me plainly: thirty-one years keeping the peace, five years building men, and he knows which of the two he'll be asked about.

Burying her

God has a promise for old men, and Mr. Pruitt is living inside it.

Isaiah 46:4 NIV

Even to your old age and gray hairs I am he, I am he who will sustain you. I have made you and I will carry you; I will sustain you and I will rescue you.

Deuteronomy uses that carrying picture for a dad holding his small son. Here it's spoken over white hair. Fifty-one years married, and then a grave. The spring after, Mr. Pruitt put forty pecan trees in the ground, and the year of mourning before he picked up a shovel was part of the assignment too. Somebody not yet born will eat from those trees.

The lie in this season says your life went into the ground with hers. Mourn as long as it takes. Get yourself one brother; God called a man alone not good and never added an age limit. Then tend whatever garden you've got left.

When the body gives out

I know a man who can't leave his house. For eleven years he's prayed for every young man in his church, each by name. The young men know it. Give a man a chair and a prayer list and he can carry more weight in a congregation than the guy with the microphone.

Paul begged three times to lose his thorn. God said no, and told him strength shows up best in weakness. So if your body's quit on you, or you're the one caring for someone whose body has, you aren't finished. You remember Mr. Alvarez, bathing his wife every morning. He's been at it three years now. The lie here is that you're useless. The assignment is to help however you still can. That counts.

The final stretch

Paul's last letter came out of a cell, with the end close enough to see.

2 Timothy 4:7 NIV

I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith.

Men dodge this season. The Bible won't. Count your days. Live like someone who'll be asked how he finished. Say what you've been putting off. Bless your children from your bed, like Jacob. Pass the plumb bob along, story included. Every man in this book reaches that line. Practice the four marks in the seasons before it and the moves will already be in your hands.

There's no month off. February counts. The ground under your boots holds work that belongs to you, and the Father who set the seasons turning sees every bit of it.

Before you turn the page

Set the ranking down. It has cost men too many years. Whether you're nineteen or seventy-nine, may the Father who orders the seasons give you yours as a single plain sentence with an action in it, and may you look down and find the ground under you was meant for you all along.

32 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Nobody asked you to carry that ranking of life's seasons, and you've carried it anyway. Say which season you're in, or which two overlap right now. Then say the temptation you've been dressing up with a softer name.

DO THIS WEEK

Every season's assignment fits on one line. Write yours down with an action word in it. Stick it where your coffee will find it each morning, and get the first piece done by Sunday.

TELL A BROTHER

Somebody standing in different weather can spot what you're too close to spot. Say where you're standing and what it's asking, then let him do the same. Ask what he notices in your life that you keep missing.

CARRY THIS

February has a job. Your season has one too.



CHAPTER 33

What You Are Building When Nobody Claps

In July around here, concrete crews start pouring foundations at four in the morning. They have to. Pour at noon and the slab cures too fast and cracks. So they work under lights, screed and float in the dark, and by sunup they're gone. All that's left is a flat gray rectangle in the dirt.

Nobody photographs that. A family will live on it for thirty years without a thought. Kids will learn to walk on it. Couples will fight and make up on it. All of it sits on something poured while the neighborhood slept.

A man's life is mostly slab. Out of sight, holding up everything you can see.

Thirty years nobody filmed

Start with Jesus. He lived thirty years before anybody outside Nazareth knew His name, and Luke covers the whole stretch in a single verse.

Luke 2:51 NIV

Then he went down to Nazareth with them and was obedient to them. But his mother treasured all these things in her heart.

The Son of God spent His twenties sanding boards in a town people made jokes about. He did what Joseph and Mary told Him. No crowd. Then He waded into the Jordan, and the Father spoke out loud: this is my Son, whom I love. One sentence of praise from heaven, followed by three years of being doubted and a cross at the end. He never went hunting for a crowd to make up the difference. He'd been seen for thirty years by the only eyes that mattered. That was enough. It can be enough for you.

Your week, mostly unwatched

Think back over the last seven days. The 2 a.m. bottle. The hotel where you shut the laptop and went to sleep. The lunch you've packed for your wife every morning for eleven years. The true answer at work that cost you, when a lie would have been easy. Nobody clapped. Nobody's going to.

The world's answer is poison: if nobody saw it, it didn't happen. Scoreboards taught us that, and it's why men perform and drift toward whatever room is applauding. If you're single, almost nobody sees your evenings. If your job hands out applause on a schedule, home may be the only place nobody grades you. Either way, Jesus flatly disagreed with the scoreboard, more than once in the same sermon.

Matthew 6:6 NIV

But when you pray, go into your room, close the door and pray to your Father, who is unseen. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

Your Father sees in secret. In the hidden thing, nobody can mistake the crowd for your motive. It's just a son and his Father. This is Work for God's Pay with nothing else mixed in, and the pay is the Father's "well done" and a son's inheritance, never wages. You know who was in the room.

The fire

Paul looked ahead to the day every man's work gets inspected.

1 Corinthians 3:13 NIV

It will be revealed with fire, and the fire will test the quality of each person's work.

Everyone builds with something. Build for applause and you're building with straw. From the highway, straw can look better than gold, because straw is bright and gold just sits there being heavy. Then the fire hits, and everything done for an audience is ash in a second. What survives is what you did for the Father when nobody was looking. That four a.m. pour is gold. The 2 a.m. bottle is gold. A sermon preached to be admired is straw. So is a donation that buys a plaque. So is the dad who's all in at the ballpark and checked out by the time the truck hits the driveway.

The barn nobody remembers

Roy's grandson rides the school bus past a barn his great-grandfather raised. The barn's still up. Nobody on that bus can tell you who built it.

That's legacy: something still standing. Towns forget, churches call new pastors, grandkids move to Denver. Build to be remembered and you'll be disappointed. Build so something stands, and you get your barn.

After Roy turned in his badge, the hardest thing, he told me, was finding out how fast the people he'd served for thirty-one years had forgotten. Then it settled on him that it didn't matter. He'd told himself it was for them. It wasn't, really. It was his to do, and God was watching. Roy found Work for God's Pay at seventy. Someday Hollis's Thursday table will be forgotten too. The two men who sit at it will still be standing.

What's going up on your slab

A floor under your kids. They won't remember one regular dinner out of a thousand, but their bones will know whether somebody was steady.

A marriage still standing at seventy. Roy's has gone forty-four years, and it ran on coffee, not anniversaries. It got better once he retired and started making the coffee himself. When you meet an old couple who still like each other, you're looking at fifty years of pours in the dark.

A name that gets there before you do. Reputation is what people learn later about what you did unwatched. A boy's first inheritance is his father's last name. The credit a man gets at a feed store two counties over comes from forty years of bills paid on time that nobody else ever saw.

A church. It runs on men nobody thanks: the one stacking chairs, the one sitting with an old-timer in the hospital, the one who's taught fourth-grade boys for twenty-two years. The pastor gets the stage. The men who poured the floor under it are standing in the parking lot afterward, hands in their pockets, at peace.

A self. Men forget this one. Jesus said faithfulness in very little is how you get trusted with much, and the very little is the stuff nobody sees. Eli's hidden work this year was telling a customer the truth when a lie would have been free, and leaving his phone in the kitchen at night when nobody would have known.

And treasure in heaven, which is Jesus' name for where all of it went, kept by a Father who loses track of nothing.

When nothing shows

There's a stretch in hidden work when you can't see a thing. The slab's down and no house goes up for months. A year of packed lunches and she still feels far away. Eight months of weekly calls to your son, and his answer to "what's new" is still "nothing." And the thought shows up: every hour was wasted.

Isaiah 49:4 NIV

But I said, "I have labored in vain; I have spent my strength for nothing at all. Yet what is due me is in the LORD's hand, and my reward is with my God."

Isaiah's servant didn't pretend the weight away. He changed where he looked. Whatever is coming to him sits in God's hand, not in the results, and not with a teenage boy who says "nothing." Before the boy finally opened up, God had watched every one of the thirty-four calls. Paul says don't quit, because harvest comes in its season. Pecan season, not yours. Those trees of Mr. Pruitt's are knee-high. He'll never eat from them. It doesn't wear him down, because he never thought the pecans were his pay.

After the big days

You've had big days. A wedding. A baptism. A morning at a creek when you spoke a name over your son. A retirement plaque and a handshake. Those are stones on the riverbank. You live on the ordinary days after, where nobody claps and everything gets decided. So a man needs a rhythm under the moments people see.

Roy built his after the hardest marker of his life. He's still up at 5:30. The first hour goes to the Word, a chapter and a prayer that begins with "Father," before the phone gets touched. Then the floor, the family things that don't move, written where he'll see them. Twenty minutes with his brother in the same slot every week. One good thing done in secret. Before noon, a job somebody's counting on him for. A blessing, hand on a head, when there are kids in the house, and a call when they're grown and gone. A notebook with one line a day about something his wife said. At sundown he carries nothing to bed: the apology's made, the anger's handed to God. On Sunday he's in his Father's house as a man with a job there.

It shrinks to fit. Tomás has a four-month-old and ten-hour shifts. He gives the first fifteen minutes of the two-to-five feeding to a Psalm on his phone. His floor is twenty minutes after his boots come off and a prayer over the crib. At nine, dishwasher humming, he calls his brother. His secret good is letting his wife sleep an extra hour on Saturdays and never mentioning it. His sundown sounds like, "I'm so

tired I scare myself, and I'm sorry, and I'm staying." No slack in that life. The rhythm lives in the cracks.

Every-other-weekend dads, your card has its own lines. The hour before the kids wake up. The midweek call. The weekend you never trade.

So write the card. Five lines or ten. That card is your slab, and everything people see sits on it.

Hebrews 6:10 NIV

God is not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown him as you have helped his people and continue to help them.

He won't forget. So pour. Pack the lunch, make the call, and let your Father be the one who sees.

Before you turn the page

Long quiet grinds on a man, so let Isaiah's servant have the last word one more time: what's due me is in the Lord's hand. Keep your rhythm seven days and tell no one. May the Father who watched a carpenter's son in Nazareth watch your pour this week, and remember every day you kept.

33 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Work nobody sees can go sour and turn into a grudge. Write down three things you're building that no one notices. Then be honest: lately, have you been resenting the silence, or quietly working for an audience?

DO THIS WEEK

Big days only harden in the plain ones after. Put your rhythm on an index card, the handful of things that stay put, sized for your season. Keep it on the dash of the truck. Live it for seven days and don't mention it to anyone.

TELL A BROTHER

Nobody sees what he's pouring either, and every man needs one witness. Show him the card, and give him permission to ask next week how it went. Then ask what he's pouring in the dark, and tell him you see it.

CARRY THIS

The crowd gets straw. The Father gets the gold you pour in the dark.



CHAPTER 34

Write the Next Move

I was sitting on Hollis's porch when I asked him which line in his little notebook had been the hardest to cross off.

He didn't have to think long. "Probably 'Tell Cole he's a good man.' That sat on the page about three weeks. Finally I thought, if it isn't written down it isn't going to happen, and it was written down, so I'd better." He shrugged. "Took thirty seconds. He sat in his truck and cried for twenty minutes. I'd have put it off another year if I hadn't had to look at it every night."

The notebook rides in his shirt pocket, about the size of a deck of cards, and he's carried one since he was nineteen. Every night he writes tomorrow's first three jobs in it, in order. That afternoon's page read: fix gate latch, call Cole, read Proverbs 14. He's seventy-four. Fifty-five years of tomorrow, three lines at a time.

His reason fits on one of those pages too. "A man who knows what he's going to do tomorrow gets up and does it. A man who's going to figure it out in the morning figures out he'd rather have another cup of coffee."

If you close this book on a good feeling and nothing else, the feeling will be gone by Christmas. So before the cover shuts, put the next move on paper. Not every move. The next one.

Talking it out in the truck

Most of us can preach the whole year to ourselves on the drive home, twenty minutes of resolve with the radio off. Then we sit down at the kitchen table with a pen and the page stays blank, because talking to the windshield cost nothing and writing feels like signing something.

It is signing something. That's the point. God has a long habit of making His people write things down, and He told Habakkuk why.

Habakkuk 2:2 NIV

Write down the revelation and make it plain on tablets so that a herald may run with it.

Written. Plain. Clear enough that somebody else could pick it up and run. That leaves two ways to miss. One man never writes anything; he leaves the retreat with wet eyes, and by the first rough week the fire's out, because a thing that never touched paper never quite became real. The other man writes forty pages of mission statements and core values, and the binder suffocates in a drawer. A herald can't run with a binder.

A tablet, not a binder

When God wants something carried, the Bible's shape is small. One surface. Ordinary words.

Nehemiah rebuilt Jerusalem's wall in fifty-two days, after months of prayer. He rode the rubble at night until he knew every gap. He asked the king for exactly what the job required. He gave each family its own stretch of wall. And when his enemies kept inviting him down for a meeting, he already had his answer.

Nehemiah 6:3 NIV

"I am carrying on a great project and cannot go down. Why should the work stop while I leave it and go down to you?"

Once a plan is written, the work has a name and so do the distractions. You can say both out loud, and you can say no.

What goes on the page

One page holds it, or an index card if you write small. You've done most of the thinking already, at the end of every chapter.

At the top, in your own handwriting, write the sentence this book has been carrying.

A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Remember what that last word means. God's pay is the inheritance a Father keeps for His sons, by grace, not wages you earn your way in with. Now circle the mark that's faintest on you. Just one. The whole page leans toward it.

Under that, a single word for how you usually leave the room when it gets hard.

Anger, the itch, or the drift. You already know which.

Next, one sentence, with a verb in it, about the season you're actually in and what God has set in front of you there. A retired man might write that he'll walk alongside two younger men and his grandson this year. A man in his first year of being single again might write that he'll drive straight, drive slow, and call his kids every week.

Then a brother, by name, with a day and an hour. "Dale, Thursdays at noon, by phone." If there's no name yet, write "Ask somebody by Friday." That counts. It may be the most important line on the page.

Then the man further down the road. His name, and the first question you'll bring him. If you're the older one now, turn it around: his name, and what you plan to offer.

Then the rhythm: the handful of quiet things that hold your week together. Five, maybe ten. Not thirty.

Then the house. One move toward your wife, or toward the wife who isn't here yet. One toward each child, or toward a kid with no dad around if you don't have kids. If a son or daughter is nearing the line into grown-up life, a date on the calendar.

Then the work. One line. One man writes that the plant gets his whole heart, for the Lord. Another writes that his wife is going to hear the truth about his hours.

Then the drawer: the hidden thing, and the name of the Nathan who's going to hear it. Men skip this line more than any other. Leave it on the page.

And at the bottom, the move. One thing, this week, that everything above it is asking for. It's often small. "Ask Dale." "Phone sleeps in the kitchen tonight."

Sign it and date it. Men need markers. This page is one.

Verb, person, day

A goal is a place you'd like to end up. Closer to God. Gentler at home. Square with Dad. You can't do a goal on a Thursday. You can do a move.

A move has a verb, a person, and a day. Thursday, after the kids are down, ask your wife what she needs most from you right now. Sunday afternoon, call your father and thank him for one specific thing. Either it happened or it didn't. There's no other score.

Hollis has never written "become a good man" in that notebook. He's written

something like twenty thousand small moves, and the good man is what they add up to. Solomon saw the difference.

Proverbs 21:5 NIV

The plans of the diligent lead to profit as surely as haste leads to poverty.

Diligence isn't a Sunday word. It lives on weekdays.

Ways a page dies

I've watched a lot of these pages die, and they mostly go one of a few ways.

Too long. If you can't read it in the truck in ninety seconds, it's too long.

Kept secret. A plan in a drawer is a wish. Hand a copy to your brother and give him permission to ask.

No dates. "Soon" is fog. Thursday is a square on the calendar.

Born in a feeling and nowhere else. Retreat fire is a fine place to start, as long as you reread the page on some dull afternoon, keep what still stands, and cross out the rest.

Never looked at again. Every ninety days, you, your brother, and the page. What got done. What changed. What the move is now. Then a clean sheet.

And the one men miss: God left off the page.

James 4:15 NIV

Instead, you ought to say, "If it is the Lord's will, we will live and do this or that."

The whole page lives under that line. You hand it to Him, and He's allowed to edit. Held in an open hand, a plan is something He can use. Clutched in a fist, the same plan turns into an idol with bullet points.

Proverbs 16:9 NIV

In their hearts humans plan their course, but the LORD establishes their steps.

You plan. He sets the steps: which moves land, and when. Write it, pray over it, and let Him keep it.

Your season's page

A new baby in the house means a three-line page, and three lines is wisdom. Time at the counter with her. The night feeding you take. Nine o'clock, your brother on

the phone.

A man newly single again starts his first-year page with a rule: no detours. Under it, the floor. A weekly call to the kids. Their weekends, never traded away. The brother. Church, awkward room and all. Rebuilding is a year-two project.

An older man's page has room for lines a young man's can't carry yet. The hill he's asking God for. The younger man he's moving toward. The conversation with a grown child he keeps putting off, with a date written next to it. Roy's page said "Say it to my son on the porch" for two months. He finally said it, because it was written down, and because Hollis asked him about it every Thursday.

A man whose wife has died may have the shortest page of all. After she passed, Mr. Pruitt's first one said, in full, "Coffee with Ed Wednesdays. Trees."

Over the door

Near the end of his life, Joshua gathered the whole nation and made them choose who they'd serve. Then he told them his own answer, out loud.

Joshua 24:15 NIV

But as for me and my household, we will serve the LORD.

Men have carved that over their front doors for three thousand years. He didn't wait for a better season or for the feeling of readiness. He named his next move where witnesses could hear it and hold him to it.

Your page is that sentence in your own hand. Plain, dated, signed, read out loud to a brother, held loosely before God. Then you run with it.

Before you turn the page

Writing a move down will make you feel exposed, because now it can be checked. That exposure is a mercy. Once a brother has seen the page, your good intentions stop being a weight you carry by yourself. May the Father who sets a man's steps set yours before this week is out. Do the thing at the bottom of the page. Fifty-five years in, Hollis will tell you the next thing was always enough. It will be for you too.



Write the next move

Ink, not the windshield.

THE COURSE THAT SITS STILL

One sentence you would still own if a brother read it out loud.

THIS WEEK

The step, with a day on it.

The day: _____

Steadfast Men, The way of Godly Men

34 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

Once you know how your plans usually die, you can guard against it. Say which kind you've been, the man with the blank page or the man with the binder.

Then say the move that's already waiting at the bottom, with a verb, a person, and a day.

DO THIS WEEK

What never reaches paper never reaches Tuesday. Put the page on one sheet, ten lines at most, each one fitted to the season you're in. Sign it and date it. Get the bottom line done before the week runs out.

TELL A BROTHER

A herald runs only after somebody else has read the plan. Read him every line and give him a copy. Ask him to check on the bottom line next week and on the whole page in ninety days. If he's writing one too, swap.

CARRY THIS

*Paper makes a plan real: a verb, a person, a day. You plan the course.
The LORD sets the steps.*



CHAPTER 35

These Men Are My Brothers

Overcast today, a breeze, nothing on the calendar, the kind of day nobody's journal remembers. That's why I chose it. Before I let you go, I want you to know what became of the men you've met in these pages.

None of this is meant to wow you. They aren't famous. You'd stand behind any of them in line at a gas station and never give him a second glance. That's my whole case: the four marks were made for plain men on plain days, in every season, and I've seen them hold.

Born for a hard day

I've used the word brother since the first page, and I've meant it. These men and I are in the same work. We've said hard, true things over coffee, in truck cabs, on nine o'clock phone calls. We've walked fence before sunup, prayed over each other's boys, stood at gravesides, rocked newborns, and dialed each other with nothing useful to say. Solomon put the whole thing in one proverb.

Proverbs 17:17 NIV

A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for a time of adversity.

That's no hunting buddy, and it's not a name buried somewhere in your phone. A brother is the man who picks up. Every man below has one now, and most had none the day I met them. Of everything that changed them, that changed them most.

Where they are tonight

Mr. Alvarez bathed his wife this morning. Her mind has let go of his name. He hasn't let go of hers. He promised "in sickness" in 1968, and he's keeping all of it.

Mr. Pruitt, seventy-six, has pecans above his knee now. Ed still comes for coffee

every Wednesday, as he has for four years, the best twenty minutes of the old man's week. He won't live to eat from those trees. No man in the county is more at rest.

Hollis, seventy-four, wrote tomorrow's three things before bed. One reads "Call Roy re: roof."

Cole is thirty-seven and done waiting. Every night his hand rests on his boy's head for a short blessing and the boy's name. Sunday he and his dad stood over a well pump at the home place and barely spoke. That silence is the nearest his father gets to a hug, and Cole took it.

Anthony made it into the kitchen tonight. His daughter glanced up from her homework to read his face when her mom came in, and his face got it right. He still prays "Father" in the truck each morning, and the word still feels clumsy.

Walt was home for supper. Part of the business is sold, a fall trip is booked, her pick, and he's chasing his wife again. He has a brother now. At 6:15 the shop is still quieter than the house, and he locks up anyway.

Micah's married. A younger couple ate at their table tonight. Dale still buys him breakfast every other week, and a twenty-four-year-old gets Micah's Thursdays. Micah wrote the date in his Bible the day an older man told him to stop living like a guest in his own place.

Kenny's kids are with their mom this week. It's Tuesday, though, so at 7:30 he called his son and got twenty minutes on the smoker they built over eleven weekends. Three years back Kenny was a ghost in a one-bedroom apartment, until an older man called every week for a year and actually waited to hear how he was. Now divorced men at church seek Kenny out. What he thought disqualified him is what God is using.

Tomás, twenty-nine, walked his two-year-old around the block at six. His wife slept five straight hours because he took first shift. They learned trust in their worst year. Most days he doesn't feel like a man. He is one.

And Roy, seventy-two. Coffee at 5:30, the porch, his wife telling her dream, a chapter of Proverbs read aloud. Then off to look at a church roof leak nobody asked him about. Five years ago he turned in his badge and thought he was finished. He'll tell you these five years mattered most. Nobody's clapped once.

What they share

Go back over that list. Single, married, divorced, widowed. A crib in one house, an empty bedroom in another. Retired. Sick. You won't find a remarkable man in the bunch, which is my point. Each of them, in his season, on his ordinary days, is living the four marks.

Nobody's sitting on the tailgate. Roy hunts up work. Tomás leaned into his marriage in the middle of the mess. Walt let trucks go so he could make supper, and Mr. Alvarez carries a load nobody would blame him for setting down. Anthony led with the apology. Hollis finally told Cole he's a good man, and Cole sat in his truck and cried. And every one of them is working for an audience of One, the Father who sees in secret. That's Work for God's Pay, and it's what keeps the rest standing. Not one of them is trying to earn heaven.

Psalm 112:7 NIV

They will have no fear of bad news; their hearts are steadfast, trusting in the LORD.

That word is the title of this book. Steadfast, on a man, is a heart lashed to something that won't shift. Bad news lands and he holds together. He reads the gauge, tells God and his brother the truth, and grips the wheel again.

The door's open

Nobody here showed up finished, and this was never a club for men who have it handled. Walt came from a shop that was quieter than his house, Roy from a recliner, Anthony from a doorway, Kenny from an apartment where he'd been haunting his own life. Someone asked, or they finally asked. The door stood open for each of them. It's open for you.

Hebrews 10:24 NIV

And let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deeds,

Spurring takes somebody close enough to reach you, and a crowd never is. If you've read this far, named your thing, taken the step, and opened your mouth to a brother, you're in this company whether we ever meet. Behind us, a garden. Ahead, a table still waiting on its plates. Plain men, made steadfast, held together by the same four marks.

Tomorrow is ordinary

Your life won't be settled at an altar, on a creek bank, or on the last page of a book. It'll be settled on days like this one, overcast and breezy, nobody watching, nothing seemingly riding on it.

Tomorrow will be another. A smoke alarm with a dying battery is chirping in somebody's hallway, maybe yours. Your wife wants to be known. Your kid needs a name and a hill to climb. Your own dad is waiting on a call. Some man you know needs you to ask. And the Father is standing out on the road, watching for you to come over the rise. You know what to do. What's left is getting up and doing it.

Once more

Once more, and then I'll step aside. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Those four show up on a man like the callus a fence stretcher leaves on an old rancher's hand. Nobody grows them by gritting his teeth. They're the family resemblance, and it comes from the Son who already did everything this book has asked of you, and did it for you. Live even one of them on a plain day and somebody is going to notice the likeness.

You will fall. What matters is whose man you're standing in, the first Adam's or the second's. Stand in the second and there's one question left, which is tomorrow morning. Get up. Turn back toward a Father who has never once walked off. Then do it again, until the word you hear is "well done."

1 Corinthians 15:58 NIV

Therefore, my dear brothers and sisters, stand firm. Let nothing move you. Always give yourselves fully to the work of the Lord, because you know that your labor in the Lord is not in vain.

Not in vain. He saw every slab, every pot of coffee, every call, every pecan tree. It's held with Him and won't fade, because what He's keeping for you is a son's inheritance, not a laborer's wage.

The open chair

Israel's priests didn't send people home without a word from God over them. Neither will I.

Numbers 6:24-26 NIV

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face shine on you and be gracious to you; the LORD turn his face toward you and give you peace."

Keep was Adam's second job in the garden, guarding the ground he'd been handed. Here the word turns around and lands on the man: the One he answers to is guarding him. So work your ground, and keep it. These men are my brothers. There's an open chair at the table. Pull it out and sit.

Before you close the book

You've made it to the end, with a written page, a man you asked, and one mark already in your hands. The Father who watches in secret missed none of it. May He guard you the way He told Adam to guard Eden. May His face shine on your plain days. And when we finally sit down at a table still unset, may you discover you had brothers all along.

35 · YOUR TURN

NAME IT

You need to know your ground and the man you're walking toward. Say it aloud: which man in this chapter looks most like you right now, and which one are you turning into? Then name your season once more, like a pasture you could walk blindfolded.

DO THIS WEEK

A plan that never gets lived leaves blank the one page that counts. Do the bottom line on your page. Then, before the week ends, read the four marks slowly and hang your week against them like a plumb line on a fresh wall.

BE A BROTHER

Somebody has to make the first move, or this company never grows. You've spent the book telling a brother. Now be one. Look around church, the job site, your street, for the man standing where you stood. Ask if he'd be willing to talk twenty minutes a week. And when he calls, pick up.

CARRY THIS

Tuesday is when it will show. Get up.

About the Author

Wes Hart writes for ordinary men who are done waiting for a better season before they start living like men.

He is a husband, a father of two, and a Texan. By day he leads teams in technology. The hours that matter most to him are spent across a table from other men: kitchen tables, garage chairs, church classrooms, and early weekday diners with a Bible and a cup of coffee. Steadfast Men, the twenty-four-week training behind this book, began at one of those tables with a few skeptical guys. It has since been taught in living rooms, garages, church basements, and online, to men in every season: single and married, young and older, still standing and starting over.

Wes did not set out to write a book or to build a men's program. He set out to stop being the passive husband and distracted dad he had quietly become. A few older men kept a chair for him when he had nothing worth setting on the table. Years later he started keeping chairs for other men. He is not a pastor and he is not a counselor, and he will tell you so before you ask. He is a layman who believes ordinary men, walking together under the Word of God, can become the husbands, fathers, brothers, and leaders their homes and churches are hungry for. He has watched it happen too many times to treat it as a theory.

When he is not working or teaching, he is usually outside with his kids, on a long walk with his wife, or sitting with one other man who is trying to get honest about his Tuesday.

He and his family live in Texas.

Learn more, find the full twenty-four-week class, or bring Steadfast Men to your church or group at walksteadfast.com.

Condensed Training

The chapters you just finished are the book. What follows is a short map of the first twenty-four weeks of the class, not an index of every chapter.

Each class week works through one chapter, now and then a close pair, with a video teaching, a leader guide, and a participant sheet. The closer never changes. Name it. Do this week. Tell a brother. Carry this.

If you're already in a group and want the outline on paper, use this page as a quick agenda. For the printable packets, the host scripts, and the full week-by-week order, including the weeks that cover the rest of the book, get the class guide at walksteadfast.com.

Class weeks 1-24 (condensed)

1. A Quiet Tuesday
2. You Are Not Crazy
3. The Four Marks
4. Stop Waiting
5. Pick Up the Weight
6. Go First
7. Work for God's Pay
8. The Empty Chair
9. Anger, the Itch, and the Drift
10. The Father Who Does Not Leave
11. When Home Never Handed You Off
12. Leave Without Slamming the Door
13. A Man With No Brothers
14. Ask the Man
15. The Problem Inside
16. How That Looks on a Man
17. No Fixed Star
18. Before the Fall
19. Two Men, Two Ways
20. Destiny Is Not a Vibe

21. If There Is No Wife Yet
22. Know Her
23. Lay It Down
24. What She Actually Needs

Also in this book

These chapters carry on past the first twenty-four class weeks. They're part of the book you just read, and the full class maps them on the site.

- The Bed Is a Covenant
- Your Daughter Is Watching
- Give Your Son a Name
- Give Your Son a Hill
- Give Your Son a Day He Will Not Forget
- You Were Made for a Work
- Feelings Are the Dash, Not the Wheel
- Every Season Still Counts
- What You Are Building When Nobody Claps
- Write the Next Move
- These Men Are My Brothers

Don't binge it. One week. One job. Then come back.

Still waiting for a better season?

Plenty of good men are. The kids get older, the job gets bigger, and the man you meant to be keeps getting moved to next year. This book says start on the Tuesday in front of you.

INSIDE

- Four marks you can see on a man, and how to build each one
- Straight talk on fathers, anger, marriage, and kids
- Help for every season of a man's life
- One thing to do each week, and a brother to tell

A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

God's pay is a Father's inheritance, not wages.

